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ようこそ実力至上主義の教室へ2年生編
Welcome to the Classroom of the Second-year
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Classroom of the Elite - Second Year, Volume 6

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EPUB Version 1.0 (11/5/22) | Compilation & markup editing by *Christmas Cavalier*

Converted to PDF by *Candle*

「下着に釘付けになって、
エッチなんですから先輩」

**「悪いが下着を見ていることよりも、
視線を外して何をされるかの方を警戒してるんだ」**

オレが天沢から目を離さないでいると、
ベッドから顔を抜き出し振り返った。
1年後輩とは思えない大人びた雰囲気をまとった天沢が、
そのまま這ってオレに近づいてくる。

体育祭　～バレー競技～

坂柳有栖（さかやなぎ ありす）


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Welcome to the Classroom of the Second-year

Prologue

I've never once thought of myself as a special person.

While I had no special talents, lacking any particular faults either made me just an average person.

I've been kinda coasting through life up until now, just doing whatever I liked.

I did a few bad things from time to time, and I also did a few kind things, in my own way.

I'm not a good guy, and I'm not a bad guy either. If I had to evaluate myself, then that's the kinda guy I am.

Ever since I was born, I've kept walking as someone who was neither of those things.

It was after I started high school that that became apparent.

Even archery I only took up because I saw it randomly on TV and thought I'd try it to kill time.

I was just moving through my ordinary life, like I was letting the currents carry me.

Not caring about the big things, it was the kind of day-to-day life where I'd always keep a reasonable distance.

It might've been a boring daily life, but I thought it would be easier so I kept it up.

Maybe it was a consequence of that, but I didn't make any real friends in high school.

It wasn't like I was lonely, but… out of the blue, that kind of me ended up making a few friends.

Keisei, Kiyotaka, Haruka, Airi.

It might've been just five of us including me, but in fact, that small group felt strangely comfortable.

I had a hunch that I'd be spending the rest of my school life relaxing in this group of five.

Even if my surroundings had changed, I was still me. I thought that alone would never change.

Despite those feelings, one major change did take place.

That was that I would fall in love with someone.

There'd been times when I'd thought a girl was cute or beautiful, but I'd never fallen in love with one.

When did it start, I wonder?

When did I start gazing at Haruka?

And then, I was convinced of it when, during the Unanimous Consent Special Exam, Haruka said she would drop out of school.

There was a part of me that couldn't accept that we would be separated.

Instead of logic, my emotions took top priority.

I thought that, even if it meant abandoning Airi, a member of the group I cared about just as much, I wanted to protect her.

I don’t know if I could be forgiven for having those feelings.

Instead of weighing up what was right and wrong based on merit, I gave preference to what I wanted to protect.

But I have no regrets.

“Will you join me in my revenge?”

That murmur pulled me back to reality. Her eyes looking at me were the same as ever.

They were strong, straightforward, and had a dangerous glint.

But they showed that she was determined without any turbulence or hesitation.

I didn’t answer her question aloud. No, I *couldn’t*.

I’m almost certain that revenge would trouble a lot of my friends and classmates.

She must’ve seen through my emotions, as she laughed, turned her back and walked away by herself.

If it was the me of the past, I surely would’ve sent her off without caring.

Sending her off was the right thing to do.

Right, if I watch that back leave, just how easy would it be?

I had no idea that falling in love with someone was so troublesome, so difficult, so much of a nuisance.

I…

Down the road, no matter how many people will hate me…

My feelings won’t allow me to let her go alone.

On this day at the end of the sports festival, I—steeled my nonexistent resolve.

Chapter 1

Introduction

With the Unanimous Consent Special Exam and the weekend behind us, it was 20th September, the start of the next week.

I woke up around 6:30, turned on the TV and started preparing my breakfast.

Yet another Monday had come, but the daily life that awaited was certainly going to be different from what it had been until just last week.

You didn't have to rack your brain to figure out why.

Broadly speaking, there were two major causes affecting us. Kushida's explosive revelations after she had been cornered created cracks in the relationships between the students of our class. Then, the fact that we had gone back on the initial condition – which was to expel only the traitor, that is, Kushida – had shaken the class's trust in Horikita and me.

The question was: should we expel someone or not? To make everyone change their votes to assent, I had promised them that we would only expel the traitor. Then, I executed my plan to use what I had prepared so far to drive Kushida into a corner, make her confess that she was the traitor and therefore lead her to expulsion.

While there were students defending her because they liked her or wanted to believe in her, in the end she showed her true colors and started exposing the class's secrets, and so their trust in her collapsed.

And when I was just one step away from driving her to expulsion, something I hadn't expected happened.

Despite the fact that she was well aware of everything, Horikita Suzune claimed that Kushida was an essential resource for the class.

Most importantly, she declared that she would absolutely not agree to expel Kushida.

I had initially promised that only the traitor would be expelled, and Horikita had nothing but agreed to it, and yet to my surprise she defended Kushida.

In the little time we had left, the only options we had were to either let Kushida remain and eat the penalty for failing the exam, or to pass the exam by expelling someone else.

At any rate, the class lost a lot of trust in both Horikita – who, as I just mentioned, changed the rules – and me, who went along with her and stuck the expulsion on someone else.

Those who were hurt by having their fleeting love exposed to the world.

Those who were left distrustful of everybody after they heard how their friends had bad mouthed them.

Those who had lost their friends or now bore a grudge against them.

The situation in the class was serious, and there was no end to the causes for it.

But, the revelations and their consequences weren't a big concern, and I had anticipated that from the very beginning. It was a necessary and unavoidable cost of breaking the ball of trust known as Kushida.

It would be easy to think of this as an absolute negative for the class.

However, that is not how I see it. If you took that view, you could not gain experience. It was equivalent to missing out on an opportunity to grow.

Of the four classes, we were the only ones to expel someone. The students of our class were deeply hurt. In turn, we gained class points. No. It is very important for us to change that perspective of this situation.

Instead of thinking that we were hurt and leaving it there, we should consider the future. It was because we were hurt that we must consider it as an opportunity to make our bonds even stronger. By doing that, Horikita's class could become even stronger.

How many of the students of the class understood this was unclear, but regardless, they mustn't run away from it, and face this problem head on.

The special exam for Horikita's class was still going on.

The weight and value of 100 Class Points. It was the perfect chance to reflect on one's own actions.

Of course, if things were left as they were, there was the possibility that the class could get mired in a swamp, so we had to be careful. With neglect, the wounds could expand further.

After breakfast, I checked my phone with one hand while brushing my teeth. Looks like there weren't any new messages from when I'd last checked at midnight.

"But, still──"

The result of the exam wasn't what I had originally planned, and I was still surprised by the unexpected direction the exam went into. Logically, objectively, consistently, or from any other such perspective, there should not have been any choice other than to expel Kushida, who had doggedly stuck to her assent vote and thrown the class into disarray. I had determined that expelling her would have caused the least damage to the class, and we could quickly shift focus to the Sports Festival. Basically, from my point of view, the position Horikita chose – to not allow the traitor Kushida Kikyou to get expelled – was impossible, irrational and wrong.

And despite thinking of it as an obvious blunder, I supported Horikita, and changed course to expel Airi. In short, I chose to lend my abilities to an illogical mistake. At the very least, I would have never made that choice before I came to this school.

So, why did I choose it now?

The student known as Horikita Suzune was, in a way, far more attached to Kushida than the other students.

While it wouldn't be right to call them close friends, it was undeniable that to Horikita, Kushida was a special person. Wanting to keep someone special to you from being expelled was natural, but making judgements based on that would be unfair.

Especially as it could be seen as an abuse of the position of leadership that she was establishing herself in.

Considering, for example, the viewpoint of Haruka, a close friend of Airi, would make this easy to understand.

To Haruka, the person who had kept voting to expel someone – Kushida – was evil, and should have been eliminated. And Horikita and I had made eliminating that evil as the premise of going forward. That was why she also added her vote to expel someone.

And yet, she had to pay the price for Horikita's preference of Kushida, with a close friend of hers getting expelled. After that, if you said "Let's do our best from next week!" she would absolutely not be on board.

However, we mustn't forget that it wasn't an easy choice for Horikita to make either. During the special exam where she was forced into making a difficult decision, Horikita had made her response clear. She declared her support for Kushida and took on the risk of criticism it carried.

Just that decision would have been impossible for most normal students to make. Knowing full well that she would be held in contempt for favoritism,

Horikita still believed that keeping Kushida would benefit the class.

“I’d still be hard pressed to say that it was the right choice at this stage though.”

Before the Unanimous Consent Special Exam was held, it was obvious that Kushida brought more to the class than Airi. You could say that, even after she exploded, she still had the lead over Airi, but at the very least that lead was certainly shrinking. On top of that, Kushida herself didn’t seem to repent, and it was likely that she would continue to be uncooperative with the class.

In short, at that point there was absolutely no basis for the idea that keeping Kushida would benefit the class. Horikita’s beliefs regarding the way Kushida would develop were wrong. That conclusion alone will not change.

There is only one reason why I supported Horikita despite that. To be perfectly honest, it was because I wanted to watch Horikita’s growth, the direction she was developing in and where it would lead to.

Actions that the person known as Ayanokouji Kiyotaka would never take, what could they lead to?

I wanted to see the chemical reaction that would happen by leaving Kushida in the class.

Would they be able to narrowly grab hold of Class A, proving that this choice was correct?

Or would it destroy the class, and they would understand their mistake?

Or would it lead to yet another unexpected change?

As for me, I thought it was very likely that it would lead to a vicious cycle, but…

I checked the OAA app on my phone, and Sakura Airi's name was already gone from the list of students in our class. It was as if such a student had never existed.

I put my phone in my right pocket, took my bag and went to the entrance.

Apart from the situation in our class, there were happenings in the other classes that piqued my interest.

Ryuuen and Sakayanagi chose to challenge each other in the end of the year exam. It was natural for Ryuuen to choose Class A and steal their points, but Sakayanagi? There was nothing in it for her to challenge what was the bottom ranked class at the time. Was it because she was allied with Ichinose, and had decided that destroying Ryuuen was the best course of action?

Was the promise between Sakayanagi and Ryuuen also a factor?

It was best for us to keep our guard in that direction, too.

This was the best possible outcome for Horikita's class, but…

At my usual time, I left my room and moved to exit the dorm.

In the lobby outside the elevator, the familiar form of Horikita was on the sofa, waiting for somebody. She glanced at me, but it didn't seem like she was going to get up.

However, perhaps because there was nobody around, after a brief delay, she got up and approached me.

"Are you waiting for Kushida?"

Before she could speak, I opened with that. She choked for a moment and replied,

"Looks like you saw through me. Yes. Over the weekend, I went to her room many times, but…"

It seemed like she was trying to counsel Kushida, but hadn't been able to make contact yet. That was probably because for Kushida, it must've been the humiliation of a lifetime. Of course she wouldn't want to see Horikita so soon after. Probably, Horikita might have been waiting here from very early in the morning for Kushida to come down.

More concerning was that the dark circles under Horikita's eyes made it easy to tell that she was not getting enough sleep.

"It looks like you're quite worried about the situation with Kushida."

"Eh? Ahh, it's not like that. My lack of sleep aside, this is for a different reason. She hasn't left her room even once. I visited her many times but she kept pretending she wasn't there. She has really holed up in there. Despite that, I wanted to meet her no matter what, so I stuck it out but…"

"She's holed up in there… you mean, you've been waiting by her door?"

Even if it was just for the weekend, sticking it out from dawn to dusk was something, alright.

"I kept ringing her doorbell and waiting for her, but she didn't even make a sound."

It wouldn't have been surprising for Kushida to store enough food in her room to sit tight for two to three days.

"And I had to be careful about my surroundings, right? It wouldn't help us if the other classes found out that Kushida-san wasn't leaving her room."

She had to be on her guard, watching out for someone coming down the hallway. It must have been a rough weekend for her.

An ordinary student would probably lose to Horikita's intensity, but Kushida was Kushida. She didn't even show the slightest bit of sympathy and rode it out.

“After all that happened the other day, she can’t carry on as she did before.”

“Since you made the choice to keep Kushida, it’s obvious that you need to follow up on it.”

Horikita nodded with determination, but it wasn’t like she didn’t have her own thoughts about it.

“As for you… how was the weekend, Ayanokouji-kun?”

Of course, by that she was asking about the Ayanokouji group. Since I had selected Airi by name and then expelled her, from Horikita’s perspective, it was likely to cause more issues for me than keeping Kushida.

“I had some contact with Keisei and Akito, but that’s about it.”

Even then, our conversations were never specifically about Airi. It wasn’t that they couldn’t broach the topic, but that they didn’t know how to. As for Haruka, I couldn’t see her “read” indicator on any of my messages. I don’t know much about how the app worked, but she definitely could have blocked me or something without leaving the group.

“You haven’t been able to talk to Hasebe-san yet, right?”

“Well, yes. Naturally, I haven’t had the courage to send her a message.”

Horikita gave me an apologetic look and bowed her head.

A face to face confrontation right now wouldn’t bridge the gap. Instead of trying to repair our relationships, it was more realistic for them to leave me and keep the group alive with just the three of them. Therefore, the best option for me was to watch over them from a distance. That way, Haruka might still resent me, but that might thaw over time.

If that comes to pass it would be good for the class, but if it doesn’t, we have to be prepared for it. If she keeps resenting me, Horikita and the class, it would be difficult to rule out the possibility that Haruka could harm the

class due to her personal circumstances. While her abilities weren't in any way indispensable to the class, losing a perfectly usable piece would, in a way, disadvantage the class and bring its total value down. It could also spread to Akito and Keisei and drag their abilities down with her.

"Right now, I suppose whatever you try to tell her won't get through. It's best to wait."

At any rate, this wasn't something we could discuss here.

After we were done checking in on each other, Horikita sighed quietly.

"Because I forced us to keep Kushida-san, your group's relationship was changed."

I was the one who struck the killing blow on Airi, but I did that of my own volition. At the very least, that was entirely on me.

"You don't need to apologize again for the same thing. If you thought that was the right thing to do, I'm fine with that."

"But you covered for me. No, it wasn't just that…"

As if she was trying to get her head in order, she carefully chose her words.

"In that situation, if I had been the one to propose Sakura-san's expulsion, Hasebe-san definitely wouldn't have compromised even at the very end. Therefore, we wouldn't have been able to avoid the penalty from running the clock out."

After cooling down over the weekend she was able to see the situation clearly. The weight of the burden of sentencing someone to expulsion, and the difficulty of executing it. It was an unimaginably rough battle given the time limit.

While she was relieved that we had avoided the worst case scenario, I could see a sense of discomfort in her eyes.

More than a little, she wished we had been saved from expelling someone by the clock running out. A world where none of the 39 were missing. The "what if" where we might have lost class points, but because we had protected our friends we could deepen our bonds and aim for Class A.

Horikita herself knew that these thoughts were those of a coward. And that is why, as those thoughts bubbled up from inside her, she suppressed them.

"I feel like you were able to understand everything about that special exam from the very beginning."

"It's not like I saw the future. I just considered every possibility and planned for them."

"That itself is incredible. I can visualize the future to some extent, but I cannot perfectly figure everything out. The contents of the motions, what you needed to say to make people act the way you wanted them to – it all turned out the way you had calculated."

Little by little, she was beginning to realize how I saw and thought about the world.

"It's good to analyze the past, but right now I think we need to solve the class's problems first, don't you?"

"Y-Yes. That's right…"

"You shouldn't expect the class to be the same as it was until just recently."

"Of course I am aware of that. There is no doubt that Hasebe-san resents me, and Yukimura-kun and Miyake-kun might too. And there are some who don't agree with how I forced us to keep Kushida-san."

She says she's aware of it, but I'd be hard pressed to say she truly understands what it will be like. How long would it be peaceful under the changes that her decision would lead to? If those would just be positive changes I wouldn't mind, but most of them would be just the opposite –

they would be negative changes. There was no way they'd see her as a high achiever who increased our class points.

"You should head to school."

Horikita had her hands full dealing with Kushida, so there was no point to having a long discussion here.

"It won't be good if we stand out carelessly."

After all, this wasn't a dorm that only had students from Horikita's class. People from classes we could call our enemies – Sakayanagi's and Ryuuen's – also lived here just like us.

She wasn't thinking that we could hold the lid on Kushida's true nature, but that didn't mean we had to open ourselves to attack by telling the world about it.

The class had certainly acquired a lot of points. Whether they were able to deal with the cost of those points or not depended on what they did in the future.

But, before all that──

What should I do about the biggest problem I immediately saw with regards to fixing the class?

1

When I entered the classroom, the difference in the atmosphere was immediately apparent, as I'd expected.

First, a few students turned to look at me. Of them, a considerable portion were students I wasn't usually very friendly with. However, that wasn't surprising at all.

That was because for someone who used to observe quietly from the sidelines, I had come off as being very involved. My relationship with Kushida, the way I used to behave in public – there were many things that didn't fit.

Even if they were curious, none of them came to talk to me directly.

"Good morning, Ayanokouji-kun!"

Through all that, Matsushita spotted me and approached me happily.

"Morning."

Both the boys and the girls of the class looked in surprise at this unexpected occurrence.

In the past, Matsushita might have waved at me from a distance, but this was probably the first time she called out to me just for showing up to class. Was she just being considerate after what happened the other day, or did she have some other objective?

Matsushita rates my abilities highly. My attempt to expel Kushida and the ensuing struggle wouldn't have lowered her opinion of me – it was more likely that it improved it instead. Even after the turn of events that led to

Airi's expulsion, Matsushita was one of the students who spoke up in assent and claimed it was unavoidable.

"So, at long last you've started working towards rising to Class A?"

"I wonder."

I dodged her verbal jab. Maybe she didn't think it was necessary to, but she didn't push it further. Then, she turned just her eyes to the side.

"There might be a lot going on for a while, but I don't think you need to worry about it."

She immediately followed up with,

"Although, considering it's you, you probably aren't worried at all."

She let both her pretense and inner thoughts out.

"The important thing here isn't you or Horikita-san, right?"

Matsushita had understood… or perhaps more accurately, interpreted my state of mind with respect to containing the impact of the special exam better than Horikita had.

The problem was with Shinohara and Haruka, and Mii-chan and Kushida. These were the people who had in particular suffered a lot of damage in the Unanimous Consent Special Exam.

I could see Shinohara's glare jabbing in our direction from time to time. It wasn't directed at me – it was for Matsushita. The target herself didn't seem to care, however.

"This weekend, I'd made a bunch of arrangements, but she canceled all of a sudden." She mumbled quietly after she noticed Shinohara looking at her. "Girls tend to hold on to things like that for long."

"Sounds like a pain."

“Well, it’s our fault, though.”

It all started with Kei, Matsushita and the others making fun of Ike and Shinohara as a couple. They’d been making fun of her appearance behind her back, so it was natural for Shinohara to get mad at them.

“This sort of thing is like an everyday affair for us. I’ve faced more troublesome situations before this too.”

Boys who only had superficial relationships with girls couldn’t ever know about this side of their relationships with other girls. Part of me wanted to find out, but part of me didn’t.

Nobody called out to me after her, so I just let the time pass.

Horikita arrived to class late, but Kushida wasn’t with her. Sudou and a few other students tried to speak to her, but she had arrived just in time with the bell going off shortly after, so they returned to their seats.

Horikita had not been able to see Kushida over the weekend, and it looked like Kushida would continue hiding. Homeroom started with her and a few other students notably missing. On her arrival in class, even Chabashira-sensei caught on to the empty seats.

“Kushida, Hasebe and Wan – three students are absent. That’s unusual.”

We weren’t aware of the reason behind those absences, but Chabashira was different.

“Hasebe and Wan have both called in sick, and I’ve accepted their leaves. I haven’t heard from Kushida, so I’ll call her afterwards to check. I’ll quickly find out if she just overslept, or if she was so sick she couldn’t wake up.”

She threw in an extremely exaggerated possibility, but it was because she knew that Kushida was almost definitely feigning sickness.

Over the course of our long school lives it wouldn't be unusual to see someone absent from class. However, this was the first time in our year and half here that three students were absent at the same time. So far, Chabashira had never said anything even if students were absent. This was different from her usual hands-off way of dealing with absences.

If this was an ordinary school, the cost of your absences would only be borne by you. If you played hooky for a week, your grades would suffer, and the course material would leave you behind. But in this school, everyone was responsible for everyone else.

Nobody said it out loud, but even Chabashira could tell what was on their minds.

"Don't look so anxious. A day or two of absences won't hurt your class points. After all, it is entirely possible that three people just happened to fall sick at the same time."

She declared that the class wouldn't be affected at this point. I'm sure that her clear and unambiguous words heartened the class.

"That said, that won't hold if their absences continue. Especially if it turns out that they're feigning illness – little by little, problems will start to surface."

She looked at Kushida's empty seat as she said that. Kushida was the only one who hadn't informed her.

"Maybe calling it a pretend illness is too much. All I'm saying is, there's a limit to how long you can be ill without giving us the specific name of your sickness. I'd like to see them recover as soon as possible."

Many looked at Horikita with anger. In the Unanimous Consent Special Exam, she prioritized her preferences and retained Kushida in the class. Naturally, most of the pitchforks were pointed at her. Horikita did not move even a bit under the force of those pitchforks… or, to put it simply, those

looks. Showing weakness at this point wouldn't do, even if we couldn't tell what she was thinking internally.

Chabashira-sensei saw the situation in the class and cleared her throat to peel the class's attention from Horikita.

"While their absence is concerning, we can't get stuck on that. The Unanimous Consent Special Exam is now over, and all of you have to turn and face the next challenge."

She lightly tapped the monitor behind her with her palm to wake the display.

"I'm going to explain the details of the Sports Festival, and the special rules in play this year. Listen carefully."

The students had all assumed that the Sports Festival that was waiting for us would be the same as it was last year and the years before.

"Special rules… are you saying the Sports Festival will be different this year, sensei?"

Sudou was more fired up for the Sports Festival than anyone else, and Chabashira nodded curtly in response to his question.

"The new way for this school that the Student Council President has been proposing is being accepted, such as with the Uninhabited Island Exam. This Sports Festival will be a realization of his experiment, and will heavily incorporate his proposal to emphasize individual ability."

In the Uninhabited Island Exam, Koenji's excellent academics and above all his superlative physical skills made him hugely successful. He won us class points, and on top of that he personally received an enormous sum of private points.

It was a true expression of this school's system of merit. On the other hand, those who weren't skilled were exposed to the risk of expulsion. This

Sports Festival is going to be similar in that it will prioritize individual ability. Judging from just those words, this exam will be difficult for students like Keisei, who had excellent academics but had cause for concern in their athletic skills.

“I am sure more than a few of you are worried about this, but this time the Sports Festival has been adjusted to ensure that nobody will get expelled for lack of ability, and nobody will have to suffer any penalty alone. After all, no individual can be the perfect embodiment of athletic and academic skills at once.”

Chabashira gently explained to keep the students from panicking. Some of the students were looking at each other, surprised by how lenient this was compared to what had come before.

As was expected by now, the summary and rules of the Sports Festival was shown on the monitor.

Sports Festival: Summary and Rules

Summary

A festival of sports with all school years participating and various events.

Hours for the event: 9AM to 4PM. There will be a break from 12PM to 1PM.

Students will be freely able to choose which events to participate in, and classes will be ranked according to the total accumulated points.

Rules

- Each student will be granted 5 points at the start of the festival.
- Students participating in the Sports Festival must participate in at least 5 different events.
- Participating in an event will grant the student a participation prize of 1 point.

- Participants can receive further rewards based on the rules of the event.
- From the sixth event onwards, the student will have to pay 1 point to participate, and will not receive the 1 point participation prize.
- One student can participate in at most 10 events.
- If a student has not participated in at least 5 events by the end of the Sports Festival, all the points they have will be forfeit.
- If a student signs up for a competition but withdraws or does not participate, barring extenuating circumstances they will lose 2 points.
- Students who have finished participating in a competition must go to one of the designated areas to cheer.

The above was displayed on the monitor. Even with just a quick read of the summary and rules, you could see that it was completely different from last year.

“That is this year’s Sports Festival, the summary and an outline of the rules. Unlike the usual set up where the entire school watches as one competition takes place, this time multiple events will be held in parallel at various locations.”

“Th-that seems packed…”

Sudou was flustered after roughly imagining what it would be like on the day of the festival.

“Participating in competitions and winning the rewards from a high-rank finish will be your first priority, but you must also prepare a careful plan for the day. If you plan on winning by participating in many events, you will have a long day at the Sports Festival. There are broadly two types of competitions. Those of the first type are called fundamental competitions. In these events you have to participate as an individual, and all of them have fixed rewards. First prize will get 5 points, second 3 points, third 1 point and there will be a participation prize of 1 point. The second type, special competitions, are team events. You must participate in teams of at least two people. Team battles have higher rewards, and all members of the participating team will receive an equal amount of points. While their high

rewards make them attractive, they have drawbacks such as requiring good teamwork and running longer."

The individual battles and team battles were clearly demarcated, and the team battles could pay out more points. Students with poor athletics would be glad for the consideration shown to them by having no risks associated with a poor showing like coming in last.

"Since the rewards for the team battles vary from event to event, you will be able to check them separately."

The rules were very simple to understand, but there were surprisingly many things we had to do.

Everyone starts with 5 points and receives at least 5 points in participation prizes. Therefore, by simply participating in the sports festival, no matter your performance, you would receive 10 points. If a student couldn't fulfill the basic requirements of the test due to an accident or something like that, for each student the class would lose 10 points.

Assuming that every student participates, Ichinose's class with 40 people at this time gets 400 points, and our class with two people missing gets 380 points. Therefore, we bear a handicap of 20 points from the very beginning.

As of now we only know about the rewards from the individual battles. Considering that, getting first place would get us 5 points. So, we need to get at least four more first place finishes. That might not seem like a big deal, but one student can only compete in 10 events. That means we can't make Sudou work overtime and do 15, 20 events to rake in the points. It might be a bigger deal than you think.

"Participating in the sixth event onwards by paying points is up to the student and their class, so you are free to choose. And at the end of the festival, based on the total points earned by a class we will determine a ranking of the classes for each year."

The screen changed and the rewards for each year were shown.

Rewards for classes based on their ranking

First place 150 points

Second place 50 points

Third place 0 points

Fourth place -150 points

Compared to the usual tests, this seemed like a pretty big change in points. I suppose this was because the Sports Festival was a big event that involved the entire student body, and the class point impact of the Cultural Festival that has been announced will be relatively light.

“Those were the rewards for the classes. Now I will announce the individual rewards.”

The class rewards themselves were very motivating, but it didn’t stop there. For a Sports Festival explicitly marked as being about individual ability, it was necessary for the school to prepare individual rewards as well.

Sudou was at the edge of his seat and swallowed, waiting for the screen to change. This was the one event in the year where he could truly shine, and he knew that better than anyone.

Individual Rewards (Per year, separate for boys and girls)

First Place 2 million Private Points, or a Class Change Ticket (Limited Time)

Second Place 1 million Private Points

Third Place 500,000 Private Points

Sudou held his fists up in triumph at the generous rewards.

Along with those rewards was written a heretofore never seen noun.

“C-Class change ticket, wait, you mean──!?”

The class erupted in surprise in a way I had never seen before.

“The school is being quite careful about the introduction of this new system. Even the Protect Points were unheard of in previous generations, and these are being introduced not long after. However, students who have demonstrated their individual ability naturally have a right to rise to the top.”

In this school, the only winners are those who graduate from Class A. In an event like the School Festival which calls for incredible athletic abilities, it was not at all surprising that the school had decided getting first place in the school year was worthy of receiving the right to change classes. Perhaps that’s because the Sports Festival was technically not considered a Special Exam.

One thing that caught my interest, though, was that the Class Change Ticket was considered to be equivalent in value to two million points. Normally, the amount required to change classes was 20 million points – it was an order of magnitude higher. Despite that, the Ticket gave you the ability to change classes. The reason for this imbalance was probably contained in the words “Limited Time” attached to the ticket.

“Limited… Do you mean, even after we change classes, we’ll have to come back after some time?”

“It can’t be that, right? No way that’s what they mean.”

Sudou and Ike were disturbed by the words “Limited Time” and were talking to each other over the distance.

“You will receive the right to change classes. But, that doesn’t mean you can get it made right away. Therefore, the words ‘Limited Time’ here refer to the period during which you can use the ticket. You can only exercise this right during the second semester. Therefore, if you haven’t done so by the time the third semester starts, the ticket will expire.”

So, by Limited Time, they mean that there is a fixed time period when you can use the ticket. Considering that, I think it's somewhat acceptable for it to be equivalent to two million points. If you could hold onto it until graduation, it would guarantee getting into Class A, but because of the time limit it required the ability to identify which class would either remain at or seize the position. If you moved from one class to another, and your former class turned out to be the one to graduate as Class A, you would forever rue the day you fell for this ticket's siren song.

Even if that worst case scenario doesn't come to pass, it would require some courage to use the ticket. It was no easy matter to leave behind the class you had become familiar with for over a year and half. Say for the sake of argument that Sudou won that right. Would he throw aside Horikita and his other friends to move to Class A? Objectively speaking, I find it hard to imagine.

One success, even in the Sports Festival where all eyes would be upon you, was not a guarantee that you would get to Class A. We would do well to keep that point in mind.

But, that's only the case for the second year. For the other class years, the story was different.

For the first years, given that at this point they weren't so close to their class, there might be people who leave their class behind to switch to another which they thought was more likely to win, or quite simply jump to Class A. And on the other hand, for the students in the third year this was a golden opportunity to switch to Nagumo's class. That would be equivalent to graduating from Class A. For every class year, the right to change classes and the choices it opened up would be massive.

We'd also need to watch out for the impact it could have on us going forward. The school, too, would be watching to determine if they can bring out more tickets of this kind in the future. In all, this was an exciting reward that was interestingly balanced.

“Both the boy and the girl who place first will get to choose whichever they want. Sudou, if you are planning to reach the top through individual battles, you should carefully think about what you want.”

You could see Sudou’s back stiffen. He didn’t need to bindly prefer his friends and take the two million points, and he should think about his future. Should he remain in Horikita’s class, or should he switch to Sakayanagi’s class, which was leagues ahead of the rest? He had the right to consider his future and carefully study his options.

“Moving on, let’s go into a bit more detail. There will be competitions which will be opened in advance, and events which will only be opened on the day of the festival. So, there will be events for you to participate in even if you go into the festival entirely unprepared.”

Apart from the core events such as the 100m race and the hurdle race, some interesting and odd events were also shown. Penalty Kicks, Basketball Shootout, Tennis Singles and Mixed Doubles, etc. Competitions that wouldn’t be seen in a usual Sports Festival were strewn about.

“Because of restrictions on the number of participants and time limits, it is not guaranteed that you will be able to participate in all of the events you want to. If you plan your day without consideration for the schedule, you might fail to arrive at the event on time and will be considered as having withdrawn from it. Don’t forget that you run the risk of losing points that way.”

The students whose athletic abilities were excellent even at the school level, they had to participate in as many events as possible that efficiently paid out points. From that perspective there was also a cerebral component to this festival, and it also tested the luck involved in deciding who could participate in which test – or the ability to figure it out.

However, if the school festival started just like this, the students would surely panic. On the day of the test, if everybody rushes at once to a certain event, they wouldn’t be able to compete. Of course, the school must have thought of this already.

“For the events that will be opened beforehand, you will be able to use a special app to pre-book your participation from 10PM today. It will be first come first serve across the entire school. You will be allowed to cancel until one week before the Sports Festival, but you won’t be able to use the cancel feature more than thrice. The deadline for pre-booking is two days before the Sports Festival. If you haven’t booked the upper limit of five events by then, you will automatically be assigned to the open slots.”

When she said that, the monitor showed a screenshot of the schedule view of what must be the app.

“For demonstration, let’s sign up for the 100 meter race.”

The screen changed.

[100 meter race. An event where up to seven students of the same year, boys and girls separate, can participate. There will be four races in total. Students can pre-book for a race of their choice. On the spot participation is also possible if there are any openings. Participants have to arrive at least five minutes before their competition and complete the entry procedures. There is no need to wait after the race is completed. The first race of the day is expected to start at 10:15 AM.]

From this, a total of 56 students can participate in the 100 meter race, considering both boys and girls. Let’s say you participate in any of the races, because the competition starts at 10:15, you must arrive there at least five minutes before that time. If you take into consideration the fact that you don’t need to wait after your race is completed, participating in the first race would allow you to finish early and go to another competition. On the other hand, participating in the fourth race would mean being caught up for a long period of time. Even with the same competition and the same rewards, the variance in time could cause a bit of a loss.

“Another important point is that you cannot participate in an event if it belongs to a club you are or have ever been a member of. Hirata cannot participate in events related to soccer and Sudou cannot participate in events related to basketball.”

So students who participated in a club weren't at an advantage, and in fact had a limitation placed upon them. Certainly, there were probably no students who could win against regulars like Yousuke and Sudou, so the school wanted to avoid the competitions simply becoming matches between club members. If Sudou played soccer or Yousuke played basketball, even the other students would have plenty of chances to win.

There will also be a few students who worked hard in clubs in their middle school but didn't go for it in high school. That might cause a bit of an imbalance as well.

"That aside, this sure looks like one of those movie ticket booking apps."

Sudou muttered after listening intently to the explanation so far. He wasn't wrong.

"It is true that they are very alike. If you press the button for a time slot, you will be able to see in real time who will be participating in that event at that time."

"You mean, there might be guys who cancel 'cus they don't want to compete with me?"

Sudou snorted, folding his hands in pride.

"Yes. But, sooner or later those people will run into the three time limit of the cancel feature."

Since the number of students who can participate in each competition and their timings are known, you would want to quickly reserve the competitions you are good at or races you want. But if you reserve too early it'll raise the chances that you'll run into a powerful competitor. And since the number of times you can run away is limited, you have to be careful even about what you book. There might even be feints to figure out what others are planning. Even before the Sports Festival begins, the battle will play out online.

“And, if multiple students individually get the same points, the private point reward will be split between them and they will not be able to get the Class Change Ticket.”

In the unlikely event that students conspire to make a lot of people get first place with the same number of points, a large number of Class Change Tickets would be acquired and the system would collapse. This was a measure to prevent that possibility.

At any rate, successfully participating in the festival and getting first place alone would allow you to take either the Class Change Ticket or a large sum of money. It was a reward befitting the name “ability”. Even if you had no intention of changing classes, a sum of two million points could be useful for many reasons. Among them was making 20 million points to guarantee ending up in Class A.

On the other hand, those with poor athletics should participate in the minimum requirement of five events and stop. Using their precious points to participate in the sixth event onwards would lead to them losing that point if they didn’t win. That could lead to a big disadvantage in the fight between classes. But that choice, too, could be up to the fighting style of the class.

Chabashira finished her explanation and left, and the class immediately erupted like a geyser.

“Alright Suzune, let’s get started with the meeting right now!”

Sudou shouted at the top of his voice. The explanation of the rules had made him very excited all of a sudden. Yousuke, too, got up and started walking towards Horikita. All of this was as it usually happened.

However, a part of the class looked at them coldly. They were filled with doubts about whether it would be good to leave it to Horikita, about whether it would be good to let her be the center of the class.

“Before we begin talking about the Sports Festival, there is something I need to tell everyone first.”

She preempted everyone and spoke. She got up from her seat and turned around to face the class.

“During the special exam last week, I broke my promise to everyone and forced my choice to prevent Kushida-san from getting expelled. I would like to apologize for that.”

Horikita bowed her head after she said that. But after she raised her head, her eyes were filled with determination.

“But I think I made the right choice. She can become an asset to the class.”

“I don’t think so.”

Shinohara was the first to counter Horikita’s words. She was one of the people hurt by Kushida’s revelations.

“After finding out the kind of person Kushida is, nobody will trust her any more. While it seems like nobody has told anybody from the other classes about Kushida, don’t you think that’s just a matter of time?”

Shinohara set aside whether or not she liked Kushida and cut right to what could be considered the most important thing about her.

Since the fact that Kushida was going to remain in the class could not be changed, in order to keep things moving smoothly it was best to keep the inconvenient truths like that to ourselves. So going around telling the other classes that Kushida was actually a bad person and had dangerous thoughts would be like tying a noose around your own neck.

While it was obvious that keeping quiet would serve you well, it was surprisingly difficult to put that into practice. Especially for the current opposition, Shinohara, as Kushida had caused her a lot of grief. It wouldn’t have been surprising for her to have gone public already, but as of now it

looked like she was keeping a lid on it. Shinohara herself didn't look like she understood the advantage of that. That must mean some other wise person who understood it, like Yousuke, must have encouraged her to keep her mouth shut beforehand.

But, how long that would continue was doubtful. The moment the anxiety or distrust people had with Kushida started spilling over, it would all break down in one go.

"Hey, Horikita-san. Can you really say that keeping Kushida-san was the right choice? Answer me."

Shinohara started to lose her patience with Horikita, who had only been looking at her so far, and tried to rush her to answer.

"You can't know the answer to that question right now. That applies to you, me, and all of our classmates. She will need to make her presence felt through the rest of our school life."

"What? I want an answer now. No matter what you think, Kushida-san will be a hindrance to the class."

"Sure, she might have hurt you during the Unanimous Consent Special Exam. She might also have hurt Wan-san and Hasebe-san, who are both absent today. But you can't erase the fact that Kushida has contributed to this class over the past year and half. Or, can you proudly say that you have contributed to this class more than she has?"

Even if she caused a massive problem, her past contributions didn't just disappear like that. She brought the class together, counseled others, and raised the class average in academics and athletics. At the very least, Shinohara didn't personally have more achievements to her name than Kushida.

"I can't get you to like the fact that I surprised you all, or that Kushida-san kept repeating her vote to expel someone. But can you immediately say that expelling Kushida at that time would've been the right choice? If we lose

in a special exam because our class average went down, would you remain calm?"

"That… we can't know that unless we try it."

"Yes, we can't. Then, for what I did as well, we can't know unless we try it."

Either choice would have left the future uncertain.

Shinohara's power wasn't enough to easily take Horikita down.

"Can I speak for a moment?"

Yousuke raised his hand and stood up as Horikita and Shinohara glared at each other.

"There's been something on my mind lately. If we want to utilize Kushida-san's skills as much as possible, we need to keep her secret within this class. That's why I request everyone in the class to keep quiet about it."

"That's right. If somebody hadn't been giving out instructions in the background, it would've leaked by now."

Even Horikita was suspicious of the fact that rumors about Kushida weren't circulating even as of Monday.

"Even so, you didn't tell us to keep quiet. Why?"

"No gag rule I could put out would mean anything to those who wanted to see her fall. It's only a matter of time before it becomes well known across the school."

No matter the rule, the students would also decide for themselves whether to give in to their emotions and take revenge on Kushida by exposing her true nature, or to keep it a secret for the sake of the class.

“I wouldn’t have spoken about it even if Hirata-kun hadn’t asked me to. Our group met up over the weekend, and we got to talking about how, like, even if we let this leak, it wouldn’t be good. Of course, I’m not saying we don’t have our own thoughts about Kushida-san.”

As expected of Matushita. She was smart. Despite being one of the people affected by Kushida’s revelations, she was well aware of the disadvantages of spreading rumors about her.

If your secrets were revealed, reveal theirs in turn. You would get nothing from that but a temporary sense of victory.

“I will bring her back. If I can’t… I’ll take responsibility for it in any way possible.”

I’ll take responsibility. Even the students who had bared their fangs at Horikita gasped in response to her iron will. Shinohara was no exception to that.

“… will you really take responsibility?”

“I was prepared for that when I chose to keep Kushida. If that happens, you can pass judgment on me.”

Akito and Keisei were also watching quietly. We couldn’t imagine what they were feeling as they heard Horikita.

At any rate, Horikita’s powerful words concluded the discussion, and we had some free time.

Horikita wasn’t looking at me, but at someone else. That person returned her gaze, and after a moment Horikita left the classroom. At the same time, the person who was one empty seat away from me, Kouenji, also got up and left the room. This made me curious, so I checked on them through the slightly open door.

“You look like you have something to say to me. What is it?”

“I wanted to confirm something with you about the Sports Festival.”

“Fufu. I don’t need to help out… I’m sure you’re aware of that?”

“Of course. But, I want to know what you’re thinking. You don’t have a problem telling me that much, do you?”

Our strategy could change based on whether we could count Koenji as an active participant or not. Koenji grinned and put his hand on Horikita’s shoulder. Annoyed, she tried to brush it off, but his arm didn’t budge.

“You are a very lucky girl, it looks like.”

Even as he annoyed her with his arm on her shoulder, he made her guess what his meaning was.

“You are willing to participate, I take it?”

“I made a bit of money in the Uninhabited Island Test and the treasure hunt, but at this time I need quite some money to spend. So from my point of view, there’s no reason for me to not participate.”

After showing his overwhelming power in the Uninhabited Island test, we thought Koenji wouldn’t be doing anything in the near future, but perhaps a unique test that gave out a large sum of money could get him pumped too.

For Horikita, this was like finding money in your coat pocket. She would have nothing to complain about with getting every additional point possible. Especially because Kouenji could easily make 10 or 20 points.

However, there was another interesting thing about the rewards this time. Horikita hesitated for a moment, but in the end she brought that fact up.

“If you win the right to change classes… what will you do?”

Kouenji was easily the biggest problem child – no, free spirit – in the entire school. If he decided to change classes, he would not hesitate before ditching his previous class. Setting aside whether Kouenji would work for

the class in the near future, at the very least Horikita wouldn't consider losing a student as a good thing. On top of that, he would participate seriously in events which had huge cash rewards, like the Uninhabited Island Test and the Sports Festival. In that case, he would stand in our way as a powerful enemy.

"You have no problems on that front. There's nothing the other classes have for me at this point that beats the agreement I have with you, Ms. Horikita."

"At this point, hmm…"

He meant that depending on the circumstances it was always possible for him to change classes.

"As of now, you're safe."

I don't think Horikita would be at ease with just that, but at any rate I'm skeptical that other classes would want to draw Kouenji to them all that much. He had his strengths, but he came with a lot of drawbacks.

"Fine. I'll accept that. But if you keep changing your mind on a whim, I'll find it hard to trust you. So you don't mind if I count on you to score enough points to reach the top?"

"I'm fine with that. After all, I don't have to team up with anybody."

Looks like he was going to participate in the solo competitions. Considering it was Koenji, it would be entirely possible for him to get first place in all of them. It was pretty likely that he would get the maximum possible score of 55 points.

"Do you really have no interest in rising to Class A?"

Kouenji answered that with a laugh and returned to the classroom.

"Do you like eavesdropping on people?"

Did he notice that the door was ajar, or did he know all along?

Koenji asked from behind me.

“I can’t say I’m not curious about what you’ll do in the Sports Festival.”

“Let’s keep it at that, then.”

“Can I ask you a question, Kouenji?”

“Right now, my heart is aflutter with joy from the rewards of the Sports Festival. I’ll answer.”

“You have a promise with Horikita. But there is no guarantee that she will keep her end of it. She was prepared for the class’s opposition when she decided to retain Kushida. Like that, I thought it was entirely possible that you would have been chosen as well. Do you have any thoughts about that?”

I enquired into whether he was anxious about his promise, about if it would’ve been kept or not.

“I had it all figured out. If the turn of events would have led to me becoming a candidate for expulsion, I would’ve voted against the motion before that step. What I said about trusting Ms. Horikita was predicated on that.”

“I get it. So it wasn’t like you trusted Horikita completely.”

“I would never trust someone else with my life. Neither would you, isn’t that so?”

“Perhaps.”

Koenji seems carefree and free spirited, but behind it all he was a calculating man. Further, despite being calculating he maintained his freedom. I could completely analyze all the other students one by one, but this man alone I could never figure out.

2

As soon as our lunch break started, Horikita approached me with that question.

“Right now, Kei and──”

“We’re about to eat together. Sorry? I caaan’t let you have Kiyotaka.”

Kei ran up and forcefully came between us to intercept Horikita’s invitation. She spread out her hands with a “no”.

“I mean, I think it’s pretty weird to ask out a guy who already has a girlfriend?”

“I agree. However, the person that wants to borrow him isn’t me, it’s someone else. And it’s not a girl either. Nevertheless, I wonder if you could give me your approval.”

She turned her phone my way. Kei reacted faster than me and peeked at the screen.

“Yagami… Takuya? Who?”

“It doesn’t matter who sent the message, the contents are what’s important.”

Yagami seemed to have sent that message to Horikita about just an hour ago.

During lunch break, would you be able to call Ayanokouji-senpai to the student council room? The student council president would like to see him. If it proves difficult, please contact me and I will come to help.

That was what was written.

“I also have duties as a member of the student council. If I am told that a classmate is needed for something, I cannot refuse the request.”

It meant that she had no choice but to come and pass on what he had to say.

“It looks like student council president Nagumo wants to meet you. Did you do something again?”

“I haven’t done anything.”

Recently, I added in my mind.

“If you refuse, Yagami-kun will come here. And if you still refuse… perhaps student council president Nagumo will come, right? So, I wonder how you should reply.”

Horikita was a mere messenger. No matter how I replied, she would just get on with it indifferently.

“Sorry, Kei. If I ignore the student council president’s orders, it’ll become troublesome later.”

“Tch. Well if it’s the student council president, I guess there’s nothing you can do… Satou-saaan, let’s have lunch together?”

Understanding that she had no choice but to accept the situation, Kei immediately rushed over to Satou and the others.

“She’s quick to switch over, isn’t she? Your girlfriend.”

Either in admiration or exasperation, she mumbled something like that.

“I’ll head over right away.”

“Then, I will report that to Yagami-kun.”

“If you’ve exchanged contact information with the student council, instead of going through Yagami, wouldn’t it be faster for student council president

Nagumo to contact you directly?”

“The only person in the student council who I have exchanged contact information with on the chat app is Yagami-kun. He directly asked me for it.”

As I left the classroom, having been convinced, Horikita also came out into the hallway with me.

“I don’t know what the reason he called for you is, but I recommend you do your utmost not to anger him.”

Horikita gave me some advice. I parted ways with her and reluctantly decided to head towards the student council room. Compared to him coming to me directly, me going over myself was many times easier, after all.

I arrived in front of the student council room and knocked on the door softly. Before long, after confirming that I’d heard Nagumo’s voice from inside the room, I opened the door. As expected, I couldn’t see anyone but Nagumo inside the student council room.

“Yo, Ayanokouji. Anything unusual happen in your daily life lately?”

He started with a light jab. The things disrupting my daily life were due to instructions given by none other than the student council president in front of me. The pressure of the daily glances I received from the third-years had not diminished in the slightest.

In fact, the third-years, who didn’t know very much about me before, committed me to memory as if it were a matter of course. Without a doubt, for the upperclassmen, I was the most famous underclassman. Even without knowing the particulars, it was ingrained into them that I was the underclassman who challenged Nagumo.

“Not much has changed. Or so I would like to say, but well, I do have a few worries.”

It was easy to pretend that I hadn't noticed anything, but I was also concerned that if I didn't come off as being distressed, things might escalate further.

"As the student council president, you can talk to me about those worries, you know?"

"I might just be making too much out of it. When I am really in trouble, I will make sure to ask for help."

If I made him feel slightly good, it was possible that Nagumo might back off.

… No, that was definitely too optimistic. The only thing Nagumo desired was my direct defeat. He wouldn't be satisfied with something of that degree.

While getting a feel for it, there was no way Nagumo was going to end it with this conversation, so he changed the subject.

"You've already heard the rules for the Sports Festival, right? It means the time when we can settle our score has come, Ayanokouji. In the sports festival, there are competitions for all grades. Fight me in them."

"Is this some sort of strict training for your underclassman? I have seen your OAA, student council president Nagumo. Unless they are competitions with a large element of luck involved, no matter what I do, I have no chance of winning. The result is clear as day."

Even though my only option was to behave modestly, that wouldn't convince Nagumo.

"You always answer like that. You think that if you act humble, I'll be satisfied. No, I guess I can't blame you for that. Because acting all modest is the only option you have now."

It seemed that he was the kind of man that could see through my shallow thoughts.

“I know you’re not eager. For me as well, spending too long on you is a waste of time. That’s why, if you beat me in even one head-to-head match during this sports festival, everything that’s happened between us will be water under the bridge.”

“One win, is it?”

It was far more lax than I had imagined it would be.

“It looks like you’re thinking ‘just one win is enough?’. Is it that easy for you?”

“That is not the case. However, I think that I have a chance.”

“It would be an embarrassment to the student council president if the condition was complete victory with no losses – no, even if it was just more wins than losses.”

There was no way that he was just letting his pride get in the way. Rather, using his pride as a shield, he was trying to drag me into the fray by any means possible.

“But there’s a condition. You’ll participate in all five competitions I specify. It doesn’t matter who wins or loses, but if you miss even one of them, it’s your loss.”

“What will you do if I lose? Would you be satisfied with that win, student council president?”

“That would be nice, but… The cause of your annoyance will remain, and on top of that I might keep calling you out like this, over and over again. Or maybe you’ll have to suffer from your worries more than ever before.”

“I also have to consider my class’s plan. Could you give me some time?”

“Well, that’s all you can say for now. I’ll give you one week. Get in touch by next Monday.”

“I understand. If that is all you wanted to talk about, may I be excused now?”

“There’s no need to hurry. Or do you have plans for after this? Since I called for you, you didn’t make any flimsy promises, did you?”

“Yes, well. I do not have any plans.”

“I’m relieved to hear it.”

Nagumo was occasionally checking his phone while talking to me. It seemed he had no intention of letting me go yet.

“Excuse me.”

On the other side of the door, I heard a voice I hadn’t heard for a long time.

“Eh──”

It was Ichinose, carrying a plastic bag in her hand.

“…Sorry to keep you waiting, Nagumo-senpai.”

“Sorry I couldn’t come along to buy it with you today.”

“It’s nothing…”

“Ahh, this? Lately, I’ve been having lunch together with Honami in the student council room every day. The student council is keeping me busy, you see, so my right hand is very tired.”

I had a feeling that of late, I’d not been running into her as much during lunch, and I guess this was the reason. The student council room was off-limits to normal students, so there was no way that I would see her if she was here.

“When it’s just the two of us, she tells me all about her worries. Isn’t that right? Honami.”

“Y-yes.”

“I told her that we would have a visitor today. Join us for lunch, Ayanokouji.”

I could see three bentos in the bag. Right from the start, after finishing our conversation he intended to have me eat here. Refusing would be easy. For Ichinose, too, it would be emotionally hard on her to sit with me right now. However, I was surrounded and had already given my word, so there was no way out.

“You said you didn’t have plans after this, right? Since that’s the case, sit down.”

I was surrounded and the student council president gave me an order. Naturally, I had no right to refuse.

I sat down in a seat slightly away from Nagumo.

Perhaps Ichinose usually ate by Nagumo’s side, as she handed him the plastic bag and sat down beside him. She began preparing her lunch with a slightly downcast look, her eyes staying away from me. There was no way that Nagumo wouldn’t notice this unnatural behavior, and he should’ve been reminded of the exchange on the ship.

“The rules for the Sports Festival are quite different from last year.”

“If anything, you should be thanking me. Because if the Sports Festival had exactly the same rules as last year, my victory would be certain.”

The rules for last year’s sports split us into two teams, red and white, which competed against each other.

Nagumo was in control of the entire third year. That meant that he could make the students in the opposing team throw their matches. No matter how strenuously the remaining first and second-years struggled, their chances of winning would be equal to zero.

Before long, the conversation that should've been taking place between the three of us became a back and forth between just Nagumo and Ichinose, so I silently ate my bento by myself.



The two of them were not even halfway through their meal by the time I was done. I closed the bento's lid and held it in my hand.

"What's this? Have you finished eating already? You can leave the empty box there."

"Thank you very much."

I replied, but Nagumo's focus was already off me, his gaze fixed on Ichinose. Ichinose, perhaps trying to avoid looking at me, was also facing Nagumo.

"Please excuse me."

There was no point in staying there, so I left the student council room.

"A strategy to demonstrate his superiority, huh."

From an outsider's perspective, it would look like I was being humiliated, but there was no point in that if I myself didn't take any psychological damage. If he was aiming for that effect, he should've arranged for more members of the student council to watch from the sidelines. If he did that, he could've at least gotten the spectators to think of me as a pitiful guy.

Having said that, from how it looked, Nagumo would probably continue to be in touch with Ichinose. It could even be possible that something could happen that would change their relationship. As I walked away, I thought about the implications.

Would joining Nagumo lead to Ichinose Honami's growth? If all went well, she could acquire enough of his favor to take over the position of student council president.

That would give her the confidence to── no, that thought was a bit too naive. If Nagumo's attachment to Ichinose was due to me, it was quite possible that he would cut Ichinose off at the last minute instead. If, after

giving her heart and soul, she wasn't elected as student council president, and Horikita was recommended despite having contributed less, her spirit wouldn't last a year and she would be crushed.

In that sense, Nagumo's power was formidable.

Although I needed to keep an eye on Nagumo, there were other things I needed to do right now.

That was true for the imminent sports festival, but before that I needed to keep preparing for the cultural festival that came after. In view of the situation in the class, I asked the originators of the idea, Satou, Matsushita, and Maezono, for a brief pause, but preparations for securing staff for the maid cafe had to proceed.

I was originally counting on Airi's participation, but that was no longer possible and Haruka was also not expected to participate at the present time. Kushida could've been another powerful card to play, but that, too, had disappeared.

Moreover, in my attempts to learn the ins and outs of this field, I couldn't thoughtlessly rely on my classmates to help me right now either.

With the class ripped apart as it was right now, if I brought up the maid cafe, not only would they be creeped out and think, 'what are you talking about?', but that feeling could also lead to them leaking information.

"A maid café…huh."

I knew nothing at all about the event, and we would have to sell a lot to cover the budget involved. I must research winning strategies as well as what our rivals were doing.

3

Homeroom, the morning after the details of the rules of the Sports Festival were explained to us.

Just like yesterday, the atmosphere in the class wasn't particularly cheery.

The reason was their three missing classmates. Still absent, huh. It wasn't unusual for someone to take the day off because they were sick or in poor shape, but I was sure everyone here knew that these three people weren't resting for that reason.

If you were absent from school for a few days in a row, normally you'd have to go to the clinic in Keyaki Mall and get a doctor's note. On the other hand, with a doctor's note, it wouldn't be a major problem.[1] In short, even if you didn't have a fever, if you swore you were sick the clinic could be amenable to a two or three day leave.

But, as Chabashira told us during homeroom, all three of them had not been to the clinic to be examined.

Unlike Kushida, the other two had at least contacted Chabashira, but how long she would let this continue with just that was unclear. It would be a problem if they were still absent after tomorrow. Haruka's absence was due to Airi's expulsion. Wang's absence was because her love for Yousuke was exposed. Kushida's absence was because her true nature was revealed. None of these reasons had anything to do with any illness.

I wonder what would happen if this continued for three days, five days, or even a week. It wouldn't be strange if the school thought these absences weren't coincidental and started an investigation. And as Chabashira had mentioned earlier, sooner or later it'd start having a significant effect on our class points.

Beyond that, several other cracks had begun to form in places that couldn't be seen.

Wang wasn't the only victim of Kushida's revelations. The fact that flame was spreading around the newly formed couple, Ike and Shinohara, was another concern. In fact, it seemed like Shinohara was still not talking to the people who had insulted her, that is, Kei, Matsushita and Mori.

And, despite the fact that they weren't named in that incident, we couldn't rule out the possibility that Shinohara was not talking to Satou or Maezono either for the same reason.

Even if they weren't members of the group she usually hung out with, this used to be a class where the girls had strong bonds even across groups. It was clear now that those bonds were completely split.

It was about time we started forming teams to earn points from the team competitions, but this class couldn't reach that stage just yet.

If we tried to make teams in this state, we'd unnecessarily exacerbate our internal divisions. Because she understood that, Horikita wasn't bringing it up either. That said, it was also impossible to repair those divisions at this time. Along with Horikita, Yousuke also understood that well.

Time didn't wait for us, and the morning homeroom ended.

Immediately after that, I received a message on my tablet.

I need to talk to you about something. Come out of the class after me.

Chabashira-sensei sent me a brief instruction. Shortly after she left the classroom, I got up from my seat, pretending to go to the toilet. Nobody saw me leave, all thanks to my seat being at the back of the class by the door. I turned the corner to the corridor leading to the staffroom and spotted Chabashira-sensei standing with her back to the wall.

"It's unusual for you to call me like this. Is it an urgent matter?"

For a moment, I thought of the three absent students, but it didn't seem like that was related.

"Yes. There is something I must tell you. It's about Sakura."

"About Airi?"

It was already the week after Airi had been expelled. Quite some time had passed.

After so long, she had something she needed to tell me?

"When she was expelled, the school naturally went through all the procedures. Arranging her luggage, reclaiming her private points. Well, that kind of thing, like, post-processing."

Her expression was clear, but what she was saying was somewhat muddled. Was it because of her feelings about losing one of her students?

"Items already purchased in the school are fundamentally the student's personal property, and how they are dealt with is up to the student. Whether you take them along or not, it's fine either way. The formalities for expulsion are processed in the staffroom but… well, an unexpected thing happened before that."

"An unexpected thing, is it?"

"Yeah. After the Unanimous Consent Special Test was finished, we found evidence that Sakura spent about five thousand of her private points, and well, you can say we're not sure how to handle that."

"Aren't the expellee's private points taken away from them?"

"Yeah. But, as I said earlier, that only happens after the formal processing. However, the school considers this a gray area. Say you transferred all your points to someone else, the school wouldn't accept that, right?"

“Right. If you transferred all your points after you were expelled, it could cause problems. So, did Airi transfer five thousand points to somebody?”

“No, it’s not like that. Sakura――”

She told me about a use of private points I hadn’t considered. As she explained, I realized that I wasn’t entirely unconnected.

“――that being the case, I thought I’d reach out to you, you being involved and all. Of course, you have no obligation to bear this. If you refuse, I’ll take care of it.”

What Airi did in the brief period after her expulsion was set in stone. I leaned into my gut feeling about what I should do and made a decision.

“It’s not a very large sum of money, so can you let it be?”

“Are you saying you will pay that sum?”

“Will that be a problem?”

“No. It’ll just be you spending your private points as you are entitled to, so the school should have no objections to it.”

“Got it.”

I got her to confirm that it wouldn’t be a problem.

“I wanted to ask—does this… have something to do with you?”

As if she was looking for something, Chabashira-sensei asked me.

“Not at all. It’s just what she herself thought of doing in the limited amount of time she had.”

Of course, even I didn’t know the details of what she was thinking, but as time passed I was sure that it would come to me eventually.

“At any rate, it’s a small matter, but I’m still glad to have taken care of this. The state of the class being what it is, there are very few things to be happy about after all.”

It didn’t fit her at all, showing concern for the class she was in charge of.

“What’s with that look.”

“Nothing. As you say, sensei, the class is unstable right now. I was planning to set part of it straight, but I think that may not be necessary.”

“What do you mean?”

“For now, please watch over each and every one of your students as they grow.”

She looked just a little unsatisfied, but she quietly nodded anyway.

Chapter 2

Introduction

I've said this again and again, but the class was facing multiple problems at the same time. It wouldn't do if the leaders of the class just watched as each and every one of those problems festered.

He probably wanted to fix these problems by himself. It wasn't a bad thing, wanting to do everything by yourself, but lacking the power to do so made it mere idealism. Well, there were also problems that you couldn't handle alone, even if you had the ability to solve them. The need of the hour was to rely on your comrades. That way, you had the option to coordinate and fix all of the problems at once.

From the weekend until this very moment, I was not showing any real signs of helping out. After reading the day's news on my phone, I got up to leave the class, a little after the students who were going out for fun right after school.

As if waiting for that moment, he hurried to catch up to me.

Frustrated by being unable to find a solution to our problems, he would reach out to me soon enough—so I'd expected.

"Hey, Kiyotaka-kun. Can you make some time this evening? I need your advice on a few things."

Keeping his surroundings in mind, he made his request in a low voice.

“I have plans with Kei this evening. How about right now, would that work?”

I didn’t actually have any such plans, but I lied to feel him out.

“That’s…”

Of course he couldn’t accept. Yousuke’s club activities didn’t give him free time so soon after school. As the sports festival drew close, the clubs, too, would suspend all activities, so this was the time when he would want to participate as much as he possibly could.

“Just kidding. I’ll speak to Kei. We’ll have our date sometime later.”

“Th-thanks.”

“Just to confirm again, you need my advice?”

I was well aware of it, but I deliberately asked again anyway. Yousuke didn’t think anything of it and nodded.

“Yes. I think it’s best to act early.”

“Hmm. Anyway, if you’re fine with my room, the evening is yours.”

Gladdened by the positive answer, Yousuke’s cheeks relaxed, and he smiled like a child.

“If possible, could you ask Karuizawa-san to attend as well? It would be a great help.”

“Kei too? Of course, she’d be happy to attend, but wouldn’t she just get in the way?”

“There are quite a few problems we need to solve, so I would like her help as well.”

Kei's presence made a big difference as she had a network of information about the girls. I didn't have to ask Yousuke to know that he wanted information on Kushida, Shinohara, Haruka and the rest.

"Then… how about 7:30?"

"That'll be fine. I'll be there on the dot."

His eyes narrow with happiness, Yousuke quickly made his way to his club activities.

He would immediately extend his help to anybody in need.

"Class Problem no. 2, indeed."

Well, this was, in a way, unavoidable. Since I'd been helping Yousuke out when he was in trouble so far, it was inevitable that it would turn out like this. It wouldn't be easy to tear down what I myself built up, but I had to.

Well then. I'll start by asking Kei to come to my room at 7:30 PM.

1

It was 5:30 PM. I'd come home and was chilling, waiting for Yousuke to arrive, when I got a notification on my phone.

Can I come over and hang out right now?

Kei, my girlfriend, had sent me a message with a cute cat sticker. We were due to meet Yousuke at 7:30 PM, so she was very early.

And while we're at it, let's have dinner together? she added before I could reply.

It seemed what she really wanted was to have dinner together. I shot her a brief response—*I'm down.*

"Now then, I'll have to make something."

I could just serve yesterday's leftovers, but what about something Kei liked that I could make quickly…

I opened the fridge, looked inside and was thinking about it when the doorbell rang. I opened the front door to find Kei grinning at me. Even though I was a little surprised, I didn't panic and casually let her in. It was a big deal that I no longer needed to be careful about when to let her into my room now that our relationship was out in the open.

"You were very quick."

Kei's movements as she took off her shoes and entered my room had become very familiar.

"That's because I messaged you just before I got on the elevator~"

It seemed she was going to come over anyway, with my presence or other plans being an afterthought. I gave up on cooking for the moment and sat with her on the floor by the table.

“Maybe it’s because I’m always in your room lately, Kiyotaka, but I’m getting used to it—like it’s my own room.”

“I’m glad to hear it. On the other hand, you’ve never invited me to your room, Kei.”

“E-ehh? It’s a bit embarrassing and…w-well, maybe one day if I feel like it!”

She didn’t give me a straightforward yes, but when it came to a girl’s room, I was sure there were a lot of circumstances. I’ll try not to hound her too much.

“Come to think of it, what are the people around you saying about our relationship?”

“The girls? Surprisingly, they’re accepting it pretty smoothly, I guess? Or like… nevermind.”

She tried to say something and got all muddled. I was a bit curious, so I tried to dig deeper.

“What is it?”

“Well, y’know? It’s that, for now, everyone’s all about the Hirata Yousuke brand. There are quite a lot of girls saying it’s a waste.”

I see. It meant they didn’t understand why she went and switched to an off-brand guy like me. Certainly, it wasn’t surprising that they compared me to Yousuke and openly talked about things like that.

“In a way, I’m taking hits because of it too. Even though it’s supposed to be that *I* broke things off with Yousuke-kun, people are wondering if, actually,

he dumped *me*."

If the guy you switched to was off-brand, then it was natural for people to suspect that.

"But like, that's only some of them. These days, your reputation has also been going up expotentially."

"You want to say *exponentially*. What kind of mistake is that?"

It was so basic that I suspected it might've been deliberate. Kei laughed with a broad grin on her face.

"Even I know that muuuch."

"Your tutor is excellent, after all."

"I'm always grateful, sensei. Thanks to your secret private lessons, my scores are going up."

Kei had been gradually improving her academics, and at the beginning of September, her Academic Ability rank in the OAA rose up to C with a score of 48. It meant she had finally acquired about as much knowledge as an average student. After a few minutes of such idle chit-chat, I got up and went to the fridge again.

"I'm thinking of making omurice, will you eat it?"

I asked without looking back and Kei immediately screamed in delight.

"I'll eat it, I'll eat it! I'd like the ketchup to be a bit thicker please, chef."

It wasn't the first time I had treated Kei to a home-cooked meal like this. Ever since we'd started dating, every now and then, I'd have the opportunity to serve her a meal in my room.

Until now, Kei herself had almost never shown any signs of cooking, but I didn't particularly mind. It was fine for the one who wanted to cook to do it.

It didn’t matter whether you were a man or a woman—gender was irrelevant. I didn’t dislike cooking, and Kei would eat it with pleasure. Kei liked to talk, and she would liven the place up by skilfully engaging me in conversation, despite me not being a good talker. We were the type to have a good balance and support each other like that, I guess.

I took eggs, ketchup, chicken and butter out of the fridge. After getting some salad oil from the shelf, I was all set. I brought out some frozen rice and left it defrosting it in the microwave. In the meantime, I got the onions ready. In truth, I wanted to include some carrots on the side, but I unfortunately didn’t have any stocked up. Just as I put the onions on the chopping board and picked my knife up, I felt a presence behind me. Kei had approached me and snuggled up against my back.

“What are you doing?”

Because it was slightly dangerous, I stopped what I was doing and asked without moving.

“Just watchiiing.” Kei answered, but with the side of her face stuck to my back, she shouldn’t be able to see what was going on. “It’s okay to just ignore me. I’ll stay still.”

“I see, got it.”

I did as she told and ignored her for the time being. Continuing my work, I cut the onion into squares of about 5mm each on the chopping board. The whole time I was doing that, Kei stuck snugly to my back and didn’t let go. I then put down the knife and reached for a bowl to crack an egg, but, at that moment, Kei put her hands around my waist and hugged me.

“What are you doing this time?”

“Hmmm…? Just watchiiing.”

“I really can’t see how you’re ‘just watching’ though? If anything, this is sabotage.”

I didn’t go so far as to give her a warning, but I prodded her about the slight drop in work efficiency. She didn’t show any sign of caring, however.

“Ahh, I’m so happy. Is there anything else that could make me this happy?” she muttered briefly, and the arms embracing me squeezed even tighter. She looked rather satisfied.

“That’s a very cheap happiness. Aren’t there more amazing sources of happiness out there? Like buying something you want or watching something you were looking forward to on TV?”

“That kinda thing wouldn’t make me anywhere near as happy.”

“I was speaking at random just now, but there actually is something, right?”

“Nope, there’s nothing. Even if there was, I don’t need it. This happiness I have now is more than enough.”

If she was satisfied with this, I didn’t have anything more to say from my side.

“Can I start cooking again?”

Naturally, continuing in this position would be highly inconvenient.

“Eh~? What shall I do~?”

She peeked at me and smiled while fluttering her eyes.

“I’d reeeally like some kinda reward for behaving.”

“There’s some chocolate in the fridge.”

“Wrong answer. That’s not what I’m talking about, but… we went out of sync somewhere, didn’t we? Well, that is very you, Kiyotaka. Then, I’ll wait quietly~”

Kei left and sat down on the bed as if she was satisfied with herself. Now then, it looked like I could concentrate on making the omurice for a while. Kei waited for me to finish cooking while alternating between looking at her phone and the TV. The two of us then sat around the table and finished dinner a little earlier than usual.

“Oh, by the waaay, it’s about Shinohara-san, but…” I didn’t broach the subject specifically or anything, but Kei said that and continued, “I was at fault too, but I guess her getting exposed had quite an effect on her—she won’t even talk to me.”

“It’s only natural.”

Whether someone looks good or bad varies according to each person’s own tastes and sense of style, but, those who are generally considered superior make condescending remarks about those considered inferior. That itself was not an uncommon occurrence and could be seen anywhere. Rather, they often just say what they’re thinking, without having any kind of malice behind it.

“Do you and the others hate Shinohara?”

“I don’t hate her at all. Shinohara-san’s a fun girl, like, she’s well known for brightening the mood.”

“I see. And that’s why you were only unconsciously having fun at the expense of her relationship with Ike.”

“…I guess. We were laughing while talking about things that would’ve hurt her if she’d heard.” She muttered regretfully, as if reflecting on her actions. “Will you hate me for saying mean things about her like that?”

“People bad-mouth other people. I don’t intend to deny that in itself. Though there may be differences in how much, it would be difficult to find someone who doesn’t bad-mouth others at all.”

Hating a senior in your club because they're too overbearing, or hating your teacher for being too egotistical. It's okay to have one or two complaints like that. There's an excessive side to matters like making fun of someone's appearance or pointing out issues related to their academic ability, but, sure enough, it isn't strange that we, as human beings, talk about such things.

"But basically, the one thing that must be avoided is having the target overhear you bad-mouthing them."

"Ain't that right."

"It must've been a shock that it was leaked by *that* Kushida, the exception among exceptions. Telling someone always carries a risk."

Naturally, Shinohara was deeply hurt by the conversations criticizing her appearance that Kushida leaked. That wasn't all. Shinohara's friends who didn't have a bad impression of her, her boyfriend Ike, as well as his friends; they would all naturally think poorly of Kei and the others. Next time, Shinohara and the others might turn it around and openly bad-mouth Kei, Matsushita, Mori and the rest. Once the vicious cycle starts, it would require considerable effort to bring a stop to it.

"And? You aren't stopping at just feeling bad, right? Did you do anything about it?"

Matsushita had already given me a brief explanation, but I had to hear it from Kei as well.

"I tried talking it out, about all the misunderstandings… no, about how I hurt her, but it's kinda like she's disapproachable right now."

"Unapproachable, you mean."

"That, yeah that… th-that was on purpose, 'kay?"

This time she really did get it wrong.

It seemed that Kei and the others had at least tried to repair their broken relationship with Shinohara, in their own ways.

“So, you know… what do you think I should do so we can make up?”

“You’re asking me?”

“Isn’t it obvious? If it’s you, Kiyotaka, I’m sure you’ll come up with a clever plan.”

Kei also had the same problem as Yousuke, but it didn’t seem like she’d found any openings until now.

“I’m still thinking about that now. Give me a little more time.”

I told her that and put off answering the question for now.

“Say, it’s a completely different topic, but can I ask you something a bit weird?” I continued to listen without stopping her, so she looked up at me with a curious face and asked, “You know how you chose to expel Sakura-san on the basis of her OAA in the special exam? If—”

When our eyes met, Kei choked on her words.

“Actually, it’s fine. It’s nothing.”

“Are you curious about what I would’ve done if you had the lowest score in the OAA?”

Her eyes widened upon being read so easily.

“I said it at that time with Ike; even if you had similar scores, the difference between the number of friends you have would be overwhelming. I wouldn’t expel you.”

“Then if I didn’t have any friends? If my status among the girls was low?”

The thoughts that had been making her anxious poured out of her in quick succession.

“That argument is meaningless. In that hypothetical, Karuizawa Kei would be a completely different person. If that were the case, you and I wouldn’t have developed our relationship to what we have right now.”

“…That’s… yeah. That might be right, but… if I was that completely different me, and I wasn’t dating you, Kiyotaka, would I have been expelled?”

Even though she understood that it was a meaningless argument, she couldn’t help but ask.

“If your abilities were like you just said, then I guess you would’ve.”

“Ugh…”

“It’s not like I don’t understand why you’d feel hurt, but that person isn’t you. It really is a different person. You were bullied and hurt, and established your position amongst the girls in order to reverse the situation once you became a high schooler. You used Yousuke, and met and went out with me. That’s Karuizawa Kei, right?”

When I went that far with my answer, Kei pouted in obvious dissatisfaction.

‘“I would’ve protected any version of you’. *That’s* the correct answer, ’kay?”

“…I see.”

Even if it wasn’t her, she wanted me to declare that I would protect Karuizawa Kei. I learnt my lesson that, when it came to things like that, there was no need for logic.

She laid down on my lap and I stroked her head, trying to put her in a good mood instead. After enjoying a few minutes curled up in my lap like a cat,

she started to speak without changing her position.

“Hey Kiyotaka. I don’t mind that you cut off Sakura-san. Because you never make any mistakes. But was it really the right decision for Horikita-san to keep Kushida-san? She’ll only be in the way, right?”

Kushida Kikyou, the person responsible for creating the cracks in the class. Kei felt that the disadvantages of not expelling her were significant. It wasn’t unusual or anything, it was the natural reaction.

Anyone would have doubts. Even if they did, they wouldn’t find it easy to speak up when pressed for time. And then they’d think that it was fine so long as they could ultimately save themselves. The heat probably started to die down during the two days off after the exam. Some would wonder whether it really was a good thing, and some would be relieved that they themselves weren’t expelled. And some would be terrified wondering if they might be next.

“Do you know what Kushida has that Airi doesn’t?”

“Eh? Studying and sports, right? Kushida is pretty amazing. She’s quite good at everything.”

“That’s right when it comes to the superficial reasons. But what’s most important isn’t that.”

“…What do you mean?”

“It’s the possibility that she becomes an important piece in awakening Horikita Suzune as a leader. She might become something to Horikita that neither you nor Yousuke could; someone she could call a partner.”

“*Kushida-san* will…?”

“Horikita herself probably hasn’t understood that fully just yet. She just trusted her instincts in a tight situation where she had no time to spare.”

“That’s what Kushida-san has that Sakura-san doesn’t…”

“A perspective that only Kushida has. Thoughts that only Kushida has. Statements that only Kushida can make. Those are things she could do regardless of her popularity. And those will support Horikita.”

While Kei had accepted it to a certain extent, she wasn’t wholly convinced. Was that also a natural reaction? It was an uncertain future. It was just an empty theory, based on the assumption that Horikita was right in making that choice.

“She’s fully aware that Haruka and those that were involved resent her. But her results won’t show in just a day or two. All we can do is watch attentively.”

“But isn’t Hasebe-san more resentful of *you*, Kiyotaka?”

“That’s right.”

The difficulty of reaching unanimity in that situation where time was just about to run out. No matter how many others Horikita suggested, it would’ve been almost impossible to come to a consensus. And the hit to our class points would’ve been unacceptable. With that being the case, there was no option but for me to take action.

“If she could talk about results, conclusions, and answers, then it’d be easy. But the reality is she can’t do that.”

“You mean Horikita-san?”

“Suppose there’s a hurdle in front of you that’s at a height where you’re not sure whether you’d be able to clear it successfully or not. If you challenge it and fail, you might just fall over without being able to jump over it, or maybe you’d get as little as a scrape on your leg and clear it. Or perhaps, if you’re really unlucky, you might even break a bone.”

I put forward an imaginary scenario where a hurdle that you could just barely clear using exactly your full strength was blocking your way forward.

“What do you think you should do to ensure you get over that hurdle?”

“Eh…? U-umm… do a bunch of practice before trying to jump it?”

“And if you can’t practice?”

“That’s… you’d have to just go for it, right? Like, that’s the only way…”

“It’s the same as that. Horikita couldn’t stop running once she’d started and tried to jump over the hurdle in front of her.”

“In short, you’re saying that Horikita failed the challenge and fell down?”

“No, it’s more like she jumped and her leg hit the hurdle. How badly was she hurt and will she just fall down like that? Is she herself okay or is she seriously injured? That has yet to be determined.”

It was easy to avoid that hurdle. She would’ve been better off not jumping and taking a slight detour. But that was also what made me want to keep watching her. I once again found myself wondering about things I never imagined when I’d first started at this school.

“So it’s like that. But yeah, I really can’t accept Horikita-san’s decision. She broke her promise as well. On top of all that, she even went as far as to say she would protect Kushida-san.”

Certainly, there was an aspect of intimidation to it, but it was also a fact that, until now, Horikita’s class had become far too shiftless. With the waves that decision made, everyone knew that their personal safety was not guaranteed. Of course, their trust in Horikita would have been shaken, but that was something she would be able to get back in the special exams ahead. Though that was conditional on if they would continue on with their goal of reaching Class A.

While we were talking about this and that, the clock struck 7PM. I cleared away the plates we'd eaten from and went to the kitchen to wash them while I still could.

"Hey, hey, come over here and chat with me~."

"Later. I'm going to do the dishes."

"Ehh? Buuuut it'll be 7:30 when you're done!"

We'll be starting our discussions when Yousuke arrives, so she cried in dissatisfaction. I ignored her and started doing the dishes. She was quiet for a while, but, unable to keep still for long, she soon started making demands of me again.

"C'mon, c'mon, come here, don't be shy. 'kay? 'kay?"

While saying that, she patted the bed three, four times.

"Guess I don't have a choice――"

I wanted to at least be done with the pots before Yousuke arrived, but I gave up. I sat down in the spot Kei was patting. Happy, she poked my right cheek again and again.

"Your cheek sure is soft for a boy~. Are you taking care of it?"

"Just lotion."

For the amount of stress my teenage skin was subjected to, I thought any more care would be fundamentally useless.

"Hmmm…"

She didn't buy it, but, at the same time, she didn't seem to care all that much and kept poking as if she just wanted to touch me. I caught her hand, pulled her towards me and stole a kiss. I thought she'd be surprised, but she blushed and smiled as if she'd been expecting it.

“I’ve been waiting for this ever since I came to the room today.”

“… I see.”

I had to admit, I still couldn’t read her when it came to things like this. After that, we wordlessly kissed each other again and again, our bodies close. Her kisses tasted like the omurice. It was an odd experience.

“I love you…”

Kei nuzzled up against me, and I gently held her, a quiet silence taking over us. Rather than being awkward, it was comforting. For a while, we just held each other tight.

Our tranquility was rent asunder by the sound of the doorbell. Brought back to reality all of a sudden, Kei panicked and moved away from me, unexpectedly embarrassed. She didn’t need to hurry—the door was locked—but well… I get why she did that.

I waited a bit for Kei to calm down, and then both of us together received Yousuke. He’d come to my room still in his uniform.

“I went to Keyaki mall with my seniors after our club activities, you see.”

He clarified, noticing that I was looking at his uniform.

“Welcome, make yourself home~”

Seeing Kei acting as if this were her own room, Yousuke smiled happily. Since we came to this school, he’d been watching over Kei more than anyone else, and that must be why he was glad to see her so genuine and cheerful.

“Thanks for having me.”

Ever courteous, he arranged his shoes before entering, and, after he took his seat, I brought him some tea.

“Thanks.”

“So, what did you want my advice on?”

There was no point in holding him here for long, so I made it easy for him to get started. Well, I’d already predicted everything he was going to talk about, though.

“Yeah, it’s about the class. As we are right now, going into the Sports Festival would be dangerous. I’m sure Karuizawa-san also understands. I feel like the girls would find it especially hard to work together.”

Yousuke turned to Kei, as she would be more aware of the details.

“I was just talking to Kiyotaka about Shinohara-san. Honestly, I’m not even thinking about the competition right now.”

Instead, she was trying to fix her friendship with Shinohara.

“I was wondering if you had any good ideas about that. I want your help, Kiyotaka-kun.”

Kei, who had also just asked me for help along similar lines, turned to me too. That being the case, I should also speak freely.

“Yousuke, have you talked to anybody else about this before me?”

“Huh? No… this is the first time. If I tried to talk without any preparation, and word got out that I was trying to fix things, I felt like it wouldn’t work out well.”

Most people would be happy if they felt like he just wanted to help them, but, on the other hand, if they knew that he was trying to bring people together again, it would just make them wary of him. They might even suspect him of having an ulterior motive for his kind words.

“You too, huh?”

“I was thinking, maybe I want instructions, after all.”

“Then, moving forward I want you to take these conversations not to me, but to Horikita, the leader of the class.”

“But I think Horikita-san has her hands full with what’s going on with Kushida-san. Right now, her helping out with the problems of our other classmates――”

“So, if I was taking care of Kushida, would you guys go to Horikita?”

“That’s… I wonder. Maybe I would still talk to you, Kiyotaka-kun.”

After picturing my hypothetical, Yousuke honestly admitted that he would.

“Horikita-san is doing a great job, but Kiyotaka-kun would be able to see the big picture, and make the right call. That’s what I thought.”

“Me too, y’know? Like, if I left it to you, you’d come up with the perfect answer.”

“I think I told you this in the last Special Exam as well. You won’t be able to rely on me forever. Even if you’re not sure, you should take these conversations to Horikita first. If you don’t follow that process, it would be wrong.”

“But――”

“It will be a burden on her. I’m not sure if she’ll come up with a solution. So I can’t rely on her, won’t rely on her. If you do that, do you think Horikita will ever become a true leader? What if it was a leader like Ryuuen, Sakayanagi or Ichinose? Even if you’re already handling it, if you had any concerns, would you not take it to them first?”

The important thing was to rely on her, to be relied upon by her. Horikita and the class are getting to the point where they grow through repeated success and failure.

“Even a failure is a learning opportunity. Everybody starts at 1 + 1. Of course, Horikita is already well beyond that stage, but she still overwhelmingly lacks experience.”

Before you go ahead with a solution, you must not skip the process of deliberating and finding one.

“I’d rather you came to me with this only after she tells you that she has her hands full with Kushida.”

“… I get it. I understand what you want to say, Kiyotaka-kun.”

He sincerely listened to me, nodded several times and internally processed the meaning of my words.

“I understand that it’s important to learn from failure, but this isn’t about marks on a test. I don’t think this situation is one where a bad result just means you’ve got to work harder next time. It’s a critical issue that deals with our class’s mental state. If the cracks in our relationships broke open because of an immature decision… there’s no coming back from that.”

How very like him. He didn’t seem to have come to me just to get an easy answer.

“That’s a good decision. But isn’t your reasoning still a little naive? You’re right that there are cracks in the relationships between our classmates. And it certainly is possible that friction between friends, fights or backbiting can lead to issues which can’t be fixed.”

If it escalates from bad-mouthing to outright harassment and ignoring or bullying each other, it would be the worst case. But, that would be the worst possible case.

“Kei. Is your feud with Shinohara at such a dangerous stage?”

“Hmm… I mean, we’re still fighting. I’m the one at fault there so I don’t feel like telling her off. And I’m not being mean to her or anything. There

aren’t even many other girls who don’t like Shinohara, I think.”

By taking this too seriously, they were getting unnecessarily worked up about it. That was how I saw it.

“On top of that, you weren’t just going to have Horikita solve it by herself, right?”

“Of course not. I am going to do everything I can,” replied Yousuke.

“That’s good. If both of you handle this well with Horikita at the lead, I reckon you could make it through most of the problems.”

But I didn’t think just those words would set them completely at ease. Let me add to that a very important thing.

“Of course, there are bound to be things you won’t be able to fix even if you work with her. I’ll help you out with those.”

I believed they would be able to act without hesitation if their backup plan was perfect. They both looked convinced, but Yousuke seemed like he still had something on his mind, and so his face was still clouded. After that, we exchanged information for a bit, and at around 8 PM, I suggested they return home.

“Umm… if you’re okay with it, can we talk? Just the two of us?”

He ventured just as he was about to leave, as if it wouldn’t do to leave something as it was.

“OK! Then, I’ll go back first.”

Yousuke still had things he wanted to talk about, so Kei gave him that reply and left quickly. After I closed the door, Yousuke turned to me again.

“Kiyotaka-kun. I will go to Horikita-san tomorrow. But—as of now—do you have a clear way to solve this in mind?”

“In all honesty, I don’t have any ideas for an immediate solution for Haruka and Kushida. I’m hoping you guys will discuss and show me a good way.”

“So… that isn’t the case with Mii-chan?”

“In a way. It’ll take some time, but it’s possible. If you’re in a hurry, there’s even a crude but forceful method.”

“Crude? If it’s something I can do, I think I should try it.”

Yousuke’s reaction and his attitude didn’t change even when it was about a girl who liked him.

“I’m telling you, it’s crude. I wouldn’t recommend it.”

“What is it?”

“Well, you should meet Mii-chan and accept her feelings, Yousuke.”

Yousuke’s reaction showed that he hadn’t even considered it.

“‘Actually, I like you too, Mii-chan. Please go out with me.’—if you make that conversation happen, she’ll go back to school tomorrow.”

I was slightly reluctant to tell him that, but that was about what I had in mind right now.

“If it wasn’t you, Yousuke, I wouldn’t even talk about such an absurd method. But, you have experience with being in a fake relationship, when Kei asked you to. So I thought it could be possible.”

“Certainly,” Yousuke muttered, but his expression still didn’t clear up. “Karuizawa and I agreed to date each other as a front because neither of us had any romantic feelings for each other. Pretending to accept Mii-chan’s feelings and dating her is not the same. She will only end up deeply hurt later.”

“I don’t want to recommend this option, but that’s wrong. I don’t know when exactly Mii-chan fell in love with you, but you can’t deny that many students did so not long after you entered the school. So, the price of you protecting Kei from bullying by going out with her is that, quite possibly, there are girls who you indirectly rejected and therefore hurt by that lie.”

“That’s――”

If Kei and Yousuke had actually been dating, it would’ve been justified. But that wasn’t the case, and so even if the situation is different, what he’ll be doing will very much be the same.

“If, right now, Mii-chan hugged you while crying, and said she’d never go to school again if you didn’t go out with her, what would you do? Would you shoot her down, saying you just couldn’t pretend?”

Yousuke was at a loss for words. After all, it was very likely that he wouldn’t do that.

“If you can’t reject her, you would have two choices. You could tell her you don’t like her but still date her, or you could lie to her that you do like her and date her.”

And if, while they dated, true love did sprout in Hirata, it could lead to the best possible ending.

“It doesn’t sit right with me… I don’t think I should do that.”

He understood what I was saying, but his emotions stood in his way.

“At the end of the day, it is a forceful method. It might take some time now, but we’re just laying the groundwork at this stage.”

“I get it. …That aside, you really are strong, Kiyotaka-kun. It’s like you’re not even slightly weighed by expelling Sakura-san.”

I couldn’t sense any sorrow or anger in his quiet voice.

“I still remember… how my hands felt at that moment.” He stretched his arms out and looked at his palms. “I can never forget. How my fingertips felt when I pressed the Support button on the tablet.”

Yousuke had to work hard for his classmates day and night, so he couldn’t show any weakness. However, he was suffering, feeling just as responsible for expelling Airi as I was.

“I know what you felt at that time, Yousuke. I knew you weren’t on board with expelling Airi, as she hadn’t done any harm in that exam. But you still went along with us. At the very end, you could’ve said you would never accept it, but you refrained from doing so.”

It was a senseless situation. If that was brought to their attention and they were made to face up to it, our classmates would have regained their composure. If they broadened their perspective, which had been narrowed by the pressure from running out of time, it was likely that reaching unanimity would have been impossible.

“The most important thing… was for our class to reach Class A… I convinced myself with that.”

His brain understood it, but he couldn’t bring himself to agree.

“Hasebe-san, Kushida-san and Mii-chan are absent from school. How long will that continue? Our classmates are terrified of the new reality, that they could get down for their lack of ability. The class that was cheerful until just last week is becoming quiet again, as if it was all a lie.”

He was trying to solve these problems, but he was suffering, asking himself these same questions again and again.

“I understand very well that you don’t agree with the choice Horikita and I made. But, you have no choice but to accept it. You just have to think about and reflect on the strength of this class. And that is why Horikita needs all the help she can get. She could pick the right path or the wrong one, or maybe even an uncertain path.”

It wasn't like Yousuke would be able to digest everything internally just by telling him once.

"I――― I wonder… would it have been better to choose to let the time run out…"

Yousuke's shoulders trembled. He could no longer contain himself. He would never want to even consider the thought of sacrificing someone. And the fact that he was able to make the right choice in that situation was a definite sign of his growth.

"… Have I become stronger, or has my sense of self broken down? I'm scared… I don't know what choice I'll make if something like this comes to pass again."

He'd hung his head so I couldn't see his face, but then he rubbed his eyes with his sleeves and raised his head again.

"I'm sorry, Kiyotaka-kun—you might be the one suffering the most, but I'm saying such weak things to you."

"That's alright. You helped Horikita and me out so many times during the Special Exam. I can tell that we'll have tougher battles ahead of us. I want you to remain as you are and keep helping the class."

Yousuke nodded. The wound in his heart was probably not completely cured, but he still smiled slightly. Standing in the entryway, Yousuke reached out to the door, but he stopped midway.

"… Thank you for everything today."

"Do you resent me for expelling Airi?"

Unlike other students, Yousuke wouldn't let it show, but it wouldn't be strange if he did.

"… For just that, yes. But I believe in you."

While those were his own thoughts that he put into words, he didn't seem to agree with them, so he added:

"… No. I want to believe in you."

If this was blind faith or something like that, I would consider Yousuke's viewpoint to be dangerous. However, there was a definite will deep in his eyes. I believe in you, so please don't betray me—that was his firm request.

"Well then, good night."

I should have been able to relieve at least some of his burden, but I might even have added a new concern to it instead. It would be good if we could use this opportunity to drain the pus out of this wound but… how effective will it end up being?

At any rate, I need to follow through with them, every step of the way.

2

As I'd expected, even on the next day, there was no change to the three vacant seats. Naturally, the turmoil in the classroom continued with no signs of abating. To solve the root of the problem, it was essential to first get the three missing students to come back to school.

"Yo. Wanna go to the toilet with me?"

I was playing with my phone, waiting at my desk for the next class to start when Sudou called out to me.

A rare invitation. He said he wanted to go to the toilet, but his expression was entirely serious. Going to the toilet was an excuse, and he had some other objective beyond that. Just like Yousuke and Kei, he was thinking of starting something through me first.

"Yeah, alright."

I didn't have any reason to refuse, so I got up from my seat and inconspicuously left the classroom to go to the bathroom with him. In situations like this, the convenient location of my seat has come in handy time and time again. However, another student quickly followed us.

"Sudou-kun. Can we talk about something?"

It seemed she had some business with Sudou and was waiting for the moment he left the classroom.

"What is it, Onodera?"

Onodera's words became muddled after she noticed me standing next to him.

“Ah… you were with Ayanokouji-kun. I see, you guys were talking about something?”

At first glance, it seemed like my presence was inconvenient for her. However, it was Sudou who invited me during this break, so this wasn’t by my choice.

“The two of us were heading to the toilet. Is it urgent?”

“Um, what should I do?”

She was hesitating. Was it something she didn’t want me to hear?

“Is it fine if I wait here? I wanted to talk about this as soon as possible.”

Onodera judged that since it was just the bathroom we would be back soon. On the other hand, this time Sudou looked uncomfortable with that. If he did have something to discuss with me, I doubt we would be done in a minute or two.

“Alright, let’s hear it. I’ll make Ayanokouji wait.”

She’d gotten ready to talk to him later so his unexpected response left her bewildered. I sensed some resistance from Onodera, but she began talking anyway, lightly scratching the back of her head as she did so.

“The individual rewards for this year’s sports festival are separated by gender, right? I was thinking that you’d obviously be aiming for first place on the boys’ side. Are you?

“Of course. This sports festival is my biggest chance to shine after all. You didn’t even have to ask,” he replied confidently.

Onodera nodded, satisfied with that strong reply.

“The truth is, I’m also betting on this sports festival. If I get first place among the girls, we’ll be one step closer to Class A after all. There aren’t many chances for us to fight in the field we’re good at, right?”

Her skill in swimming was genuine, and she'd also shown us her ability as a sprinter during last year's sports festival. She had no shortcomings in her physical ability on the OAA and was a student with remarkable talent in sports as a whole. I could see her having the ability to adapt and win in various competitions.

"If it's you, you might get first place. I'm seriously rooting for you."

"Thanks. But, let's say I managed to win a bunch of individual competitions, there's still no guarantee I'll take first place, right?"

"Why not. If you keep taking first place —"

Sudou wasn't entirely wrong in thinking it could be good enough to keep taking first place, but actually, it was still possible to lose from an angle he hadn't considered.

"Because there are a lot of points up for grabs from the team events, right?."

Her expression stiffened again when I added that, but she nodded in agreement.

Onodera seemed to hold some sort of distrust towards me. In the Unanimous Consent Special Exam that was held the other day, I cut off one of my friends from my own group. It wouldn't be strange for some of the students to react that way.

"Yeah, for sure. If there's a group that just kept taking first place in team events, it'd be super bad. But, that being said, it ain't so easy to form teams you know? Suzune said it herself, but if you just throw together five or six people into a team, it might lead to its own problems. Also, I hate to say it, but five or six people coming together to do the team events, how will that go?"

If everyone was on the same level as him, then Sudou could be convinced that a team could work out. However, in reality, some of the students would

drag the others down. So it would be easy to imagine losing the competition due to that. That's what a team event means.

"Yeah. I wasn't thinking of large team events either. But—what about doubles events we would surely win? And, on top of that, a few of those events allow participation from mixed pairs."

With this, Sudou could also begin to guess what Onodera's objective talking to him was.

"If you and I worked together, Sudou-kun, there'd be nothing to be worried about. I'm thinking, if I have to join with someone, I want to choose the best possible partner, you know?"

They'd be an asset to our class, and there would be no harm in them aiming for first place in the boys' side and the girls' side.

"So you wanted me… well, that's possible."

"That's right. Of course, that's only if you don't object to it. Plus, isn't the atmosphere in our class kind of bad right now? Due to Sakura-san's expulsion, Hasebe-san and Wang-san have been absent for a while."

She glanced at me for a moment before quickly turning back to Sudou.

"That's why we have to pull the class together."

Sudou wasn't altogether displeased by the invitation as it came from her recognition of his own abilities, yet he looked apprehensive.

"Am I not good enough?"

"It ain't that. As if I could complain about your abilities, Onodera."

Even though he had full faith in her physical ability, it seemed like Sudou was concerned about something else.

"Do you not want to pair up with anyone other than Horikita-san?"

“Eh? N-no, that’s not…”

She was probably on the money, because her question made him embarrassed.

Forming a pair with the one he liked. Apart from physical ability, that could also certainly be very important to Sudou. Given that Onodera couldn’t participate in swimming events, even if you compared her to Horikita there wasn’t a huge difference between them.

“There’s also Kouenji, right? I don’t wanna admit it, but that dude is better than me.”

“In terms of ability, sure. However, I can’t trust Kouenji-kun. I hate him more than anything, after all.”

Onodera rejected Kouenji outright.

Onodera’s proposal to Sudo was genuine, but I wondered how Sudou would answer.

“If I said no… what would you do?”

“Is there some other capable person in our class that I can trust… Well, I suppose there’s Hirata-kun, but inviting him to pair up with me is kind of… you know? I don’t want to cause any weird misunderstandings.”

If she paired with Yousuke, his extreme popularity with the girls wouldn’t let it end with just a few of them being jealous.

“That’s why, if you reject me, Sudou-kun, I think I’d just have to do whatever I can on my own?”

She wasn’t threatening him, but simply stating the facts. It was easy to imagine her steadily earning points, yet struggling to reach first place in our year.

Hearing Horikita's name had shaken Sudou, but he regained his composure after seeing Onodera in this state. He realized that he was about to turn her down for such a pointless reason.

"… Alright then, Onodera. Let's pair up?"

"Really?"

"Yeah. With our power, let's support our class!"

With that, he extended his arm straight out to shake Onodera's hand.

After staring at his hand, she firmly shook his hand in response.

"Nice to be working with you, Sudou-kun. Let's get both first places at all costs."

Perhaps satisfied with the pact they formed, Onodera returned to the classroom.

"Didn't expect it to turn out this way, but it's for the best, right?"

"I think so. You may have wanted to pair up with Horikita, but it's better to pair up with Onodera, so you can exert 100% of your power without your feelings distracting you."

"… Yeah."

We only had five minutes left, but we headed to the toilet as we'd originally planned.

"Anyway, the thing I wanted to talk about… it's the stuff with Shinohara and Kanji."

"Because of Kushida's leaks?"

"Honestly, their relationship is kinda awkward right now. I don't think that's good."

“Isn’t it funnier to see the two of them break up, though? From your point of view, at least.”

“I was only messing around when I said that. I want their relationship to go well. I mean it.”

I’d asked that question to test him, but he seemed to be genuinely worried about them.

“Unfortunately though, I don’t have much of a relationship with them. There’s nothing in particular I can really do.”

“Can you at least give me some advice?”

“I can’t come up with a plan without talking to them. For the moment, if I can set aside whether what Kushida said was true or not, I’d say they need to lay their feelings bare to one another.”

“Ain’t that dangerous? It might make the situation worse than it is now.”

“I suppose. That’s why you need to have someone on the scene to control the situation. They need someone to lend an ear and hear both of them out, and in case the conversation goes south, calm down the situation.”

“I… I can’t do that, you know?”

“If that’s the case, you have no choice but to get someone who can.”

Instead of giving him the answer, I made him think.

“If Kushida was genuine, wouldn’t she have filled this kind of role?”

“Yeah. Right now she’s no good. If you can’t rely on Kushida, you’ll just have to find someone else.”

It was now simple enough for him to figure it out.

“So, Hirata?”

Even Sudou could think of the right person. He wasn't very close to Yousuke, but this wasn't the time to be saying that.

"Right. I'll bow my head and make him help me."

Sudou and Yousuke may not have a close relationship, but this matter might be a good opportunity to change that.

"Thanks, Ayanokouji."

"I haven't done anything. You thought about it and came up with the answer yourself."

After that, class started again.

3

The same day. Every class—no, every grade was preparing for the Sports Festival in full swing.

It had happened last year as well, but since some of the competitions had already been revealed, the students had started making time to use the grounds or the gymnasium during lunch and practiced as if they were in the real thing. They would want to devote as much time to practice as possible, especially for team events with two or more players.

We had come to the gymnasium to scout out the competition, and it was filled with energetic voices. Each year had a demarcated area they could use somewhat freely, and it looked like the school had even carefully distributed equipment to ensure everyone could practice fairly. It seemed that the second-years would be playing volleyball and table tennis today.

The first thing that jumped out at me was the sheer number of people participating from a particular class. On top of that, they were also intensely passionate. They were shouting, actively critiquing each other's performance and exchanging tips and techniques for the events.

"You can see how serious Class A is about this." Yousuke said, after calmly analyzing them. I was here with him today.

"Right. It's because a pure sports-based class competition isn't Class A's forte."

"Yeah. For better or worse, many of their students have average physical ability, and this time only the best students can win the top prizes, after all."

Because they knew that they were at a disadvantage when it came to overall strength, they were working together to improve their baseline capabilities

as quickly as possible. They must be aiming for events where a bit of practice could give them enough experience to earn points. I couldn't see who was leading them, but whoever it was, they were almost certainly following Sakayanagi's instructions.

There were also students from Ichinose's class and Ryuuen's class, but it looked like they were still fumbling about. On the other hand, there were no students from Horikita's class. I thought maybe one or two people would show up, but even if they *were* to visit in this situation, they would just be standing in the corner, unable to do anything.

"We're not done with the Unanimous Consent Special Exam yet. It's not easy to practice under these circumstances, is it?

"Certainly, there are still grounds for concern. But it's not necessarily all doom and gloom."

I told Yousuke about how Sudou and Onodera had teamed up and were aiming for first place among boys and girls from the second-year. The rare bit of good news made him feel at ease, if only a little.

"If they keep getting first place in both their individual and paired events, that should be enough to get the top spots," I explained.

"If it's those two, they'll have a good chance of winning."

We had high expectations of them, but even so, the two of them alone couldn't carry the class to victory. We urgently needed a system that would allow us to collaborate temporarily, even if it was just a patchwork job.

"Speaking of which, Sudou-kun asked me to meet him after school, before club activities start. Maybe you had a hand in this, Kiyotaka-kun?"

"I haven't done anything. Surely, Sudou thought of it himself and decided to rely on you?"

"It's probably something to do with Shinohara-san, right?"

“Sudou must also have thought that we couldn’t leave it like this.”

“But what about Mii-chan?”

“I’m thinking of taking a shot at that one.”

“*You* will?”

Yousuke would be reluctant if I told him to leave it alone or delegate it to a suitable person. The reason why he was so stuck on Mii-chan in this recent fiasco was probably because he felt like he was responsible for it more than for the other students. Of course, it wasn’t his fault at all, however.

While I was observing, I came to the conclusion that Mii-chan’s was the only case that required a bit of my help.

The fact that I couldn’t use Yousuke as the key was one of the reasons for that.

Chapter 3

Introduction

The last time that I saw Kushida-san was at the end of last week, during the special exam.

One week later, after school on Friday, I still hadn't seen her even once. It wasn't just that. Both Wang-san and Hasebe-san hadn't been coming to school either. The five days from Monday to Friday. It had already been *five* days. During that time, life continued to move on without them.

From my work in the student council and my usual studies, to careful preparations and meetings for the sports festival, there were times where I felt like my knees would buckle and collapse from facing wave after wave of responsibilities.

However, I couldn't afford to fall here. Even though I declared that I would definitely bring her back, I hadn't produced any results yet. I had no right to complain.

There were many times where I wanted to reach out to Ayanokouji-kun, but I always stopped myself. If I sought help, there was a chance he would respond.There was also a chance that he would guide me to the answer I needed. Even so, the current problem was something that I must solve on my own, with my own power.

"That concludes homeroom."

When Chabashira-sensei ended the final homeroom for the day and left the classroom, I quickly followed after her.

“Chabashira-sensei, are you free to talk right now?”

“I don’t mind, but… let’s walk and talk.”

There would be a lot of students leaving their seats to go to the restroom right about now, so we’d stand out in the hallway. Was that why she decided to have us talk on the move?

“It’s the fifth day that Kushida-san, Wang-san, and Hasebe-san have been absent from school.”

“Ah, about that. Two of them are ostensibly still sick; they’ve continued to call in as such. However, they still haven’t been examined at the clinic as they should have. As for Hasebe, she’s consistently said that she would be absent, but she hasn’t told me any details.”

It wasn’t a particularly proper way of taking a leave; its recklessness felt like a sort of retribution against me.

“Are we in a state where we’re continuously receiving severe penalties?”

I probably wouldn’t receive a concrete answer from her, but I tried asking anyway.

“Don’t worry about that. Especially for diligent students like Wang and Kushida, there are rules in place that allow for somewhat prolonged absences. Even with Hasebe, she’s not a problem student, so right now it’s not such a big deal. If they didn’t have good grades or had a track record of bad behavior, it would be a different story.”

“It’s thanks to their usual behavior—is that what you’re saying?”

“Exactly. In addition, there might be healthy students who nonchalantly ditch school, but there also are students who will be down in the dumps for a week due to heartbreak. Distinguishing between the two is difficult. So, we have to make the decision by looking at their grades and how they have behaved in school.”

I could feel my heart easing up just from that explanation.

“Also, the school isn’t *fiendish*. They aren’t plotting to force students to come to school and traumatize them mentally, you know. Anyhow, the three of those haven’t even been late to school before, and they had been taking their classes seriously. They’ve easily earned a reprieve.”

Chabashira explained to me in a gentle tone.She seemed like a different person than normal, almost as if she was hiding something. As rumored by my classmates, it may be true that something changed during the special exam.

“More than anything, the school understands that they conduct harsh special exams.”

I suppose that a simple absence wasn’t out of the ordinary, so they were letting it pass…

Making sure there was no one around us, Chabashira-sensei stopped walking for a moment.

“That said, the time limit is close. If they continue being absent next week, the 100 class points you guys obtained after such desperation will, without mercy, disappear.”

Hidden in her statement was a message: do something about it this weekend. However, could I actually live up to that message? I had only intended to ask about the current situation, but, bit by bit, my weakness began to surface.

“Thank you very much. This was helpful.”

“Wait a minute, Horikita. You look like you still have something you want to say.”

“… Not at all. I can’t trouble you any further.”

“I won’t know if it will trouble me or not until I hear about it. I still have a bit of time left. It’d feel better if you talk about it with someone, wouldn’t it?”

Chabashira-sensei must have seen through my weak mental state. I would be lying if I said I wasn’t hesitant to bring it up, but I built up the courage to speak anyway.

“We gained class points by forcing Sakura-san to drop out. Was it really the right thing to do?”

“Are you regretting your choice?”

“At the time, I believed it was the right decision. But… honestly, I’m wavering now.”

“I want to give you an answer, but there’s nothing I can say.”

“I know. As a teacher, you can’t tell me the answer, right?”

“It’s not that. It’s just that, at this stage, you can’t prove whether or not you were right. Sure, there were students who thought your decision was a bit despotic and self-serving. Those opinions are weighing on you, and you are beginning to feel that you may have been mistaken.”

Her words stung. I had no response.

“However, is it really that important? Nobody is perfect from the beginning, no matter who they may be. We make mistakes on simple arithmetic, learn from it, and move on. I myself have lived a life full of mistakes.”

“You… too?”

“Even when I took the same special exam, that was the case. I couldn’t even figure out whether I was right or wrong before time ran out. You, on the other hand, managed to produce a single answer. That’s something you did well! Nobody can score a 100 without gaining experience first. During that

special exam, you were recognized as a leader and given due authority. In addition, you were prepared to sacrifice someone to protect Kushida. From here on out is where you make everyone recognize that you made the right choice."

My teacher said something befitting of a teacher. She hadn't done much of that up until now, so I was a bit baffled.

"It's fine for you to not aim for a 100 now. After all, your only two choices were to either logically cut off the lowest ranked person on the OAA, or to prioritize your promise and receive a handicap."

"I-Indeed…"

I understood that. I understood that, but I still had doubts.

"Even so—I think I might have lost sight of my surroundings. If I had been more open to opinions, I think I might have been able to reach a more correct answer."

"There will be times when you lose sight of your surroundings. There will also be times when you will doubt if your decision was correct once you cool down."

Still, I didn't have that kind of experience. Frustrated, I unconsciously clenched my hands into a fist.

"Until now, you've only had to make decisions that, in a positive sense, could be considered appropriate, but, in a negative sense, could also be considered just *simple*, right? Of course, that's normal. After all, the uniqueness of this school is what made you seek out a new choice."

"Yes…"

Despite receiving firm advice, I still couldn't reach a suitable answer. Even though I probably had a pitiful expression at the moment, Chabashira-sensei gently came up to me without looking disappointed.

“You fought within the rules the school set, didn’t you?”

“Yes, but I broke my promise and expelled someone other than the traitor.”

“Were you set on protecting Kushida from the start, and the promise was just a lie in order to get assent?”

“No! At the time I really was prepared to expel the traitor… I really was.”

“If that’s the case, then there’s no problem. Sure, keeping your promise is important. However, sometimes, even adults have to go back on their word. I understand that your thinking changed, and you took that action because you realized it would be better if Kushida remained in the class. People are free to make fun of you, disrespect you, or ignore you now. Just as there are people who will follow you, there are also those who will not. Uniting a class of nearly 40 people is no easy task, even for Ryuuen, Sakayanagi, or Ichinose. Even while some students might ostensibly act as yes-men, there’s no telling what they are really thinking on the inside.”

After saying that, Chabashira-sensei gently placed her hand on my shoulder.

“Don’t be afraid of failure. I’m not the kind of adult who won’t accept and won’t forgive a child’s mistakes.”

“Chabashira-sensei, I haven’t failed yet.”

“… I suppose so. But that means that you need to protect that choice you made until the very end.”



She was flustered, but then she once again looked me in the eyes. For a moment, I had no words for her polite, strict, yet heartfelt remark.

“You’ve changed, haven’t you, Chabashira-sensei?”

I didn’t intend to speak of it, but I blurted it out anyway. It was because that was how I honestly felt.

“Is it weird that, after being cold for too long, I’ve now started behaving like a teacher?”

“I was a bit surprised, but it’s not weird.”

“Is that so? Then that’s fine.”

Perhaps she also thought she’d spoken too much, because she cleared her throat and changed the subject.

“What is Ayanokouji doing in regards to Kushida?”

“Ayanokouji-kun? No, he’s not doing anything in particular. If I were to speak frankly, I think he’s simply observing what I’m doing.”

“I see. So he thinks this is something that you should solve yourself?”

“He may just not want to go along with my selfish plans.”

“Hm, I’m not so sure. During the incident with Kushida, he took drastic action. If he didn’t trust you, he probably would have just left you alone.”

“You think pretty highly of Ayanokouji-kun. But I remember you saying that he was the most defective among us.”

“You remember that remark from back then pretty well.”

“He’s more outstanding than the OAA can evaluate.”

“You seem to trust and value him quite a bit more now.”

“He may have a few problems with his personality, but he’s not alone in that… What did you mean when you said that? Or were you mistaken?”

He was, without a doubt, brilliant, and he was more calm and collected than I was. I couldn’t think of any aspect of him that deserved to be mocked as defective.

“There’s no need to take everything I say so seriously. Haven’t you spent far more time with him than I have?”

“Even so, I want to hear your opinion.”

“…Well, my opinion of him hasn’t changed. Rather, I think I’m more certain of my evaluation now.”

He was defective. She was still sure that it was a fact.

“However, it’s too early for you to be worrying about that! After all, there are other pressing problems you need to solve.”

“Yes, you’re right.”

While I was definitely curious about it, I could come back to it later. I had to make Kushida-san, Wang-san, and Hasebe-san come back to school.

“Is Kushida tough to deal with?”

“It’s like I’m punching the air. No matter how many times I go to her room and wait for her, she won’t open her door.”

“That’s a problem.”

Setting aside weekends, she could go to the convenience store or other places as much as she wanted while I was away at school on weekdays. There would be no meaning in waiting for her supplies to run out. Also, even if I tried calling her, her phone wasn’t on.

“I’m just happy that I could hear her moving around near the door.”

“We can’t really say she’s not even moving. That said, if you don’t do something, the situation isn’t going to improve, and it’ll gradually get worse.”

“I understand…”

“If you can’t do anything on your own, you have the option of taking the help of others.”

“A classmate who would happily help me persuade Kushida… that would be someone like Hirata-kun. But right now, asking him for help is out of the question.”

He was currently dealing with Wang-san and mediating for Shinohara-san and the others.

“If it was Hirata, then… no, I’m not sure when it comes to Kushida. If you took an upfront, good-natured, virtuous person to her, I can’t imagine her simply opening the door for him.”

“I somehow understand what you’re trying to say, sensei. She’s not an honest person.”

“Unfortunately, I can’t think of the right person for the job, but it might not be a bad idea to try looking for someone outside of your classmates.”

“However, going to persuade Kushida would mean knowing her true nature. Telling an outsider about that would be a detriment to our class.”

“It’s definitely necessary to balance the pros and cons. Still, it doesn’t mean you absolutely can’t tell anyone about it. For instance, some of us teachers already know about Kushida’s past, and, out of those who don’t, there are probably teachers who would stay quiet if you consulted them. I don’t think it’s that much of a secret.”

Someone who could sway Kushida's feelings… No, even without swaying her feelings, if there was someone who could make some kind of breakthrough…

"It's about time I get going. It may be a bother, but let me say one last thing. What's most important is what you want to do with Kushida. Think hard about that."

What I want to do with Kushida…

"Thank you very much. Thanks to you, I have found my resolve."

I hadn't found the answer yet, but I was once again filled with the energy to try again.

"Think nothing of it. As a teacher, doing at least this much should be the natural thing to do."

After saying that, Chabashira-sensei returned to the staff room. I continued to watch her from the stairs until I could no longer see her back.

1

When I returned from Keyaki Mall after shopping, I saw Ibuki-san standing by the elevator, glaring at the entrance. Ignoring her, I pushed the elevator button, causing her to explode with anger.

“Don’t ignore me!”

She approached me, pressing me for an answer with such vigor that she almost spit at my face. I steeled myself for a long-drawn battle of attrition, but honestly, what was this even about? From how intense she was, I’m sure she’d follow me even if I boarded the elevator now. Forced to stop, I had to watch the invitingly open elevator close and depart.

“Ignore you? Do you have something you need from me?”

“This! This message, what does it mean? Answer me!”

She glared at me and thrust her phone screen into my face. Although the bright light was streaming into my eyes, all I could see was a white glow.

“Are you an idiot? It’s too close, I can’t see anything. Move back a little?”

“Fine! Here!”

She only moved it back a teensy bit, but I could still quickly read what was written with just a glance.

“What a well written message, I’m impressed. Clearly, a very intelligent person must have written it.”

“Don’t toot your own horn! More importantly, what part of this screams *intelligence*?”

“Why, if you read it out loud, you might get it.”

“HUH? ‘If you get expelled because of something that has nothing to do with me, naturally, it will count as a loss against me. You wouldn’t be such an idiot, right?’… Just how is this intelligent? No, forget it, just tell me what it means!”

“You just read it, but you still haven’t understood it?”

“Not at all. I thought about it all week, and I still don’t. What, is that a problem?’

She *hmphed* loudly and crossed her arms. It was a very straightforward piece of advice, and for her to not take it as such, that was unexpected… Well, I would like to believe that it at least had an effect on her subconscious.

“Well, even if I tell you now, there’s no point. And it seems like it wasn’t a problem after all.”

“Haa? What does that mean? Explain it, so I can understand.”

This girl is really slow on the uptake. Could it really be that her athletic and fighting skills are all she has…

“I was giving you a secret strategy to make sure you wouldn’t get expelled. It doesn’t seem like your classmates like you, and if there was a motion that involved expulsion, it could’ve meant trouble for you. But with this, I could spur you on and make sure you stayed here even if you hated it, right?”

“Don’t tell me… You were *worried* about me?”

She was surprised… No, the grimace on her face showed that she was disgusted from the bottom of her heart.

“Don’t put words in my mouth. There are still things I need your help with. Being short on manpower could be a problem, and anyway, if you were

expelled in the previous exam, Ryuuen's class would have gained 100 points with no downsides by removing you. If you had to be expelled, it would be better for me if you left during an exam which has a penalty."

Even after the explanation, it didn't look like she understood even the slightest bit of it.

"Anyway, that's enough. Let's go home."

She was still silently furious, but she let me pass. She kept eyeing me from the side as I once again called the elevator. When I entered the elevator this time, I realized Ibuki-san wasn't following me in.

"Aren't you coming?"

"I don't feel like getting into an elevator with you."

"What a child. We've done this many times before, even as a coincidence."

"I don't want to right now."

"I see. Do as you please."

I pressed the button to close the elevator and headed towards the floor Kushida-san lived on. From here on out, I will have to persevere until she opens her door. As the elevator climbed, I wondered whether I could really get a breakthrough today. If I didn't try different tactics, I don't think anything would change. That being the case, what I intended to do would just be a waste of time.

The elevator reached the destination floor and opened. However, I remained stuck in place, and I didn't take a single step to get out. What should I do, what should I do to be able to have a face to face conversation with Kushida-san… I was just wasting time, and eventually the elevator doors closed. Before I could press the button to open them again, the elevator moved, heading downstairs.

“Really, it’s all useless.”

With my mind wandering like this, even if I managed to get face to face I can’t expect to be able to convince her to return. I felt sorry for wasting the kind words Chabashira-sensei had said to me earlier.

The elevator had returned back to the first floor. The door opened, and Ibuki-san stepped into the elevator. She was looking down at her phone, so she hadn’t noticed me. Finally realizing that she wasn’t alone, she looked up, saw me and exclaimed.

“Wh, why are you here!?”

Honestly, it wasn’t weird for her to be surprised by this.

“Aren’t you getting on?”

“I said so, didn’t I!? You trying to piss me off?”

I shook my head, and then reached for the close button. At that moment, my mind got stuck on Ibuki-san as I saw her avoiding my gaze. At the last moment, I switched to pressing the open button and stared at her intensely. She looked at me, suspicious about the elevator door not closing even after so long.

Maybe the key to the breakthrough lay in an entirely unexpected place. Wasn’t this just the right time to use Chabashira sensei’s advice?

“What is it!’

“… If it’s going to be like this, I think I can use your help.”

“Huh?”

It would be quite the gamble, but she could be exactly what I needed to break this impasse. An unexpected ambush might be the way to make an invisible breakthrough. While I thought it was a harebrained idea, right now I had no choice but to do whatever it took to try it.

“Get on.”

“How many times do I need to tell you that I’m not getting on?”

“Enough already. Get on.”

“… What is with you?”

I ensured that Ibuki-san got on despite her irritation, and then I pressed the close button.

“There is something I need your advice on.”

“HAAAHH? For you? No, no way I’m taking on something like that.”

“But you got on the elevator.”

“You dragged me on!”

“You’re already on, so why not advise me on it too?”

“Uh, that doesn’t make any sense.”

“It won’t hurt you or anything. Anyway, it’s about…”

“Don’t keep going on your own! Just having to give you advice hurts me though?”

While we were going back and forth like that, we reached Kushida-san’s floor. I got off first and turned around towards Ibuki-san, who was still on the elevator.

“Get off. You never know who’s listening here. Just in case.”

“Don’t care. I’m going back. I don’t even understand what’s going on.”

Ibuki pressed the close button to go home, but the elevator didn’t close.

“Look, even the elevator wants you to get off.”

“That’s because you’re keeping it from closing by pressing the button outside!”

“By the way, do you have anything you like? Like anything you think is important?”

“… What does that have to do with this?”

“Just tell me.”

“——nu”

“nu?”

“No, umm, what was it? I can’t really think of anything, strawberries, something like that?

“Wow, there’s an unexpectedly cute side to you… Let’s move on and forget about this conversation.”

“YOU’RE the one one asked! More importantly, enough already, let go of the button.”

As she was getting more and more irritated, I decided to get to the topic. I’d realized that it would be better for her, too, if I quickly let her in on the situation.

“I’m about to go meet Kushida-san.”

“And? You can just go by yourself?”

She was mashing the close button but of course, that was meaningless.

“I can’t just do that. For the past week, I haven’t been able to see her, and she’s not coming to school. Even when I come to her room, she shows no signs of coming out. I want you to drag her out. Do you understand?”

“Huh? Wait, why do I have to do this?”

“You’d be helping me out.”

“Don’t care. I don’t even help my own classmates, so there’s no way I can help your class?”

When I brought this conversation up, I’d already predicted that Ibuki-san wouldn’t immediately be on board. But if there was something in it for her, it was another matter entirely.

The elevator had started emitting a warning beep since the door was open for so long.

“Fine. If that’s the case, I’ll give you a reward if you succeed.”

“Don’t need it. If you think I will work for money you are badly mistaken.”

“Yes, you are right about that. However, my reward will definitely be something that you really want.”

“… I don’t think there’s anything like that, though?”

It wasn’t easy to lure Ibuki-san, but if I used a certain something, her thinking would turn right around.

“At the sports festival, we can freely pick any 5 competitions, right? You are free to choose which competitions you want to participate in, and in which groups. This was a provision to help us clear the 5 required events, or, to put it another way, its main purpose is to allow one to avoid powerful opponents… but one the other hand, it’s also a system that also allows you to pick your opponent.”

Ibuki-san had been unwilling until now, but after that explanation her eyes lit up.

“Knowing you, in order to fight me, you’ve not reserved a spot in any competitions, and are just waiting for me, right? Unfortunately for you, I’m

not going to make my decision until the last moment. Depending on the situation, it's likely that I'd be aiming for the last open slot in the competitions. In other words, you will never get the opportunity to challenge me, the very thing you want and are waiting for."

"… if I help you, you will let me fight you?"

"Yes. I will fight you in one competition of your choice. Of course, for the sake of my class, I won't be holding back, so you won't be winning any points though. If that's fine with you, I'll do it."

"Ha. Isn't that interesting. But I won't be satisfied with just one. At the very least, three. If we have a best of three, I'll help you."

"Three? That's too greedy…"

As the warning signal continued to beep, I pretended to think.

"I won't give up otherwise."

She's not wrong. If we had just one competition, you wouldn't be able to accept the result. I agree with that. That said, with two or four matches there was a chance of a draw. So, from the beginning I was expecting that we would end up on three matches, but if I had started by suggesting that she would probably ask for five matches. If you're okay with three matches, then that was exactly where I wanted to be.

"…… Fine. As you wish, I will compete against you in three matches. Is that alright?"

"Done. You can't back out now."

She got off the elevator after that. I released the button and the elevator door slowly closed.

"Of course. But! You will help me until this situation is resolved."

"Can you tell me clearly what the goal is?"

“Make Kushida-san come to school from Monday. That’s all.”

“*Sounds* easy enough. Wait, why is Kushida taking a break from school a big deal, anyway? Couldn’t she just be unwell? Everyone has days like those.”

Chabashira-sensei did say that Kushida-san’s secret still wasn’t widely known. But the important thing was to not recklessly leak the truth. Keeping that advice in mind, I decided to tell her everything. If Ibuki-san turned out to be the type to leak it to the people around her, that would mean I was as blind as a bat. Even if I was driving myself into a corner, right now I needed a way to break the deadlock.

I told her the details about Kushida-san. Of course, I didn’t try to strangely hide any information. Even Ibuki-san should be well aware of how Kushida-san has been so far. Even so, I explained to her Kushida’s real personality, how she thinks and even the details of how we reached this situation.

While I was talking, Ibuki-san looked uninterested, and she was listening while looking off in some other direction. Normally, someone acting this way would have made me unhappy, but seeing her do it made me feel relieved. Once I had finished explaining why she was absent from school and the current situation, Ibuki-san released an exasperated sigh.

“How pointless.”

She wasn’t particularly interested in Kushida’s true personality or anything, and so she was simply expressing that thought.

“You aren’t surprised, huh. Did you know something?”

“Nothing. But I don’t believe that anyone is that nice of a person. Not Kushida, not Hirata, not even Ichinose. I think anyone who puts on a ‘I’m a nice guy!’ image is guaranteed to have a dark side underneath.”

“That’s an interesting way of looking at it.”

It may be surprisingly accurate in some ways.

“So, do you think highly of Ryuuen-kun then? He doesn’t pretend to be good… or rather, considering what he’s like inside, he isn’t a good person.”

“I hate that more. And on that topic, I’m also beginning to dislike people who seem harmless, like Ayanokouji. Those pieces of shit piss me off!”

With all that, does there even exist a person that Ibuki-san could have a favorable opinion of?

“Well, I don’t hate dragging out someone like that. If anything, it makes me want to ask her how it felt to have her good girl front exposed as fake.”

I might have to stop her from going too far, but I also might need to learn from her how to be that kind of forceful.

“So, Kushida is holed up at home, and I just need to drag her out?”

“Yes.”

With a fair bit of confidence she casually headed to Kushida’s room.

“Do you intend to do it alone?”

“Just shut up and watch.”

If that’s the case, let’s see what she’s got.

When Ibuki-san approached the front of Kushida-san’s door, she suddenly held onto her stomach and bent over.

“…… Ah, it hurts, it HURTS!”

Her screams of agony could be heard throughout the corridor. For a moment, I couldn’t understand what was going on, and I just stared blankly at the scene in front of me.

“M-my stomach suddenly started to hurt… I… I can’t make it to my room…!”

Eh… a stomachache? Don’t tell me, *this* is what you came up with? You are trying to get her to open her door so you can use her toilet? On top of how cliche this is, your acting is disastrously atrocious… To start with, Ibuki-san’s room isn’t even on this floor. And even if her floor was the same, it would definitely be faster to go back to her own room.

“To…Toilet, let me use your toilet!”

Ibuki called Kushida-san as she mashed the doorbell. She kept this on for 10 seconds, but it didn’t look like Kushida-san was going to come out at all.

This was a problem I’ve had since before this case… I wanted to hold my head in my hands because of how badly I’d messed up the choice of personnel here. After the performance continued for another ten or twenty seconds, Ibuki-san got up, put on a straight face and returned to me.

“She isn’t out, is she?

“First of all, I am very sure she is in her room.”

“Really? If that performance didn’t work, that Kushida is a real piece of work.”

“A-ah, yeah.”

She seemed to be serious, so I should refrain from retorting.

I ordered her to follow after me quietly and opened the box that covered the electrical meter of Kushida-san’s room.

“You can see the disk in here, right? If this disk is spinning slowly, then it’s likely that she’s not in there. However, if she *is* in there using her TV or computer, then it should be spinning fast.”

The disk was currently spinning rather quickly.

“With this, you get that there’s a high chance she’s in there, right?”

“That’s the kind of thing a burglar would know…”

“I looked up a lot of things while waiting for her last weekend. You are prohibited from abusing this knowledge.”

Nah, I wouldn’t do that, Ibuki’s cold eyes seemed to say.

“So, have you thought of any other methods? If not, then I might have to bench you――”

“We’ve been going about this the wrong way.”

“Eh?”

“I’m gonna force Kushida out of her room. This will be all or nothing, but that’s fine, right?”

I wanted her to show me her basis for that claim, but after seeing her all revved up I decided to trust her one more time. I took some distance from her, and she once again made her way to the door.

“Hey, Kushida. I’ve heard all about you. The fact that you were deceiving everyone till now was revealed during the exam, was it?”

While I was wondering what she would do, she began berating Kushida. I considered stopping her for a moment, but even if I did that, it would be pointless. Even if I stopped her here, Kushida-san’s probably already heard her.

“Sure serves you right! How does it feel to lose your position as the most popular up until now? Well, if we’re ranking good people, then Ichinose’s probably above you. How’s it feel falling from second?”

Compared to her wooden acting earlier, the method she used to rile Kushida-san up was way better. The most aggravating part of it was probably that she was being told such things by *Ibuki-san* of all people.

However, there was not a sound in response. I suppose such a crude measure wasn't going to work…

Ibuki-san continued speaking in front of the door, her expression unchanged.

"Come on, show me your unsightly face!"

Using the toes of her right foot, she banged the door with considerable force.

"I've got a lot of pent up stress 'cause of Horikita just now. I can't help wanting to vent it."

Ibuki-san's true feelings didn't involve saving Kushida-san in the slightest. She vented those feelings to Kushida-san, who was probably on the other side of the door.

"Kicking the door to someone's room might not be so bad. I kind of understand how Ryuuen feels."

At this point, it seemed like banging the door again and again was for her own sake. After several kicks, a sound came from inside the room. In spite of that, Ibuki went to kick, but then the room's door was suddenly unlocked.

"――You're annoying me, so could you stop it, Ibuki-san?"

Kushida-san appeared, dressed in casual clothes. To think that she would react to Ibuki's violent way of doing things… What was all my effort for this whole past week? I was slightly struck.

"Hey, you came out! I guess you're that kind of person after all."

After learning of Kushida-san's personality in detail, there may have been some things that Ibuki understood better.

"That misunderstanding is irritating, so could you stop?"

“Eh? Is that the case? I think I’m more likable than you with your fake personality.”

“I’ve never thought positively of you even once. Same as Horikita-san over there.”

Seeing that she added “san” to my name, she seems to have regained her composure. Since there was no point in hiding, I went in front of her room without reservation.

“If it’s fine, can we come into your room? I’m tired and fed up with all this waiting.”

“Well, even if I wanted to close the door, it would be pointless.”

Ibuki-san had stuck one foot firmly in the gap between the door, so she couldn’t close it. Kushida stared at the foot Ibuki had slid in and stomped down with all her might.

“Ow!”

She continued grinding her foot on Ibuki’s, but Ibuki showed no sign of pulling her foot out.

“It really isn’t closing, huh.”

“Cut. It. Out!”

As she forcibly opened the door and stepped inside, Kushida-san quickly stepped back and showed us the way in with a straight face.

“Come on in. This may be the first and last time you do so, so take your time.”

It was a loaded way of saying things, but I was already prepared for that much.

It would be simple for Kushida-san to let the current state of affairs continue forever and put the class in a fix. There was no doubt that she'd invited us in because she had already made some sort of decision. This was probably my first and last chance. From a glance, I could see that she kept a tidy room. I got the impression that she was very much more of a clean freak than I was.

"Hmm? Well, well, you sure take care of the place, don't you?"

Ibuki-san looked around the room, commenting with a mix of admiration and surprise. Seeing Ibuki-san like that, Kushida-san responded.

"Your room is probably a mess, with dirty clothes scattered around where you took them off, isn't it?"

"Ngh… y-you haven't even been to my room, how would you know?"

No matter how you looked at it, it was obvious that she'd hit the nail on the head…

"Sit down. I won't be providing any snacks or drinks, but you don't really mind, right?"

"Yes, that's fine."

When she encouraged us to sit down, Ibuki-san and I looked at each other for a moment before taking a good distance between us as we sat. Kushida-san sat on the opposite end with the table between us, making the setup a two on one.

"Well then. You've been causing a racket in front of my room for a long time. What are you after?"

"You already know, don't you? You've stayed here, absent from school for a whole week. It's about that."

"Huh."

Kushida continued after that half-hearted response.

“You expect me to go to school after all that happened? Not that I’m surprised, but you let this girl know about me, too, right? Just something you did out of spite, I suppose.”

“That’s not it. She’s not going to blabber about it to someone else.”

“*Oh?* You trust her?”

“I don’t. It’s just that she’d be hard pressed to find someone to talk to.”

“Oi.”

Ibuki pounded her fist against the table and glared at me, but I ignored her. It was the truth after all.

“Even if that is the case, you sure aren’t thinking about how I feel. I’m hurt.”

“*You* have the right to say that?”

“Even if I don’t, Horikita-san, that’s no reason for you to ignore my feelings.”

She quickly threw back a sharp response.

“Let’s move on from that. I fully understand I may be lacking in some areas, but in the beginning you were the one who came at me with hostility. Isn’t that right, Kushida-san?”

To me, Kushida-san was simply a classmate. However, right from the start until now, she’d seen me as someone who had to be expelled.

“I won’t deny that. But it couldn’t be helped; I just couldn’t stand it.”

“I wonder what I should have done. Even looking back on it now, I can’t think of a clear answer.”

“I get it. I thought about the same thing many times—and then I came to a conclusion. I couldn’t stand Horikita-san being here, so shouldn’t she voluntarily drop out of school for my sake?”

“Could you stop saying ridiculous things? That’s not a conclusion, that’s just absurd.”

“It *was* absurd, wasn’t it? However, that absurdity was the only choice I had.”

Although she was answering my questions, it was definitely hard to call this conversation amicable. However, those must really be Kushida-san’s true feelings. She’d tried to follow the conversation at first, but Ibuki-san’s eyes gradually lost their life.

“Can’t you put all of this behind us and cooperate?”

“I knew you’d say something like that, but don’t make me laugh.”

“You just have that much ability and value.”

“I know.”

She replied immediately, not showing the slightest hint of modesty.

“You sure think a lot of yourself…”

Ibuki mumbled quietly, but Kushida-san continued in response, without reconsidering what she’d said.

“Really? I don’t think so, though.”

“I don’t think so either. I don’t think your abilities are all that great. Wanna throw down?

Saying that, she clenched her fists.

“You’re more of an idiot than I imagined, Ibuki-san. That’s not what ability means, you know? Why don’t you take a look at the OAA? In this school, our ability is determined by how good those grades are. I believe the gap between me and you is larger than you’d think.”

Piqued, Ibuki-san took her up on that and pulled her phone out to check the OAA. And when she saw and compared their Overall Ability scores, her face turned pale and she closed her phone without saying anything.

“I’d like you to put that great strength of yours to use for the sake of our class. If you continue being absent without permission any more than this, you will eventually lose your seat in our class.”

“It’s already lost, though. Well, you may be right. You were prepared for the class’s animosity when you opposed my expulsion, weren’t you? That’s why *you* are the one who’ll be in trouble if I don’t become an asset. I completely get why you’re so desperate to convince me like this.”

Kushida-san should also have been well aware that the class’s situation was in her hands.

“I’ve lost. I have no place where I belong anymore. However, the reason why I stayed quiet at the very end of the Unanimous Consent Special Exam was to hurt you, even if only a little. If I continue to stay absent even going forward, won’t the school punish the class that caused a student to stop going to school? And then the responsibility for that punishment will be yours.”

Indeed, if she continued to stay absent in this manner, then the class would keep taking damage as if we were poisoned. There was always the chance that a special exam would leave her unable to continue this strategy, but Kushida-san would still have carried out her revenge brilliantly.

“You gain nothing from this.”

“It’s a bit late for that. I already have nothing to lose, so isn’t it normal to try to drag you down with me?”

“Huh? That ain’t normal. Don’t get carried away just because your stats on the OAA are a bit good.”

“I invited you inside on a lark, Ibuki-san, and that might’ve been the right choice. You’re funny. If it was just me and Horikita-san, then the conversation would just have been boring. I certainly may have been mistaken for saying ‘normal’. What’s normal for me is definitely abnormal for others, after all.”

“So you admit that you’re abnormal?”

“I’m not satisfied unless I’m number one. I can’t allow things that are inconvenient for me.”

“You make me sick.”

“I can’t help it. I can’t change the way I think. I was born this way.”

Even if people resented her or took their anger out at her, she didn’t mind.

It was even more unsettling than usual to see her so calm, as if she’d attained enlightenment. She was being more difficult than the time she was yelling and exposing her own weakness.

“Until the school forces me to do something, I’m gonna keep skipping class.”

She proclaimed that from here on out she was ready to continue her attack till her dying breath. Kushida-san, who was—in some sense—invincible, disinterestedly explained that to us.

“What are you gonna do?”

“What am I going to do? I have no choice but to continue talking to you like this.”

“No plan, huh? A big difference from Ayanokouji-kun.”

Upon hearing Ayanokouji-kun's name, Ibuki-san's ears perked up.

"I thought I had the advantage, but he never lost his nerve. On the contrary, he made a plan that used it against me. I think he's someone I shouldn't have made an enemy out of."

"He's—that's right. He might have the ability to see many possibilities of how things play out far into the future. I only realized that recently though."

"You're just like me then."

"Right."

After that, a bit of silence ensued.

"You're really an idiot as well, Horikita-san. Things would have been easier if you'd just cut me off."

"I suppose I may be an idiot. It can't be helped if people think my intuition or confidence was baseless. However, I have no doubts in the fact that you are an outstanding student. While your actions against the people who know your past—that is, me and Ayanokouji-kun—have had a negative impact, at the very least, there's no changing the fact that you contributed to our class for the past year and a half."

She maintained her grades at a level where being proud of them wouldn't be embarrassing.

"If causing trouble for the class is truly your top priority, then you may succeed at your revenge by continuing to stay absent like this. But, more importantly, is that all you want?"

"I wonder what you're trying to get at."

"I'm asking if that much is enough to satisfy you."

"It's enough to satisfy me; I don't currently wish for any more than that. No matter how you frame your words to try convince me, it's pointless. I'm not

going to agree to anything.”

‘Convince’. When I heard that word, I felt as if something got lodged in my throat. Indeed, I wanted to make Kushida-san come to school. I wanted it to prove that my choice wasn’t wrong. The person in front of me knew that more than anything. However, that was just for my sake. It was hard to say that it was the most suitable answer for Kushida-san.

“I may have been mistaken.”

“What do you mean?”

“I had come here with the intent to ‘convince’ you. But that’s not it. In the end that was just for my sake and the class’s sake. I wasn’t taking into account how you feel.”

“What? This time do you intend to break down crying out of pity?”

“It’s just that I realized that bringing you to a school that you don’t want to go to is a mistake.”

“If that’s the case, then our conversation is over. If I pull your leg then you’ll naturally fall over. I’d be happy if you suffer through your long school life without me.”

“I’m fine with that. But you’ll end up suffering at the same time.”

“I’ll suffer? What?”

“Because even though you still have a place to return to, you’re going to end up losing it.”

“You started saying some very self-centered things. I already have no place to return to.”

The more I thought about her, the more a certain feeling welled up inside me.

“I get irritated watching you.”

“… Huh?”

“Even if I get close to you, there’s no use since you’re a child. In short, you’ve only made the wrong choices at every turn. I wasn’t going to spill your secret, and I didn’t even know everything, so if you hadn’t tried to expel me it wouldn’t have come to this. And the same goes for Ayanokouji-kun.”

“I told you, didn’t I? That I couldn’t stand it.”

“That’s what makes you a child. Lashing out because you couldn’t stand it… isn’t that the same as being a child?”

The one who was struck by that word first was Ibuki-san, who was listening quietly. Without thinking, she burst out laughing. It must have got to Kushida-san’s nerves because she looked irritated.

“Bear at least that much. You’re already a high schooler, you know? You can’t even just walk over to the classroom? Don’t just lie on the ground throwing a tantrum—c’mon, get up and walk.”

“Ah, you don’t say, Horikita-san. But I’m just a poor girl who’s hurt. If I went to school now, then I’d be disliked by my classmates and things won’t be like before. Taking me to such a painful place is unfair. You’re not getting close to me.”

“I’m not in a position to say things about others, but this is the lamest you’ve ever been.”

“…”

“*My past has already been found out. I can’t keep up my appearance anymore. So I’ll bother everyone.* Your appearance crying in class looked like a child’s, but you really are a child. No, you’re a toddler. I feel like I’ve been dealing with a toddler.”

“Quit mocking me!”

She raised her hand, and swung her hand down towards my cheek without mercy. I calmly grabbed her arm and gripped it with force.

“Of course I’ll want to make fun of you. You trouble me and our class for your own enjoyment. Who else would make that their highest priority other than a toddler?”

“I alone should experience pain, deal with it, and cooperate as part of your class?”

“Don’t make up a convenient interpretation, okay? You have solid abilities. As such, you should use them solely for your own sake. Those around you don’t matter. If you act for your own sake and rise to Class A for your own sake, then that will without a doubt be your achievement. You can do what you want with Class A’s special privileges as you please. If you want to do the same thing, then go somewhere where no one knows your past this time.”

Glaring at me, Kushida-san stopped what she was going to say.

“We only have a year and a half left of school. It shouldn’t be that difficult, right? For the past year and a half, you only showed your classmates your good-person facade. This should be easier than that. Or is that perhaps the extent of your abilities?”

Kushida-san’s rage was transmitted to me through the trembling hand clenched in my grip. However, I followed up with one more point.

“This is the only time I will come to visit you here. The rest is for you to figure out. If you still want to make me your enemy after talking *this* much, then there’s already no remedy—stay a child for the rest of your life.”

“So you’re saying… while I stop here, you will keep moving forward.”

Even without telling her everything, Kushida-san should have been able to see the current situation.

“You will be expelled. I will graduate from Class A and have my dreams fulfilled. That’s a pretty big difference.”

The very prideful Kushida-san imagined the bright future of the person she hated oh-so much and closed her eyes. Looking at school life in terms of our long lifespans, it wouldn’t make up any more than a small percentage.

“Do you really… think that I have a chance to return to school at this point?”

“That depends on you. Are you going to lower that raised fist of yours, or not? Decide.”

Her arm was still filled with strength. With time, she lowered her fist bit by bit.

“I will hear you out, at least. Tell me what you’re planning, Horikita-san.”

After all the twists and turns, Kushida was finally willing to hear what I had to say. But I couldn’t just gloss over everything to make her feel good. I had to give her a plan for her survival and make her accept it.

I built and rebuilt the several hypothetical solutions that existed and arrived at the ideal one.

“After all that, do you want to pretend to be friendly and live your school life――”

“Not at all. Anyway, wouldn’t that be impossible? My classmates have seen my true nature, and nothing’s going to change that fact, right?”

“Indeed. But, to put it another way, you can still pretend to be friendly to people who haven’t seen your true nature, don’t you think?”

Kushida-san appeared thoughtful for just a bit, but then she muttered, "Maybe not?"

She continued, "Until now, only a few people knew my true self, like you or Ayanokouji-kun. That's why I never hesitated to keep up appearances. But now, that number has gone up by an entire class, you know? And it's not just you wise men, there's quite a few idiots and shit people in there."

What she said was very important. But, Ibuki-san reacted before I could say anything.

"What'd you call me!"

Ibuki-san reacted, inflamed by the "idiots and shit people" remark.

"I'm not talking about you, so why do you care?"

"If you can't stay quiet, Ibuki-san, you can just go home?"

"Oh, sure. Then I'm leaving. I take it you'll keep that promise?"

She was about to get up, so I told her what I needed to, just in case.

"No. If you leave now, I'll consider it as you giving up midway and cancel our promise."

"Huuuuh? You're kiddi… Argh, fine, I'm gonna shut up so finish this quickly."

"Promise? That's interesting."

"If she helped me get you back to school, I promised I'd fight her in the Sports Festival. That's it."

I wrapped up the addendum of why Ibuki-san was here at this point.

"Oh, so that's how it is. I was wondering why it was Ibuki-san, but now it's clear."

“As a matter of fact, it was thanks to her that I was able to intrude on your room, so it did have some use.”

Ibuki-san looked like she had quite a few things to say, but she restrained herself. I could tell that she wanted to compete against me, even if it required a lot of patience. That spirit was impressive.

“Back to the main topic, can I take it that it would be painful for you to continue pretending after your true nature has been known?”

“Yes. If there was some sense to it, I wouldn’t mind putting in the effort, but why would I do that if I get nothing out of it?”

Until now, the hope survived that she could continue acting after Ayanokouji-kun and I had been expelled. But it was close to impossible to expel everyone in the class. Back in middle school, Kushida-san destroyed her class to end everything when she was in a similar situation. That was why her plan until now had been to do the same thing once again.

“If you are unwilling, you don’t need to continue treating your classmates as you’ve done so far.”

“Huh?”

It wasn’t just Kushida-san—this was a surprising statement even to Ibuki-san, and so both of them reacted in the same way.

“Even though we have a gag rule in place, we can’t be entirely sure it’ll work. So, we must work from the assumption that to the other classes, Kushida-san is problematic and has a hidden personality.”

But that way Kushida-san would lose half her potential as a weapon. She was good at both sports and academics, but she wasn’t top-class in either. At best, she was just an honor student. She might win over Sakura with just her raw talent, but she lacked any other point of interest.

“Nobody trusts me anymore. I don’t think everyone will be happy with me when I’m like that. Don’t you think?”

“Of course, it won’t be as it was until now. But can you really say you’ve completely lost their trust? What do you think, Ibuki-san?”

“…”

“Answer me, Ibuki-san.”

“Weren’t *you* the one who told me to shut up?”

“I give you permission to speak.”

“On god… Telling me to shut up, telling me to speak—I’m not your henchman or anything, you know?”

“You don’t want to compete with me? If so, just say the word and—”

“Argh, fine!”

Ibuki-san replied, nearly ripping her hair off her head.

“You were overacting as the goody two shoes until now. I don’t believe in anybody being perfect, and, in fact, how you used to be is way more shady to me. If I had to trust either the old you or the new you, maybe I’d pick the new you because you’re more honest this way.”

She quickly blurted out what she was thinking. Since she hadn’t clumsily tried to dress it up, Kushida-san would probably understand it directly.

“Hahaha, that’s an interesting answer. Or should I say, you have a unique way of thought. But not everybody is a weirdo like you, Ibuki-san. In fact, normal people would hate me instead.”

“I agree, she isn’t normal.”

“Oi!”

“But, to some degree or another, everyone has two personas. Ibuki-san has recognized your true nature as acting for yourself first and foremost. And that’s because your true nature will absolutely never change.”

Attempting to change that true nature of hers would be a complete mistake.

“And, if you don’t change your tone or how you speak to others from how it was before, it would be difficult for someone who hasn’t seen your true self for themselves to imagine it. Even if someone explained it to them in words, people have trouble understanding something they’ve not experienced for themselves.”

“What do you mean?”

“Let’s say, hmm. Consider Ichinose Honami-san. She is a good person, even more than you pretended to be. But if someone told you that she is a violent person who uses foul language and desires nothing more than to crush her enemies, would you quickly believe them?”

“…It could be difficult. She seems like a genuinely good person.”

“I have my doubts,” Ibuki-san interjected.

“But those doubts aren’t about Ichinose-san, and more about whether a good person can really exist, right?”

“Well… Sure, maybe it’s hard to understand something without experiencing it for yourself. I only heard about Kushida from what you said, and didn’t actually get that feeling myself.”

“Right? At the very least, Ichinose-san has spent the past year and a half being a good person. Even if someone made a shocking revelation about her to you, you wouldn’t believe it. Let’s say her entire class lined up and told you that she was that kind of person, then, naturally, you would suspect her too. But—even after that—you wouldn’t really see it deep down, would you?”

‘Ichinose-san is violent and uses foul language.’ Even if someone told us that, we wouldn’t truly believe it. We might be on our guard, but until we see that side of her we wouldn’t believe it.

“That thing about not understanding until you experience it, you might be right on that. Even in martial arts, someone could explain a move to you and warn you that it’s dangerous, but you won’t really feel it. But when it hits you for real, then you truly know how powerful it is.”

“Using martial arts as an example, how like you, Ibuki-san.”

“But as long as they still have doubts, I won’t be able to get their full trust.”

“That’s where you show your skills. You have no choice but to act well from now on. At the very least, it is undeniable that your communication skills and ability to maintain the right distance are above most people’s.”

Whether she would be able to get them to trust her from now on was unknown at this point.

“That might be true for the other classes, but what about our classmates? Some people like Shinohara-san, Wang-san and especially Hasebe-san must resent me. Will they work with me?”

“It might be impossible to get everyone on board. But if you just respond with your abilities, you can produce results.”

Just by doing better than average, Kushida-san would render those who couldn’t achieve any more than her unable to complain.

“If their lack of trust in you becomes important, I will help.”

“… Do you think I’ll just take your word for it? You could just betray me.”

“You can have your doubts. I’ll suffer your complaints if you get betrayed.”

Given that she’d already been done and betrayed once, she didn’t have anything to fear in the future. It was entirely up to her whether she chose to

rise to the occasion or not. There was a pause—the longest of the day—and Kushida-san shut her eyes. Then she muttered something I couldn't make out. Finally, having reached a conclusion, she opened her eyes.

"I get it. I, solely for my own sake, will fight for this class and contribute to it for the next year and half. I won't fight for you, nor our classmates. That should be fine?"

"I have no complaints. I'm fine so long as your results are up to the mark."

Kushida-san stood up, and this time it wasn't her fist, but her left hand that she thrust forward.

"It was the other way around that time, wasn't it?"

I'd held out my hand, but she hadn't responded.

"You do know that a left-handed handshake signifies animosity?"

"… Does it? Hm, which hand did I proffer last time?"

"The left."

She responded instantly, as if she remembered it like it was yesterday. That must mean she was well aware of the meaning when she sought a left-handed handshake. I rose, too, and meeting her left hand with my own, shook it.

"It's almost like we're commemorating our animosity."

"Don't you think that suits us better?"

"Perhaps it does."

She squeezed my hand tightly, and I squeezed hers in turn.

"That reminds me. There's something I wanted to do to you, Horikita-san. Is that alright?"

“A request? What is it?”

“It’s—”

With a broad grin, she slowly stretched both her hands towards me. Those hands reached above my body and towards my face. And while I was expecting her to gently caress my cheeks… a sharp pain shot through my left and right cheek.

It took me a second to realize that it was the pain from her pulling my cheeks to her heart’s content.

“Whach are you…!?”

“I *really* hate you, Horikita-san.” She pulled even harder as she said that. “I’ve been so annoyed ever since we met today, and even though we’re now allies you’re still annoying. The thought that this’ll go on *forever* from Monday fills me with such an *insane* amount of stress, so you gotta give me an outlet like this, at least a little!”

She squeezed my cheeks with even more power. It didn’t seem like she was going to ease up soon.

“I-isn’t this enuf?”

“No, no! I’m not even close to satisfied!”

I was going to be gracious and let her have at least a little fun, but she got carried away and wasn’t letting go. If she wasn’t going to stop, I had my own plans. Exactly as she had done, I raised both my hands and pulled her cheeks.

“???”

“I think itsh about chime you stopped?”

I’d acted on the assumption that she’d stop after getting a taste of her own medicine, but…

“Ofofo, can ju keep jour jokes to that silly faish?”

I didn’t relent, and with enough power to tear her cheeks out, I squeezed even tighter with my fingertips. Despite that, Kushida-san didn’t yield an inch, and pulled even harder, with a power beyond what should’ve been possible for her.



So it had become a battle of who could be more stubborn.

"… You guys gonna keep this up until you've ripped each other apart? You look fucking stupid so I'm going home."

Ibuki-san, the only calm person in the room, said as she turned to the entranceway and left.

This battle of stubborness continued for two or three more minutes, and by that time even the pain had begun to numb. We realized that we'd shown each other a really silly sight, and so we both released the other. When I saw that Kushida-san's cheeks had become beet red, I became aware that I probably looked the same.

"… Come to school on Monday."

"You're persistent. Just go home already?"

She pushed my back, almost driving me out of her room, and so I came out into the hallway.

"Honestly…"

I stroked my painful cheeks and turned towards the elevator, where I saw Ibuki-san entering it.

"Wait, were you waiting for me?"

I stepped forward as I said that, but Ibuki-san stuck her tongue out and pressed the button to close the elevator.

"… She sure has the talent to annoy people…"

But I couldn't deny that it was thanks to her that I was able to meet Kushida-san. In the Sports Festival, I must settle scores with her as she'd wanted.

2

Raising my groggy head, I rolled out of bed.

It wasn't like I had a fever or anything, but there was a constant, mild ache. The cause was obvious—it was all this guilt I had for skipping school for five days now. Even though, until now, I had never taken a day off unless I was sick. Racked with guilt, I tried thinking of anything else to get rid of those feelings, but I just couldn't drive them out of my head. If it were possible to get over it just by trying a little, I wouldn't have had to take five days off…

Let's try something different for a change, I thought as I picked up my phone. Leaving numerous messages unread, I tapped on the photos folder and went to the earliest ones I had. As I scrolled through those shots, I started feeling nostalgic. What first stopped my hand was a photo of me just after I'd started school, back when I still didn't have anyone I could call a friend.

It was the first—and only—two-shot I had with Hirata-kun. I still couldn't smile properly, but he was next to me, smiling kindly. Even now, I'm not very good at smiling, but I feel like I have improved a lot since then.

"I miss it…"

School life in Japan, where I was a fish out of water. The first one to help me unravel my nervousness was Hirata-kun.

At that time, I was still unaware that I had fallen in love. I only thought that he was handsome, kind, and a wonderful person. I didn't realize it because I didn't have time for love when I was in China, where academics were very rigorous and competitive. I don't know when exactly I noticed that I was in

love with him, but, from the day I became aware of it, I knew that I could never put it into words.

Because Hirata-kun was popular, and a person like me could never reach him. Even if I did the wrong thing and told him my feelings, it would just bother him. So I kept it to myself and was satisfied with just being by his side.

"—And yet."

Just thinking about it again made me feel embarrassed and scared, and tears started to stream down my face.

"What should I…"

Everyone in class found out that I like Hirata-kun. They definitely realized that I was trying to be next to Hirata-kun back when we were changing seats, didn't they? I don't know what kind of expression I should put on when I go back to school…

After coming to that thought, I was struck by another, different bout of guilt.

When she was expelled, Sakura-san was both kind and harsh to Hasebe-san. It must have been immensely painful for her, to the extent that it would be unfathomable for someone like me. And yet, I had enough on my plate with just myself, and in the hope that the exam would hurry up and end, I pressed the button in support of expulsion.

"I'm the worst…"

I hate myself for being an awful person, and it hurts, it hurts! The insignificant worries of a person like me…

The sight of myself smiling awkwardly bothered me, so I decided to put the phone to sleep, but then I remembered an email I'd received from Ayanokouji-kun on Monday night. How is Ayanokouji-kun feeling right

now, I wonder? Is he still properly going to school after expelling a precious friend with his own hands?

If he *is* going, what kind of… I'd like to meet up in person and talk to him… That was what I was thinking when I scanned what he sent me.

I'd like to meet up in person and talk.

"Ah…"

Ayanokouji-kun's message was connected to what I'd been thinking, as if he'd put my own thoughts into writing. His phone and room numbers were also included, just in case. Would he be able to give me advice?

Apart from Ayanokouji-kun, there were many other people, too, who were worried about me. *Are you okay? You want to talk? You don't need to force yourself, you know?* Although I was grateful for their kind words, I wasn't confident that responding to any of them would lead to a resolution. But if it was Ayanokouji-kun… I wanted him to hear me out, I wanted to hear what he had to say.

"…Let's go… maybe."

It was still only 5:30 PM. A bit early for dinner… I didn't think it was so late that I would be impolite even if I called on him out of the blue. I struggled with it while pacing back and forth in my room for a while, and the clock just kept ticking. I steeled my resolve and decided to go visit Ayanokouji-kun.

I picked up my phone and nervously called him. Five rings, six rings… after hearing ten rings, I was wondering whether I should just hang up when… Ayanokouji-kun answered the call and I got so flustered that the words spilled out of my mouth right away.

"Ahh, um, it's Wang! Uh, is this Ayanokouji-kun?"

"You decided to call me."

Ayanokouji-kun's voice echoed slightly, and I could faintly hear the sound of the shower running.

"…Yes. I haven't been able to leave my room, and I was struggling, but… I felt like I might be able to take that step now… so I was wondering if maybe I could talk to you a little bit…"

"Right now?"

"Is this a bad time…? I'm sorry for calling so suddenly… I am hopeless, aren't I…"

The timing was bad… Maybe it was impossible no matter what I did.

"That's not the case, but could you wait a bit? 30 minutes, no, I'll be ready in 20 minutes," said Ayanokouji-kun, perhaps catching on to how depressed I was.

"Th-thank you very much! I will be there in 20 minutes! Then, if you'll excuse me!"

I was strangely nervous, and, unable to stand it any longer, I hung up immediately.

"Whew… My heart is racing…"

Maybe the fact that I hadn't spoken to anyone for a week had affected me…

I fixed myself up while I waited, and after about 20 minutes, I was done preparing and left my room. The front door felt heavier than usual, and when I opened it—

"Ah, again…"

A plastic bag was placed by my door.

"You came today as well."

There was jelly, tea, sandwiches, and more inside the bag. I'd first noticed it on Monday night when I quietly left my room to go to the convenience store. At first, I thought someone had just left it in the wrong place, but placed inside was a small piece of paper with my room number written on it. However, with no name given, I didn't know who was responsible for these little care packages.

"Ah, there's a salad in there today… but… it's not really my kind of thing…"

A chicken breast salad with lots of protein. Nevertheless, there was a kindness in the fact that the line-up changed a little every day.

"Just who could it be?"

There was nothing else in the plastic bag that might provide a clue, and there wasn't a receipt either. Feeling grateful to nameless-san, I left it at the entrance for now and headed down the stairs to the fourth floor, where Ayanokouji-kun's room was. Going to the floor where the boys' rooms were made me so weirdly nervous…

With such thoughts in my head, I entered the corridor just as the door to someone's room opened. It seemed to be none other than Ayanokouji-kun's room. But the one who came out was—

I wondered who it was for a moment, but it turned out to be Karuizawa-san. Instead of the beautiful ponytail she usually sported, her hair was sleek and straight. And after her came Ayanokouji-kun, dressed casually, making a pair.

Were they perhaps on a date inside his room…? If so, my call must have been incredibly annoying… My mood was about to plummet again, but I couldn't run away after coming this far.

Karuizawa-san quickly checked her surroundings, and so our eyes met.

“Ah, th-this is that ‘speak of the devil’ thingy, right? See you later, Kiyotaka!”

When I nervously took a deep breath, Karuizawa-san also took two deep breaths. Maybe she would say something about Hirata-kun.

“B-bye bye!”



“E-eh?”

I braced myself, but she just said goodbye and walked past me without making eye contact. I called out to stop her as she walked off at a brisk pace.

“Um, Karuizawa-san!”

“W-w-w-what?”

“…I’m sorry for calling Ayanokouji-kun so suddenly… I was disturbing you, wasn’t I…”

“You weren’t, not at all! Really.”

“But…”

“You wanted some advice, right? Kiyotaka said so. He said if he didn’t call for you now, you’d have to build up the courage to get out of your room all over again.”

As I thought, it seemed he was able to figure out my feelings from the other side of the phone. Karuizawa-san stopped walking and came back a little, smiling kindly.

“I think it’s fine for you to feel free and ask for advice. He’s good at talking, and although he can be a bit clumsy with his words at times, I think he’ll give you the answers you’re looking for.”

“—Yes.”

I’d come this far. I had to crush all these useless thoughts or I’d never get back up. I felt like it was all thanks to Karuizawa-san that I could steel myself that much.

“Well then, I’ll be waiting for you next Monday.”

She gave me a pep talk to cheer me on, and, just like that, repeatedly mashed the buttons to call the elevator. However, when she realized that it wouldn't come any time soon, she used the emergency exit stairway to go back instead.

"Thank you very much, Karuizawa-san."

At the very least, she didn't seem to be pissed at me. I always had the impression that she would be scary if I pissed her off, but today's Karuizawa-san exuded a gentle feeling and was very kind! Anyway, I couldn't afford to think about anything unnecessary right now, so I hurried towards Ayanokouji-kun's room.

I pressed the bell and the door opened after about 30 seconds. Ayanokouji-kun was silent after welcoming me in, so I immediately rushed to speak.

"U-um… I got your message, and… uh, I wanted to talk to you a bit…!"

3

Mii-chan arrived almost exactly at the time we'd scheduled. I'd actually wanted to send Kei back to her room a bit earlier, but, even with that, this was still quite abrupt. I feel I should've been given a few more minutes grace, but there was no helping it, as I had to be careful not to let Mii-chan change her mind.

"Feel free to come in."

"Pardon the intrusion…!"

Mii-chan couldn't hide her nervousness, but she showed no sign whatsoever of trying to turn back. Just from this small interaction, I could tell that she was earnestly working hard to get back on her feet. Unlike Kushida and Haruka, she didn't want to stay holed up in her room.

"Want a drink?"

"No, I am all right. Thank you very much for your concern."

She refused politely and sat on the carpet in a reserved manner. I sat opposite her and got the conversation started.

"You came here because of what Kushida exposed about you and Yousuke, right?"

Mii-chan's shoulders jolted upon hearing that name before nodding quietly.

"I would also like to know how the class is doing. At least for those who are hurting much more than I am, like Shinohara-san, Matsushita-san, and Hasebe-san. And also you, Ayanokouji-kun."

I didn’t think she would bring up my name here, but I guess it wasn’t that unexpected. To an outside observer, it seemed like I’d made the difficult decision of discarding a member of my own friend circle.

“There must be a lot of people trying to get in touch with you?”

“… Thankfully, there are many people who are worried about me. But I just can’t look. Because if I do, I will have to reply to them.”

She was saying that she couldn’t bring herself to just read their messages and not send a reply. That being the case, the only thing she could do was not read them in the first place.

“Okay then. There’s no need to put too much thought into it, but if there’s anything you want to ask me, feel free.”

The two of us seldom spoke alone together like this. The conversation didn’t need to be smooth, but if she was too reserved, something that we should have been able to find a solution to might remain unsolved. It would be better if we could open up to each other, even if only a little.

“Then, uh, I’ll feel free… Ah, but before that… Just checking, but were you the one who bought and left all that stuff in front of my room?”

Seeing that I had no idea what she was talking about, Mii-chan continued. Ever since she started skipping school, someone had been delivering food to her once a day. The supplies came with a piece of paper that had only Mii-chan’s room number written on it, and nothing else that could be used to identify whoever the sender was.

I thought of Yousuke for a moment, but I hadn’t heard of anything like that with Kushida or Haruka. If he—who treated all of his classmates equally—was sending supplies to Mii-chan, he would’ve also done so for the others, and he would’ve let me know during one of the few times that we’d met since the exam.

“Sorry, but it wasn’t me, and I don’t know who’s doing it either.”

“Is that so… That person has been so very helpful… I would like to thank them.”

“Whoever it is, it means there are students who are worried about your absence.”

Those sending her messages, those calling her, the one bringing her food. And even if they didn’t contact her, there were plenty of other students around her who were concerned.

After happily nodding just a little, Mii-chan asked me a question.

“You’re still going to school… right?”

If she hadn’t been in contact with anyone outside, it was understandable that she didn’t even know for sure whether I was attending properly. Of course, she wouldn’t expect that the person offering to give her advice would be spending their days moping in bed.

“I went to school this past week as usual.”

“… Didn’t you find it difficult? No, of course it was difficult, but weren’t you reluctant to go to school?”

“You’re asking me generally, right? I’ve never tried to be a leader to my classmates up to now, so anyone would be surprised by how I cornered Kushida or expelled a friend.”

“… Yes. You were different from the Ayanokouji-kun that I knew. It was a bit scary.”

She was straightforward and honest, and candidly expressed her feelings. There was no point talking about friends or the relative merits of our classmates or the order of priorities here. I’d explained all of those during the special exam, and we shouldn’t dig them back up at this point.

“I forced myself to, lying to myself that I’d be a coward if I didn’t. It’s just that nobody noticed it since I was never any good at expressing my emotions in the first place. I think the reason that I can go to school and I’m not skipping is because I feel like it would be uncool to do so.”

“That is something I also thought about a little. I didn’t want everyone to think that—since I was skipping school—I was hurt because what Kushida said was right on the money. Even on Monday morning, I changed into my uniform and went as far as the front door. But I couldn’t take the next step. After taking that first day off, the door gradually got heavier and further away… I mean, it’s all my fault, but…”

Then, as if just remembering, Mii-chan lowered her head.

“I am very sorry for missing a week because of something like this.”

“I wasn’t thinking anything like that. Even coming here must have taken a fair amount of courage. Besides, you haven’t completely given up on going to school, have you?”

“O-of course not! I really want to go to school right away. I know that what I am doing right now is no good. But… I’m embarrassed, and pathetic…”

Regardless of how many students had already noticed those secret feelings of hers, it was understandable that she would be deeply traumatized when exposed publicly like that.

“I can’t say that I understand your situation, or that I can take your place. But, at the very least, our classmates are worried about you.”

“Yes…”

“And it’s a fact that, right now, you’re causing trouble for the class.”

Feeling as if a blade was suddenly held to her throat, her body went stiff and she gulped. *You don’t need to worry. We’ll wait as long as you need*. It would be easy to list off kind words that were pleasant to hear, but it would

only have the effect of delaying her return. From an outsider's perspective, this may look heavy handed, but it would allow me to step in and open up her heart.

"However, fortunately, Kushida and Haruka are also skipping school right now, so your absence has taken the back seat. But who knows about next week? What would happen if those two came to school and you were the only one who stayed back? You know, don't you?"

Imagining a situation where you were left behind was something even an elementary school student could do.

She nodded while her arms trembled slightly, her fear rising. I was going to recalibrate if my prodding was too much for her, but, surprisingly, there were no signs of danger. She was petite and had a timid disposition, but I judged that her core was relatively strong, and she would not fold easily.

"You can just come to school, a nonchalant look on your face. You don't have to tell Yousuke anything special."

"But… I, um… sit in front of Hirata-kun… we'll be so close…"

"Come to think of it, during the seat change, you went for the seat right in front of the unpopular middle seat before anyone else. Was that because you were thinking that Yousuke would take the seat behind it?"

"Ugh…!"

Her reaction was so obvious she didn't have to tell me I was right.

"As expected. You've been observing… I mean, you understand Yousuke very well."

"Urghh, so embarrassing…"

Hugging her legs, she shook her head from side to side. It seemed that her shame was the bigger problem.

“H-has Hirata-kun… said anything about me…?”

She personally took the first step to find out about the part she’d been most anxious about this whole time. But her face was still hidden behind her knees, and I couldn’t peek at her expression.

“Naturally, he’s worried about you. Much, much more than about Kushida and Haruka.”

“…That’s… because he finds me to be a nuisance after all… isn’t it?”

Since he was directly involved, it was natural that Yousuke would be more concerned about her issue than the others.

“It’s not that he thinks you’re a nuisance. On the contrary, he feels apologetic since he thinks he’s the reason why you’re skipping school.”

“That’s… but Hirata-kun did nothing wrong…!”

“I know that. But I’m sure you know very well that he’s just that kind of guy. From well before I did.”

He was able to rejoice in someone else’s delight as if it were his own. On the other hand, if someone was unhappy, he would empathize with them and also feel unhappy. That was the kind of personality he had. Because Mii-chan was holed up in her room, Yousuke was also suffering. Getting her to understand that was the most effective and important thing to get her to push through her current situation.

Mii-chan slowly looked up, her eyes a little bit red, but she still lowered the knee she was hugging without showing any tears.

“It’s not like I never thought about it. That maybe Hirata-kun was suffering because of me. But I decided I wouldn’t prioritize myself…”

It appeared that there was no need for me to tell her everything from the ground up—just providing a trigger would be enough. Looking at her as a

second-year high school student, you could say that Mii-chan was almost complete.

“You look a little different from a moment ago.”

“Thank you very much. I feel much more at ease after talking to you about all this. It is all thanks to you, Ayanokouji-kun.”

“It’s no big deal. I just happened to be there by chance when you got back to your feet, nothing more.”

“That is not true. It is because I thought that if I met you, I would be able to solve my problem.” She answered firmly and followed with a very deep bow. “I—I will definitely go to school properly on Monday.”

“I know. But when you really catch a cold, it’s better to just get some rest.”

“No. Just for Monday, I’ll go even if I have to crawl.”

I felt like that may be a little too much of a pointless endeavor, but it was good that she was that spirited.

“The other thing that I’m concerned about is the person dropping off food for me. I let them buy quite a lot of food for me over those five days… I think the total probably comes close to 10,000 points.”

If it was just one person behind it, it could indeed have been quite expensive.

She tried to repeatedly thank me again on the way out, so I drove her out quickly and sent her home.

“That must be the result of her parents’ education. It’s a bit much, though.”

Even though we were classmates, she was too polite. That was Mii-chan’s strong point, however.

One problem has been solved. I hadn't been able to finish cleaning my room, so maybe I should do that now. The number of people visiting my room had increased of late, so I couldn't afford to be complacent. Horikita, Yousuke, or other students could visit at any time.

I quickly resumed my cleaning, but shortly after that the doorbell rang once again. I quickly checked my phone, but there were no notifications from Kei or any other friends messaging me.

An unannounced visitor, huh… What unpleasant timing. I'll try to be silent for a while. Depending on the situation, I had the option of pretending to be out…

However, after 30 seconds or so, the doorbell rang again. It was evening, and after turning the light in my room off, I opened the peephole and looked into the hallway while hiding my presence. Standing there now was—in a sense—the last person I wanted to see; first-year student Amasawa Ichika.

Come to think of it, something similar happened a while back. I thought back to that day—I had a visitor at a bad time, when I least wanted someone to show up. Seeing that she was wearing her uniform even though it was Saturday, I wondered if she'd been by the school. Should I think of the visit as purposeful, or her simply dropping by? Given what happened last time, I couldn't help but suspect something contrived this time as well.

It was obvious that she'd called on me after already inferring that I was inside. In the meantime, the doorbell rang for the third time.

"Hiya Senpaaii. I came to hang out!" Amasawa called out in a sweet voice when I still refused to respond.

"Sorry, but I'm busy right now. Can we do this tomorrow?"

"That won't do~! I heard you brought a girl home and were doing something naughty, Senpai, so I've come to investigate. If you don't open up, we'll have a problem!"

Speaking in a voice so loud that it echoed down the hallway, she tried to force me to open the door. If I let her keep yelling unchecked like this, my neighbors would eventually hear the commotion. Left with no other choice, I decided to open the door and face Amasawa.

“Where did you hear that I brought a girl home?”

“The source of the information is me~!”

“What an utterly unreliable source.”

“That isn’t true! You brought both Karuizawa-senpai and Wang-senpai home today, didn’t you?”

It wasn’t mere intuition. She didn’t hesitate to name both visitors. Even if she could reasonably guess that Kei had come by, that wasn’t the case with Mii-chan. It was clear that she was aware of my movements.

“Ah, I will say it first, but I haven’t set up any bugs in your room anything, ’kay? And it seems like the school is thorough with its inspections.”

Certainly, it wouldn’t be possible to purchase such a dangerous thing by mail order or the like. But there was a method to obtain them available only to Amasawa.

“If it’s you, with your connection to Tsukishiro, it wouldn’t be much of a surprise if you had one or two, though.”

Even after I pointed that out, she continued scouring my room, her wide grin never breaking.

“For now, could you let me in? Excuse me~”

Amasawa kicked off her shoes and energetically stepped into my room before I could give permission. Then—without restraint—she started energetically looking around the room…

“What are you doing?”

“Eh? Nothing c’mon, I’m just checking a bit.”

I’d like to get an answer as to *why* she needed to check my room. Amasawa, who continued rummaging without hesitation, turned her attention towards the bed and approached it.

“You’re wondering how I knew about Wang-senpai, aren’t you? Did I just happen to see her leave by chance? Or did I know about it through some other method?”

“Did you come over just to brag about your information network?”

She immediately agreed without even attempting to deny it, and then she reached out to the bed. While fixing the wrinkles in the sheets, her fingertips covered every nook and cranny, searching for something. I sat down on the carpet and observed Amasawa, who I was sure would continue her examination until she was satisfied.

“Your girlfriend has long hair, doesn’t she? That means you like girls with long hair, right? That’s why I’m also growing mine out little by little.”

She kept her hands and eyes moving while she talked about her hair situation that I never asked about. I couldn’t force her to stop, so I was reluctantly watching over her when she suddenly stopped moving. She then pinched something from the vicinity of the pillow between her index finger and thumb and lifted it up.

“What’s this~?”

She triumphantly held up a single strand of sparkling, golden hair.

“It must be Kei’s. She comes to hang out often these days.”

“I’m sure that’s true, but what does it mean for it to be by the pillow?”

“I can think of various reasons, but do I have to list them one by one?”

“No, no. You don’t really have to, but~”

She then got down on her hands and knees, turned her eyes to the floor, and started searching for something like a forensic scientist. I don't know what she's looking for, but I doubt she'll be able to find it.

"Did the White Room also teach you how to ransack people's rooms?"

When I asked a question about the White Room, Amasawa stopped where she was.

"Don't you have any doubts, Senpai? About why we—who were sent to this school to get you expelled—haven't laid a hand on you and just integrated ourselves into daily life, even though it's the second semester now?"

"At the very least, it seems like *you* have been expelled from the White Room's team, and branded as unnecessary."

"I won't deny that, but then what do you think about the others?"

"I'm not really interested."

"Well, I guess that's right. If you stay vigilant, you won't do anything careless~"

"I recommend you stop worrying about me, and just enjoy your school life."

"I agree! I was also thinking I should do that…"

After a slight pause, Amasawa continued her search. With her back to me and her butt sticking out, I caught a glimpse of her underwear due to the short length of her skirt. There was no way she was unaware of it, but she continued to crawl along the floor as if she hadn't noticed. Slipping her head under the bed, her underwear was exposed even more.

"Staring at my panties like that, how lewd, Senpai!"

“Sorry, but rather than looking at your underwear, I’m more wary of what you will do to me if I let you out of my sight.”

With me keeping my eyes fixed on Amasawa, she pulled her face out from under the bed and looked back at me. Clad in a mature aura that made it hard to believe she was a year younger, Amasawa approached me, still crawling on her knees.

“I think they have started to go off the rails, confusing means with ends. They are more focused on driving you to expulsion than returning to the White Room.”

She murmured at close range, only a few centimeters separating our lips. A sweet scent reached my nostrils.

“What an annoying story.”

“For you, Senpai, yes. So I’ve been thinking these past few days. Wouldn’t it be fine to just tell you who it is, and let you send them to the next world?”

“Don’t get *me* sent to the next world.”

“Ahahaha, so funny.”

It wasn’t funny at all.

“What will you do? Would you like me to tell you their name?”

Amasawa moved another centimeter closer, and waited for my response.

“I’m grateful for the proposition. But I’ll pass.”

“Is it because you’re not confident you will win after hearing the name?”

“If their identity was revealed unexpectedly, you would be the first to be suspected. How would that end?”

“Of course, they would probably switch targets to me.”

“There’s no need to unsettle your school life just so I can find out their identity.”

If she were to stand in my way as an enemy, I would show no mercy, but Amasawa had shown no sign of that so far.

“You are very kind, aren’t you, Senpai?” Besides, trusting her too much would also be a problem. If they were acting with multiple strategies in hand, I couldn’t completely deny the possibility that Amasawa’s proposal was also a trap. “I’ve been rejected, so I’ll go home.”

“Did you come all the way to my room just to tell me that? Or was the search your main purpose?”

“Now which could it be?”

Laughing like a little devil, Amasawa quickly went to head for the front door when her eyes turned to the hardly filled garbage bag in the kitchen.

“I’ve visited your room a few times already, but I see that you are taking out the trash even though there is a lot less of it today. I thought you were the type to only throw it away after the bag was full to the brim.”

“It’s just that there’s so much food waste from vegetables and fish that I feel reluctant to leave it until next week.”

“If that’s the case, should I take the trash out with me on my way home?”

“Sorry, but taking out the trash before 8 PM is prohibited.”

“You follow all the rules, huh.”

Amasawa’s visit was unexpected, but one mystery had been solved.

“I see part of what you came here to do. You came to visit to make your proposition. And the reason why you searched every inch of my room was because you were on the lookout to see if anyone else was listening in.”

Even her act of trying to search for something private about me was all done as a precaution. Amasawa was vigilant in case the White Room student had already set up a trick.

“Senpai. I’m sure that since it’s you, you’ll be fine, but—nevertheless—if I drop out of school, please know that something even you wouldn’t expect is happening.”

Amasawa left me with those words on her way out of my room. I checked my phone in case there had been any changes and a message came in from Akito.

Haruka will be coming to school from Monday next week.

For the time being, there was some good news. As someone from the same group, he must have succeeded in persuading Haruka. The problem was that this wasn’t sent in the group chat with all the members of the Ayanokouji group. After staring at the screen for a moment, I received a new message.

Could you quietly watch over Haruka for a while?

The text itself was plain, but the emphasis was on the word *quietly.* She would go to school, but she didn’t want to talk to me. That being the case, if I spoke to her carelessly, there was a risk she would start skipping again—that must be what he meant. His reasoning was simple enough to understand. If she was willing to come back, I had no objections at all.

Got it. I’ll pay close attention.

That helps. I hope we can go back to how we were.

For a little while after that, I received several texts from Akito that were almost encouraging, and when the timing was right, ended our chat.

“That’s one problem solved.”

However, this solution was not a true solution. It was best to just see it as a temporary return for Haruka.

After those hectic few hours came to an end, I felt far more fatigued than usual.

“Let’s go to bed early today.”

But I absolutely shouldn’t forget to take out the trash, though.

4

It was Monday again. Saturday turned out to be a big day, as I found out directly from Mii-chan and indirectly from Haruka via Akito that they were willing to start going to school again. But there was no guarantee that either of them would come to school, and now it was up to the strength of their wills.

As for Kushida, I hadn't received a single message from Horikita regarding her as of this morning. If she *were* to come to class, I had no idea how both she and the rest of the class would react.

I reached the class at my usual time, took my seat and waited for the three of them to come to class.

After about a quarter of the class had come, the arrival of one person initially surprised the girls, but they then welcomed her with smiles. Mii-chan hesitantly entered the class.

"G-good… Morning…"

She raised her head cautiously, ready and expecting to be teased. Those worries vanished when the girls warmly welcomed her without touching that topic at all.

"Morning, Mii-chan!"

"M-morning, Hirata-kun."

And this boy, too, welcomed Mii-chan with a smile that hadn't changed one bit. At this time, I didn't know if a way forward had opened up for Mii-chan's love. But even if it hadn't started, it certainly hadn't ended either. It

was entirely within reason that, as they continued their school lives, there would be a watershed moment for the both of them.

After a while, Mii-chan still seemed slightly nervous, but the girls stuck with her and happily started chatting about what had happened at school last week.

And then, when most of our classmates had come, Haruka appeared. Akito was attending her by her side, and she seemed like she'd run off at any moment. In order to keep that from happening, he accompanied her to her seat. Keisei hesitated just a bit, but eventually he steeled himself, approached her seat and called out to her. When I'd changed seats, I never thought I'd be happy I wasn't close to them.

Haruka glanced at me for a moment, but she quickly turned away and looked at her phone instead. After they saw that for themselves, Akito and Keisei said a couple of words and went back to their seats.

Mii-chan and Haruka had come to school. Both of them had friends who came to support them as they were suffering. For Mii-chan, it was many girls, and for Haruka it was Akito and Keisei. Even if they were few, she had people she could call close friends.

For now, we could assume that we'd dodged a major punishment from the school. However, Kushida was still left. What about her?

When there were only three minutes left for homeroom to start, Horikita entered the class alone, a stiff expression on her face. She glanced at Kushida's seat once, took her own seat and stared directly at the board. Since she wasn't in the lobby today, I thought she might've come through, but I guess it didn't work out. Shinohara and some portion of the class were possibly getting the same idea as they looked at her from behind.

Before long, the bell rang and it was time for homeroom. Every seat except Kushida's was occupied when Chabashira-sensei entered the classroom.

“Looks like the two of you are feeling better. I suppose it was just a long summer cold, but take care of your health from now on.”

She gave them a light warning, but didn’t scold them harshly when she confirmed their attendance.

“So Kushida is absent today. I haven’t heard from her either—”

At that moment, I heard the classroom door behind me slide open. The entrant was panting slightly, but they quickly recovered.

“I’m sorry, I’m late.”

Kushida entered the class, her voice calm.

“This is the first time you’re late, Kushida. You were absent for a long time, are you feeling okay now?”

“Yes. I will take care of myself moving forward.”

She answered smoothly, completely unfazed, and took her own seat. She didn’t speak to anybody and kept her gaze to the front of the class. The classroom had tensed up immediately, but they couldn’t carelessly speak to each other so the silence continued.

“I’m sure a lot has happened, but after a week everyone’s back together.” The class was still unstable, and Chabashira-sensei understood that, but she still nodded with satisfaction. “The Sports Festival is just around the corner. I am expecting all of you to make great strides and participate well.”

Homeroom ended after that, and the class immediately erupted. Needless to say, it was the effect of Kushida coming back to school. Every student looked at Kushida as if she was a tumor. Would she continue to maintain her silence, or would she put on her usual smile? Or maybe, would she bare her fangs again? For now, I quietly got up from my seat, intending to go out into the hallway.

The door was closed, so I opened it just a bit. It wouldn't do if our internal matters were to leak to the other classes. So I'd thought, but—

I'm keeping watch. Don't worry.

I got that message on my phone. I poked my head out of the door, and after spotting me, Chabashira-sensei nodded once in response. After confirming that, I closed the door so nobody would notice. Chabashira-sensei was covering for us, doing all she could as a teacher.

Nobody moved, as the situation became one where anything could happen. Horikita was just about to pull her chair when Kushida preempted her and got up. That move of hers could be seen as a threat, "Don't stick your nose here."

The first person Kushida went to was Mii-chan, whose seat was close to hers. At long last, Mii-chan had returned to school, but now she was frozen like a deer in headlights.

"I heard from Horikita-san that you've been absent because of me."

""'Um, er, erm…"

"Do you hate me?"

"N-No, it's not like that—"

"It isn't as if you have to like me, Wang-san. I can't change the fact that I ended up exposing your secret to everyone, and I don't intend to get along with you either. Well, not that I needed to say that, I suppose."

I don't intend to get along with you.

While her tone itself was gentle, her intense statement made Mii-chan stiffen up even more. The many students watching Kushida grew doubtful, unhappy and anxious of her. Normally, that alone would've been enough to shake someone, but it did not affect Kushida in the slightest.

“I’m not going to say you should understand what I was feeling at that time, but that was my only choice back then. I apologize for making you a target of that, Wang-san.”

She bowed deeply after saying that. I very strongly got the impression that these weren’t her true feelings, and she was only doing this out of a sense of obligation, but at least she didn’t seem malicious.

“Shinohara-san, Matsushita-san and the others, I’m sorry I bothered you too. Looks like you’ve managed to patch things up.”

Now that she mentioned it, Shinohara’s and Matsushita’s groups were close now. Over the weekend, Yousuke, Sudou and the rest must’ve worked to bring them together again.

“You think an apology is enough?”

Shinohara shot back a rather rough reply, keeping Kushida at bay.

“I don’t think so, but we can’t start without one at least, can we?”

“That’s… anyway, is that how you apologize?”

“Who knows? At the very least, this is who I really am.”

The facade she had maintained until now, Kushida the Angel, did not exist any more. That fact alone, and the associated tension, should’ve gotten through loud and clear to the entire class.

“For the time being, I’m planning to continue to maintain the facade I had until now to some extent. That way, depending on the circumstances, I can even gather information from the other classes. But if any of you in the class are going to stand in my way while I do that, I’m fine with not doing it too.”

It didn’t matter how much Kushida tried to keep up appearances—if people from inside the class interfered, she wouldn’t be able to build connections.

“I’ll leave it to you all to decide whether or not I should use the arsenal I’ve built up.”

If Kushida was the kind of girl who cherished her friends and was afraid of being alone, secluding her would be a way of getting back at her. But Kushida wasn’t being passive, and instead she showed an aggressive attitude.

“And if anybody comes at me with hostility, I won’t show any mercy, no matter who they are. I’ve only exposed a small portion of your secrets during the Special Exam. I’m sure many other people have things they want to keep secret, right?”

She dispassionately muttered, directing her threat to no one in particular but to the entire class.

“But I promise you just one thing. Unless I fall, I won’t even try to expose any other secrets. I’m not doing it for the class, I’m doing it for myself. So that I can graduate in Class A. It’s my final line of defense, so that I don’t lose my value as myself.”

Since she was resented, distrusted and disliked by her classmates, depending on circumstances, she could end up being on the side that gets thrown away. To keep that from happening, she wasn’t going to reveal any more secrets, but if someone stabbed her in the back she wouldn’t show them any mercy.

She told us how she would protect herself and, at the same time, promised to contribute to the class. Kushida Kikyou would easily be in the top tier in terms of overall status. At the very least, in academic or physical subjects, she wouldn’t hold the class back.

“Hasebe-san. Are you okay with that?”

Kushida tried speaking to Haruka, who hadn’t moved an inch from her seat and hadn’t even looked at her. But Haruka didn’t respond, and continued staring out of the window.

5

Ever since last week, my daily life started to change significantly. The Ayanokouji group hasn't met even once. Even today, with Haruka having come to school, there hasn't been any change from – no, return from that fact.

Now that the meetings that felt natural before had stopped, the way I spend time at school has changed completely. During our ten-minute breaks, I would either spend time by myself or talk with Kei. Sometimes, I might chat with some classmates like Sudou or Matsushita, but my chances to talk with Akito or Keisei have clearly diminished.

Though this lifestyle felt off at first, my body slowly began to accept and get used to it. I go through the same cycle during our afternoon breaks, but if Kei goes to eat with her friends or something like that I head to the library. That remained the break where I could rest alone. However, it seems that Hiyori hasn't been coming to the library recently, so it's a bit of a shame that we haven't been able to discuss any books.

In addition, the flow of this chain of events continued even after school. As for today, Kei had already messaged me that she'd hang out with her friends and go home, so I had no special plans. If I thoughtlessly lingered around school, I'd add onto Haruka's current emotional burden, so I decided to quickly head back to the dorm. However, an unexpected development occurred when someone saw me doing that.

"Kiyopon, do you have some time?"

I hadn't expected Haruka to make contact with me, but she approached me as I was in the hallway trying to leave. Her voice contained a forcefulness that showed she didn't actually care whether or not I had time. Her objective in coming to school for the first time in a week was probably to

make contact with me in a public location. Without even looking back to check her expression, I answered frankly.

“If it’s necessary, I’ll make time.”

To feel her out, I tried to come off as if I had plans, but…

“Then make some. That’s fine, right?” She showed no sign of holding back that forcefulness in her voice. “I already talked to Horikita-san. I’ll go ahead and wait at the cafe in Keyaki Mall.”

Saying only those words, Haruka left the classroom. Immediately after, Akito came this way as if following after Haruka.

“Was she always intending on coming to school to talk to me?” I said.

“I’m not sure… this is my first time hearing of it. That’s why I’m not sure what she wants to talk about. But, depending on how it goes, I don’t think I’ll be able to be on your side.”

Akito apologized, although I would be troubled if he *wasn’t* there for Haruka as her ally.

“That’s fine.”

Leaving the conversation short enough to not draw suspicion, Akito as well as Keisei left the classroom. I suppose she has gathered all the members of the Ayanokouji Group and called Horikita as well. Of course, it’s certain that our discussion would be about Airi’s expulsion. Horikita waited for those three to leave before she approached me.

“I checked if she’d be fine with just me, but she said you were absolutely essential and didn’t listen to me at all.”

She was taking care to try and solve the problem by herself, but well, this time the circumstances were different.

We left the classroom together and headed to the cafe Haruka had specified. Before we went into a heavy conversation, I decided to wrap up something I had on my mind.

“You seemed to have succeeded at bringing Kushida back to school. I’m honestly impressed.”

“She has technically returned for the time being. However, there’s still many things that are uncertain. Things won’t be the same as before.”

“But still, we couldn’t wish for a better development than that at this point.”

Even her style of speaking had changed drastically, but it’s safe to say that Kushida had come back with nearly the best answer to make the class run smoothly from now on. Horikita’s advice was without a doubt part of how she reached that answer. The tough part would be keeping to a minimum the information leaking to the other classes. Even if it became widely known someday, it was entirely possible that the passage of time would have faded some of it.

“How did you convince her? I can’t imagine her becoming obedient from just a good plan.”

While the eventual destination was the declaration she’d made today, there must have been twists and turns before she got there. If anything, that was what I was interested in, but Horikita’s facial expression looked complicated.

“I treated her like a kid unbecoming of her age. To the point where I don’t want to talk about it.”

Seeing that she avoided talking about any specifics, I guess she really did stuff she didn’t want to talk about. It didn’t seem like she’d answer even if I pressed the matter harder, so I had no choice but to give up.

“However, given who you were dealing with, that may have been the right choice.”

Perhaps recalling some detail, she rubbed her cheek with her left hand and answered.

“Anyway, it took a week but we’ve managed to gather everyone in the class.”

“Speaking of which, it seems the trouble with the girls has also calmed down.”

Yousuke said that he would rely on Horikita, so she without a doubt took part in that as well.

“For the matter with Shinohara-san and the others, Hirata-kun took the lead and brought them all to Keyaki Mall on Sunday.”

“You were present as well?”

I pretended I didn’t know anything about it and responded as if I never imagined it could happen.

“Yes. On top of that, they agreed to let the bad-mouthing be water under the bridge. Shinohara-san was against it for a while, but Ike-kun calming her down was a big help.” Even from Horikita’s way of speaking, I can tell that Ike is fulfilling his role as a boyfriend. She continued, “A lot of students sure are growing up while we’re not looking.”

“You don’t seem happy about it.”

“I think I’m happy. It’s just that because of that, I feel pathetic in comparison. When I think about whether I’ve managed to grow myself… I feel anxious.”

It’s easy to appraise others, but judging oneself is difficult. If you want to be optimistic, you can judge yourself generously. If you want to be strict, you can judge yourself harshly.

“Someday, a third party would be able to give you that answer.”

“… Right.”

The first thing is to pour her energy into getting the class back on its feet, since her own evaluation will come on its own after that.

“We couldn’t get a hold of Wan-san, but it looks like you helped her out. Thanks.”

“I just gave her a bit of advice. Even if I hadn’t done anything, someone would have helped her out.”

“Even if it was just one day, you’re to thank for her faster return. This time, too, I’ve been saved by many people. I feel like the fact that I can’t do anything on my own was once again thrown at my face.”

What she was saying was depressing, but if anything her tone was cheerful.

“Oh yeah. I want you to send a message to Student Council President Nagumo.”

“Me? You’re constantly using me as the middleman. Well, it’s fine. What should I tell him?”

“Just tell him that I accept his proposal.”

“… Accept his proposal?”

“He’ll understand if you relay just that.”

“Alright. I’ll be going to the student council room after this, so I’ll tell him what you just told me.”

I’m still deciding if I’m going to participate in this year’s Sports Festival. But the one week time limit has already passed, so I must at least reply to him that I’ve accepted. If I don’t challenge Nagumo to some kind of duel sometime, he probably won’t be satisfied.

“What remains is the problem with Hasebe-san. I honestly can’t tell what we’re going to talk about – I can’t read her.”

“From how she was today, I wouldn’t be surprised no matter what she throws at us.”

“It does seem better to not be naive about this.”

Mii-chan and Kushida overcame their challenges and came to school. However, Haruka is different. It’s likely that from here on out, she will become an obstacle and stand in our way.

“While I was waiting to meet with Kushida-san, I also checked on Miyake-kun and Yukimura-kun many times.” So she was watching out for not just Shinohara and the others, but also the members of the Ayanokouji group. “The one who bore the most difficult feelings during the special exam was Hasebe-san. It’s necessary to follow up with her.” Despite that, the reason why Horikita didn’t look so cheerful as she walked beside me was probably that she didn’t achieve anything out of it. “We met at her doorway, but we couldn’t talk about anything. Miyake-kun had asked me to let her be, so I’d kept an eye on things for the past week.”

Is she talking about today? Haruka coming to school must have been outside of expectations for Horikita as well.

“In the end, Akito succeeded at convincing her and managed to bring her with him to school – and that’s the end of that chapter.” I said.

“It would be good if that was it… but that’s not the case.”

Given that she’d called the two of us out like this, we naturally thought something was up.

From now on, let’s work hard together! – as if.

“In that situation, I was the one who nominated Airi and cornered her. It’s fine if you just listen to our conversation.”

“I can’t do that. I was of the same opinion, so I am equally responsible. No, the reason all this happened was because I broke my promise. I have to accept everything.”

Compared to then, it looks like she’s managed to regain her composure, but being too eager was also a cause for concern.

“Haruka is important, but it’s also necessary to change your mindset and look towards the Sports Festival.”

We’ve already spent a week trying to solve our class problems. In that time, Classes like A had already started preparing to win at the Sports Festival, so we couldn’t afford to fall behind.

“You’re right. Of course, I’ve been thinking well about how to fight in the Sports Festival. I think I’ve figured it out to some extent.”

While backing up Kushida or Shinohara and the others, she didn’t overlook that part.

“Then I’ll ask. What’s your goal for the Sports Festival?”

I tried asking Horikita her objective.

“It goes without saying─we’re aiming for first place. No, we will definitely take first place. We have to.”

From the profile of her face gazing forwards, you could see confidence peeking through.

“It’s not a bad thing to set your sights high; we don’t lose to anyone else in terms of manpower. Have you thought of a strategy? There’s the battle between whole school years, but fundamentally, the fight for our cumulative points within the same year will be the focus. Sakayanagi and Ryuuen will be implementing strategies you haven’t even thought of.”

“If one doesn’t complete five events, then all of their points will be forfeit. Considering Ryuuen, it wouldn’t be weird if he was aiming to feign an accident during the competition, injure someone and have them removed due to that.”

Just like Horikita was targeted last year, it wouldn’t be strange for Ryuuen to choose the kind of methods one would call cowardly. If it were Sakayanagi, she would probably look at those participating in the competition and guide her classmates with the most appropriate arrangements.

“Considering all possibilities, what hand do you intend to play?”

“To be specific, it’ll be a frontal attack. Sudou-kun and Onodera-san will make a bundle for us, and students like Kushida and me will also steadily earn points. We’ll just do what’s necessary to win.”

“There’d be no trouble if we could win with that, but our class having only 38 people is also a handicap.”

Horikita immediately nodded. Her response indicated that she’d accounted for that.

“That’s why I’ve decided to take one single risk. I’m in the middle of preparations for that now.”

“Risk?”

“For a more detailed conversation, perhaps you’ll come with me after school tomorrow?”

“Do you mean you want me to help with something?”

“No. It’ll be enough if you come along and listen to the conversation. And after that, I just want you to objectively assess whether or not there’s value in taking that risk and tell me.”

“Are you really fine with just that?”

“I can’t have you coddle me again and again, like last time.”

Since she’s already thought about this to some extent, she doesn’t need any suggestions or advice. If that’s the case, I’ll look forward to the strategy Horikita is thinking of for the Sports Festival.

“Got it. I’ll hear you out tomorrow after school.”

When we finally arrived at the cafe, the three members of the Ayanokouji group were waiting at their seats. It didn’t seem like they’d been chatting, and three drinks were placed out in vain. If we wanted to use the store, we needed to get at least one drink. One by one, we randomly picked drinks and headed to our seats.

“Sit down.” As soon as we arrived, Haruka urged us to sit in the two empty seats. “While I was away, you seemed to have wanted to talk to me several times, so I thought I’d ask about that.” Haruka dispassionately opened with that, with her gaze directed towards neither me nor Horikita. I think she was asking that to both of us, but the focus was obviously on Horikita. “What did you want to talk about?”

“In a way, the problem has already been solved. You’d been absent from school for several days.”

“So you were worried. Our class evaluation may drop, after all.”

“Of course that’s not everything. You must have had a good reason for being absent for a week, right?”

“I wasn’t feeling well. I told that to the school, so there shouldn’t be any problems? Miyacchi told me that we may receive a penalty if I’m out more than a week, so I came to school today.”

Is there a problem with that? Haruka’s body language said, while she still showed no emotion.

“Certainly. However, the reason you skipped school wasn’t because you weren’t feeling good.”

“How can you say that’s the case? I could simply have been sick, right?”

Without denying anything, Horikita brought her cup to her mouth. Was she absent because she wasn’t feeling well, or was that not the case? That’s nothing more than the step before the problem. With how Horikita answered, there’s no way that she was satisfied.

“You seem to have your doubts, but I really wasn’t feeling well. It wasn’t an injury or sickness though. Waking up was emotionally difficult, I couldn’t sleep, and simply took off from school.”

Akito and Keisei appear to be listening calmly, but that’s not the case. Though they are suffering in the same fashion, they understand that their suffering is a far cry from Haruka’s. Thus they have no choice but to be quiet and listen.

“Could you stop beating around the bush and say what you want to say?”

Rather than becoming deferential, Horikita got more assertive. It would be normal for that attitude to have the opposite effect, but Haruka doesn’t seem bothered by it. I got the strong impression that she’d sealed her emotions deep in her heart. Horikita, who was sitting next to me, probably gave that excessive reaction because she felt the same thing.

“Are you satisfied that you gained class points during the special exam?”

“I’m not satisfied. There’s still a gap of more than 500 points between us and Class A. Moreover, striving for Class A without losing anyone if possible was my ideal… my vision. However, talking about those things is meaningless at this point.”

No one wants to expel someone else. Amidst the fighting, I simply nominated Airi for an unavoidable reason. We’ve already finished confirming that.

“My dear friend was sacrificed due to your selfish judgment. Are you aware of that, Horikita-san?”

For the first time today, the things that Haruka has been wanting to say came spilling out.

“Indeed.”

For the more than a week that had passed since the end of the special exam, Horikita faced her decision and continued to fight. That’s something you would understand by observing her every day, even without listening to her face-to-face. Of course, that’s something of no concern to Haruka. She won’t forgive her just because she was trying her best; she won’t forgive her just because she produced results.

“What a fine leader. You don’t question the methods you take in order to make your class win.”

“I still have ways to go.”

“Do you understand that I was being sarcastic?”

“Of course I understand.”

“Where did your original promise to cut off the traitor – the student who kept pressing “agree” – go?”

“Regarding that, I think my foresight was inadequate. However, so long as we can’t make it as if the special exam from the other day never happened, we have no choice but to keep living on.”

“There are mistakes that can’t be forgiven.”

“I won’t deny that. It’s as you say.”

“Even if having Kyou-cha– Kushida-san remain in the class was the right choice?”

“It’s *because* I deemed it to be the right choice that I had the resolve to keep her in the class, taking on the animosity from everyone else. This is getting redundant.”

“Ah, I see.”

Horikita wasn’t backing down, so Haruka made her manner of speaking a bit more aggressive.

“I don’t intend to give a poor apology. No matter how much I apologize, it’s a fact that I changed my opinion and judged that Kushida-san should remain in the class. It’s natural for you to resent me, and one day I may receive painful retaliation. However, I decided that the person who can become fighting strength for our class was Kushida. I have gradually become certain of that.”



“Even if Kushida-san is an outstanding student, there are others who have no abilities. There was no need for it to be her.” The person we should have cut off was someone else. Horikita hadn’t reached that conclusion, so in front of her Haruka continued. “I won’t accept it. No matter how many people approve of you from here on out, I will never accept it.”

Maintaining that position as long as she possessed her feelings, Haruka showed no sign of forgiving her.

“I have no choice but to try hard so that you’ll approve of me then.”

“I just said that I don’t approve of you.”

“The one responsibility for expelling Sakura-san lies with me. Yes, I won’t deny that. I can’t deny that. On the other hand, what should I do? Are you going to tell me from here on to quit school?” Even if she did that, it doesn’t mean that Airi would come back. That action would make the 100 class points that remained from her taking the initiative for the sake of the class also disappear into nothing. “Perhaps you want me to get down on my knees? Would you feel better with that?”

A strong will. The will to not lose. That’s how it may have seemed, but that wasn’t the case. Horikita is struggling. Though she’s struggling, she’s putting up a front and facing Haruka. While sitting next to her, I was able to peer at the real intent behind her shaking eyes.

“Give Airi back.”

“… I can’t fulfill a request that can’t be done.”

“That’s all I wish for. I don’t care what happens to the class.” She grabbed a few strands of her own hair and pulled them out with all her might. “The decision from that time was wrong.”

“If you’re dissatisfied, then perhaps you should have fought.” Right after letting loose what was almost a taunt, Horikita followed up with a finishing

blow. “But that’s a pointless conversation. Even if you had fought, you had no means to resist us, after all.”

“I suppose so. Certainly, there’s not much that the likes of me could have done. Kiyopon used Airi’s feelings and cornered her without mercy. That kind of behavior is something that a normal person absolutely couldn’t have done.” Here for the first time, she sent a scornful look in my direction. However, since she seemed to have no intent on talking to me, she left it at that and turned her gaze back to Horikita. “Is Kushida-san really going to work for the sake of the class? She’s bound to betray you.”

“If Kushida-san drags us down moving forward, I’ll regret it.”

There’s indeed no guarantee that Kushida will definitely be of use to our class. If Horikita makes a mistake in her leadership after this point, then there may come a day where she regrets her choice to get rid of Airi.

“However, even if I were to go to the past with my memories as I am now, what I would most likely do wouldn’t change much. I would repeat my decision to save Kushida-san and choose Airi to be expelled. If I were to make just one change, I wouldn’t have carelessly made a promise.”

She stated that she would make no changes to her decision.”

“Why? Why Airi?”

Even if she’s silent she’ll probably give an answer, but I decided to mention my opinion here.

“The issue is how we think about things. The events this time around have become a strong stimulus for the students whose names are lowest on the OAA. If they continue to fly low like this, then they may become the next ones to be expelled. Even just them possessing a stronger sense of danger can be thought of as a plus.”

That’s also a part of my role as the one who nominated Airi.

“It’s as if we’re like Ryuuen’s class. Throwing away people without any abilities?”

“I wonder about that. I’m not sure what principles Ryueen goes by, but it’s a fact that it’s close to his reigning with fear in some sense. Our class policy up until now has been vague and too weak.”

“It kind of reminds me of when we started school. It’s the same as when we all acted on our own and had not a shred of cohesiveness.”

She can say it resembles it, but it’s something different that simply looks similar.

“The situation from that time was different. Preventing avoidable expulsions before they happen is important, but keeping those who we have to expel to a minimum was the issue at hand this time around.”

“But—!

Haruka raised her voice here for the first time.

“It’s *because* Horikita felt the possibility of the benefits gained upon Kushida becoming an ally greatly outweighing Airi’s that she reached that conclusion. It’s also because I saw that future that I respected her opinion and threw her a lifeline.”

Fundamentally, you can never find a definitive future. We can only act towards grasping a future that we see and imagine. People aren’t all-powerful.

“Even though Airi disappeared, the class returned to their everyday lives before I knew it.”

“I understand your discontent, but did you think the same things when Yamauchi-kun was expelled?”

“He got what he deserved. It’s different this time around.”

“It’s the same. You’re just mad that one of your friends was sacrificed.”

“What’s so wrong about that?” There’s no clear goal for this back-and-forth. Strictly speaking, there’s no hint at solving this aside from Haruka backing down. “I can’t accept that kind of reality. I can’t come to terms with it.” And if Haruka won’t yield, then a big problem lies ahead waiting for us. “Kushida-san indeed may have been a threat. She may now have a change of heart and work for the class from here on out. However, do you seriously think I’ll look at that and cooperate?”

“You have a point. When you were out for a whole week, it felt like you would become a long-term problem more so than anyone else.” There was a need to deal with Kushida quickly, but Horikita says that Haruka was resolved for the long haul. After losing Airi in the exam, Haruka was unafraid of anything. “However, you came to school. If you wanted to go out of your way to talk to me, you could’ve done so while continuing to stay absent. Isn’t that right?”

It’s unlikely, but if Haruka changed her attitude herself and came to school, it would be a welcome turn of events. However, the world isn’t so simple.

“I still haven’t come up with an answer so I simply tried coming here.”

“An answer?”

“I came to school to look for the answer I couldn’t find while holed up inside my room.”

Akito cast his eyes downwards after hearing those words.

“What should I do to achieve revenge against Horikita-san and Kiyopon? I’m searching for that answer.”

This was the coldest thing Haruka had said yet. The words that came out of her dry lips weren’t in the same league as a threat or a bluff.

“… You’re serious, aren’t you?”

Horikita also noticed the weight of those words.

“I wanted to tell you today: I will make you regret expelling Airi.”

Haruka left her seat, leaving her drink on the table. Akito, too, went after her, hoping to catch up to her.

Horikita wasn’t the only one whose jaw had dropped. Keisei shared her surprise.

“I don’t think either of you, Horikita or Haruka, are wrong. It might seem unfair, but those are my honest thoughts. At the end of the day, so long as I survive it’s alright, that’s at the core of it.”

Keisei was ashamed of himself, but he didn’t attempt to hide the truth and told it to us.

“Everyone’s like that. It isn’t strange to want to save yourself.” Horikita said.

“That’s why I can’t understand Haruka’s feelings just now. But despite that, I don’t think I have the right to tell her to stop. Even if it ends up causing trouble for the class.” Keisei weakly struck the table with his fist before getting up. “The group is half broken now. But still, I will be useful to the class as myself. While I might not do well in the Sports Festival, in turn I will study more and more to contribute to the class. If I don’t… I wouldn’t be able to rule out the possibility that I’ll get thrown out.”

While he was good at academics, Keisei held us back when it came to sports or social contributions. It was clear that he would be playing at a disadvantage if it came down to how many friends one had.

Chapter 4

Introduction

Picking up from where we left off yesterday, we arrived at the karaoke parlor in Keyaki Mall. Certainly, excluding the dormitories, it was one of the most optimal places to ensure our privacy.

There was nobody in the room Horikita and I stepped into.

“If we were just going to talk, we didn’t need to come all the way to the karaoke parlor?”

Since we had visited each other’s rooms in the past, there shouldn’t have been any problem with having this conversation in either of our rooms. In other words, the fact that she chose to bring me here meant other people would be joining us.

I won’t get too involved, and leave it to Horikita to drive it through the end.

“We have some time until our appointment…will you sing something?”

She picked up the microphone that lay on top of the table and held it out to me.

“Nah, I’ll pass. How about you sing? I’ll at least clap along for you.”

“No way.”

An immediate denial. You aren’t going to practice what you preach…?

“Because I am going to study,” she said, before silently taking out her notebook.

Seeing that, I pulled out my own reference book and also started studying. At school, most lessons were now making use of our tablets and other such equipment, but when studying by myself, cracking open a book and keeping a notebook really is easier.

Since we weren’t singing, the room was very quiet. While our weird back and forth had created a strange mood, I decided to quietly wait on the sofa and wait for the time to come.

And then it passed 5:10 PM. Horikita, who had been checking the time on her phone every few minutes since before 5 PM, raised her head with a sigh.

“I’m sorry. This might get drawn out longer than I thought.”

I didn’t ask who we would be meeting with, but I think it was safe to say that we were due to meet at 5 o’clock and they were late. Seeing as they hadn’t made contact, there were either circumstances that were beyond their control, or they were somewhat lax, or they were the kind of person who would deliberately be late.

As we waited, I considered several students, picturing one, striking them off and moving on to the next. Another fifteen minutes passed.

The door to the room—which hadn’t budged in the slightest since we’d arrived—was slowly opened from the outside. The one who showed up was… someone I didn’t expect.

It was second-year Class D’s Katsuragi Kohei. He seemed like the sort to be particular about punctuality, so I was surprised.

“Sorry for being late.”

“No, I don’t mind. It must’ve been a lot of trouble for you too, Katsuragi-kun.”

“…More or less.”

Muttering that, Katsuragi prompted the person lurking behind him to enter the room. Another person revealed themself.

“Suzune, it’s great that you wanna have a date with me, but it looks like there’s a few too many people tagging along.”

It was the man who pulled Katsuragi—once the leader of Class A—into his own class, Ryuuen Kakeru.

“It’s because it would be difficult to have a constructive conversation with just the two of us.”

Although he was sneering audaciously, Ryuuen had shown no sign of letting up on his keen observation of Horikita. Now that the case with Kushida was settled, Horikita had cleared her mind and regained her usual composure. Since they’d had almost no direct interaction since becoming second-years, it wouldn’t be surprising if—even at this early stage—he’d sensed the changes in Horikita.

“Were you trying to gain a mental advantage by intentionally coming late?”

“Who knows?”

The battle had begun, its first shots were them sounding each other out before they even faced off. I guess I can assume that Ryuuen’s side hasn’t been told yet why they were summoned here.

“There was something you wanted to talk to us about… let’s hear the details, shall we.”

“Can you sit down? If this was something that would only take a minute or two, I wouldn’t have bothered calling you out here.”

Ryuuen shot me a glance before sitting down confidently on the sofa and grabbing the tablet from the charging station. As if he was used to it, he placed his order and then tossed the tablet haphazardly onto the table. After that, Horikita reached for the tablet and picked it up.

“How about you, Katsuragi-kun?”

“I’ll have oolong tea, please.”

After hearing his request and completing the order with the tablet, she carefully returned it to the charging station.

“I’ll tell you why I called you here—”

She promptly tried to start the conversation, but Ryuuen held her back with a hand, aiming to unnerve her from the outset.

“Before that, there’s something I wanted to ask you. How did it feel to cut off the dead weight and get those class points? It must’ve been something special, right?”

He flatly asked a question that would be likely to inflict emotional damage upon us. It was a play to try and get the upper hand in this situation where he didn’t know what the topic of our discussion would be yet. There was no doubt that Ryuuen—with his classic style—was using the state of our class to sound us out. It was a trick based on the assumption that our class’s internal affairs hadn’t been cleared up, but Horikita was unperturbed.

“Certainly, it’s not like it didn’t cause a mountain of problems. However, I’m sorry to disappoint you, but it’s not going to turn out the way you want. Most of the big problems have already been solved.”

That was a lie. At the very least, the issue with Haruka remained untouched, and it was unclear when that bomb would explode.

“Lying to me, acting all big, ain’tcha?”

Ryuuen asserted that she was lying in an attempt to trick her into revealing the truth, but Horikita paid no heed to it.

“If you think I’m lying, then so be it. You are not the kind of person who would easily believe anything I say in the first place, are you?”

“Hmm, I wonder? I might trust you more than you think, y’know?”

“Whether you’re being serious or joking, that isn’t very funny.”

She dodged his provocations. Katsuragi slowly crossed his arms while staring at Horikita, as if analyzing her.

“Rather, what were *you* trying? I was sure that you would expel someone.”

“You getting worried ’cause you’re all alone? After all, you were the only one who made the wrong choice.”

Three out of the four classes protected their classmates. He was trying to implant the idea that only Horikita was cruel and made a mistake.

“It’s too bad that we were the only ones who chose the correct answer. You didn’t take even one step forward in the fight for Class A.”

“That’s enough for now.”

Katsuragi stepped in to control the situation, but just then there was a light knock on the door. A waiter showed up with the oolong tea Katsuragi had ordered and also some orange juice. The ill-fitting drink was placed in front of Ryuuen. The incongruity of the combination captured both Horikita and Katsuragi’s gazes for a moment.

Incidentally, I was the same. Ryuuen and orange juice… it just didn’t fit.

“Now that we have our drinks, shall we get down to business? What’s the meaning of this get-together?”

While everyone was still internally commenting on that choice, Katsuragi prompted Horikita to start the conversation. Horikita nodded, and after looking back at each of Ryuuen and Katsuragi once again, she started to talk.

“In order to defeat Sakayanagi-san’s class, I propose we form a cooperative relationship for the upcoming Sports Festival.”

Katsuragi’s shoulders reacted slightly, indicating his surprise. Moments later, after returning to his usual state, he asked her back her own words.

“… What do you mean by *cooperative relationship*?”

She said *cooperative*, but the degree of cooperation differed greatly on how that word was taken. It was natural that he wanted to hear the particulars, but it didn’t seem like he intended to reject her outright. Ryuuen, on the other hand, wasn’t surprised, but he didn’t look impressed either. I guess you could say he was just watching with a smirk plastered on his face.

“In this special exam, there are both mixed grade level and grade-specific aspects to the competition. I want to make the most of the system where if we win in a group competition with multiple people taking part, everyone will score equally.”

“Why our class? Would you mind if I ask your reasoning?”

Ryuuen—the leader of their class—listened throughout without interjecting at all.

“First of all, it goes without saying that Class A is out of the question. Sharing the points we obtain with the class we are trying to catch up to would be like putting the cart before the horse. The two remaining options are Ichinose-san’s class or your class. In my analysis, even if Ichinose-san is by far and away the best in terms of trust, it’s hard to say she has many classmates who are physically gifted.”

“So you’re saying you chose us by process of elimination, huh.”

“If it were through a simple process of elimination, I wouldn’t have teamed up with any class to begin with. Since the only person more untrustworthy than someone from Sakayanagi-san’s class is Ryuuen-kun, your class’s leader.”

He certainly wasn’t an easy person to team up with. As if he sympathized, Katsuragi nodded deeply.

“That’s true. Even I, now a fellow classmate, think so. There is no one I’d be more afraid of trusting my back to. That being the case, why did you propose a cooperative relationship that poses such a great risk to you?”

“To win, of course. We can’t advance without bringing an end to Class A’s overwhelming lead.”

“But it would be pointless if those hopes aren’t met, wouldn’t it? This guy will use any means available, that’s who he is. I know it well, since I have my own painful experiences. I can’t recommend it.”

He expressed such an acrimonious opinion of his classmate that it was hard to believe he was on Ryuuen’s side. If we joined forces imprudently, far from reaching Class A, we would be swallowed up by Ryuuen’s class instead. He warned her of that danger.

“I didn’t intend to cut right to the chase during today’s discussion. I haven’t spoken to Ryuuen-kun like this for a while, and I just can’t trust someone who is so unabashedly late. However, when I saw you apologize for being late, Katsuragi-kun, I changed my mind. At the very least, I can trust *you*.”

“That’s very simplistic. Did you not consider that this attitude of mine may also be one of Ryuuen’s schemes?”

“If I’m not able to discern whether or not I can trust you, sooner or later, I’ll just be swallowed up, right?”

Right now, Horikita was also taking a risk.

When Ryuuen and Katsuragi were put side by side, Katsuragi looked like a good, relatively sensible person.

But if she showed that she was prepared for it, Katsuragi would have no choice but to accept.

“You seem a little different from before, Horikita. So I guess that means you’re growing, too, huh.”

Katsuragi sensed the change in Horikita—how she had matured—and showed a renewed willingness to sit down for dialogue.

“I understand the situation on your side. From here on out, I’ll give you my personal opinion.”

He deliberately added the word *personal*, probably to warn us that it didn’t take Ryuuen’s intentions and thoughts into account in any way.

“I, too, had a plan in mind to join forces with your class this time and defeat Class A.”

“You too…?”

“That’s right. Your class has strong individuals like Sudou and Kouenji who can compete across grade levels. Among the four second-year classes, you have the students with the highest physical abilities, and the depth of your roster is the very best. We don’t need to worry about being dragged down if we team up with you. You’re not someone I can trust unconditionally, but the fact that your class won’t easily betray us is worth noting.”

While Katsuragi said that, Ryuuen’s eyes turned to me as well. However, his mouth remained shut.

Until now, there was no one else in Ryuuen’s class who could conduct negotiations, so Ryuuen always took the initiative in the conversation. However, with the addition of Katsuragi, the need for this had diminished,

and he now had the option to wait and see. That was a very big advantage for them.

It was eerie not knowing what Ryuuen was thinking, what he was going to suggest, and at what timing he would do so. While it was easy to talk to Katsuragi, Hoikita must have also started to become conscious of that fear. However, this was a path she would have to take if she was going to periodically propose ideas to him over the next year and a half.

“But, to tell you the truth, I was of two minds on whether I should propose working together with your class to Ryuuen-kun.”

A week had passed since the details of the Sports Festival were announced. If Katsuragi was working towards our classes cooperating, it wouldn’t have been surprising if Horikita had heard of it already. That meant that, in his mind, the half that didn’t want to join forces won out.

“If we were to form a cooperative relationship, our classes would naturally take first and second place. If that happens, the deciding factor would inevitably be the total strength of our classes. Roughly speaking, I’d say that we’d have to resign ourselves to the possibility that your class would get first and we’d get second,” said Katsuragi.

Working together would allow them to leave Sakayanagi’s class and Ichinose’s class behind, but it would also set it up such that the real battle would be between Horikita’s class and Ryuuen’s class. Precisely because Katsuragi understood this, he answered that he was of two minds about it.

Katsuragi understood us, but that didn’t mean he’d immediately show his support for a cooperative relationship with us. So if we didn’t overcome this barrier that we were facing, we wouldn’t even be able to start negotiating with Ryuuen…

So, what will you do, Horikita?

“So you mean your class sees our class as a threat, right?”

“Absolutely. The circumstances are very different from what they were a year ago. Unlike when you were mocked for being a bundle of defective goods, you are now Class B. And that’s after your class points fell all the way down to zero once. Most recently, you had Kouenji’s solo victory and gained a hundred points from making the difficult decision of kicking out a classmate in the Unanimous Consent Special Test. There is no doubt that you certainly are a formidable enemy.”

“It doesn’t feel bad to be evaluated like that, even if it isn’t due to my own achievements. But if we don’t form a pact and face the Sports Festival without any coordination, won’t the worst-case scenario of Sakayanagi-san’s class taking first place become entirely likely? The important thing right now is to defeat Sakayanagi-san’s class. Am I wrong?”

“No. You’re right. Ryuuen, what do you think?”

Now, for the first time, Katsuragi sought Ryuuen’s opinion.

“If you want us to help you out, then there has to be a suitable reward, right?”

“I think you’ve got this mixed up? Sure, the one who brought this proposal to you was me, but that doesn’t mean I must make some sort of concession to you. In fact, you should realize that you’re in the position to form a partnership with the class that’s in the running to get first place.”

“Don’t make me laugh. Even if we don’t cooperate, we’ll win, but if you guys are gonna beg us, I guess it wouldn’t hurt us to help out. *That’s* our position. If you don’t like it, feel free to run back home.”

“Do *you* know the way back? Just exit from that door and turn left, you’ll be outside.”

She didn’t even entertain the possibility of a concession and instead recommended Ryuuen and Katsuragi to leave. Not only was her attitude in the true spirit of bargaining, but she also gave off the impression that we weren’t betting everything on its result. That meant that negotiations would

end the moment Ryuuen left the table, and along with it would disappear the proposal to defeat Sakayanagi. And after that, if Ryuuen told us he was willing to join hands anew, our positions would be reversed

“You’ve finally got the balls to make a bluff, huh.”

“What are you saying? Just as Katsuragi-kun said, our class has plenty of firepower for the Sports Festival. Or perhaps you think you can take Sudou-kun or Kouenji-kun head on and place better than them?”

“Mano a mano, fair and square, maybe not. But there are many other ways. You haven’t forgotten about last year, have you?”

Ryuuen faking an accident, the very move we were anxious about. It was clear that his words just now were hinting at that.

“It looks like we’ll have guests this year, so they’ll be watching over the spirit of the Sports Festival’s rules more strictly, right? I’d like to see just how far you can take your despicable moves.”

“There’s plen’y of blind spots, and it doesn’t only need to be during the events.”

To wit, he was talking about the changing rooms or toilets, where there couldn’t be anybody watching.

“You haven’t changed a bit. Certainly, the thought of that is terrifying, but… looks like we’re done here.”

Not even slightly disappointed, Horikita snapped her notebook shut.

“Thank you for coming along with me today, Ayanokouji-kun. Unfortunately, it seems like this case is so risky that I don’t even have to ask for your opinion on it. I’m thinking of wrapping this up here.”

“If you’re fine with that, then I have no problems.”

That being the case, Horikita started packing her notebooks. Ryueen watched on without saying anything, but Katsuragi made a move.

“Ryuuen. It looks like Horikita is different from how she used to be, far more than we could imagine. If we don’t take this negotiation seriously, we will be the ones losing out.”

Katsuragi had calmly analyzed the whole situation, so he turned to look at Horikita again.

“Weren’t you the one who decided not to bring this to me because you thought the drawbacks of forming an alliance were worse?” Ryuuen asked back.

“We didn’t propose this idea. But, now that Horikita has started the conversation, the situation has changed. Not to mention, I’m getting the feeling it will be better than I expected.”

Now that he’d refreshed the data he had, his evaluation of Horikita’s class had gone up a little. In short, he’d reevaluated us as a class which he considered good enough to work with.

“She’s putting on a good show, but from my perspective it’s nothing but a front. When you’re at an advantage, it’s natural to try and set things up in your favor. Sure, she seems to have gotten somewhat more persuasive, but the only reason it looks like it’s working is because Ayanokouji is by her side.”

As soon as he said that, Ryuuen picked up the filled-to-the-brim glass of orange juice in front of him, and—without wavering even a bit—threw its contents in my direction. I immediately dodged it by slipping to the side of where I was sitting and avoided getting splashed. A yellowish, foul-smelling stain instantly spread on the spot I was sitting on just a moment ago.

“So, are you finally gonna realize just how abnormal this guy is? You think you could dodge that?”

“… No, that would be impossible.”

“That’s right. An Average Joe would’ve been dripping wet before he even had time to react. No ordinary guy could dodge that, but this dude pulled it off like it was no big deal.”

“I admit he has insane reflexes but… what does that have to do with this discussion?”

“Don’t you get it? Let me break it down for you: Ayanokouji is Suzune’s Lethal Weapon. Of course she’s talking big after flashing her pistol at an unarmed enemy.”

“You ordered an orange juice just to test that? …Spare me, please.”

I knew something was off, and as usual he ended up doing something ridiculous. It was a good idea to keep my guard up until he drank what was an unusual drink for him.

“Why did you dodge it? If you just took it on the chin, you could’ve kept him from getting back at you.”

“Don’t be ridiculous. Even I don’t want to take a glass of juice to the face.”

It would smell awful, it would be sticky, and it wouldn’t come off easily. It would’ve been difficult to take it all unconditionally. I could’ve borne it if it were oolong tea, however. If you wanted to annoy someone by dashing them with a drink, orange juice was one of the best options.

“If you want to have a serious discussion, get Ayanokouji out of here. Then we’ll talk.”

He declared that the condition for continuing this negotiation was removing me from this place.

“How very like you. But I refuse. He is my classmate. Not only does he have a right to be here, I also have the right to invite him here. I have no

idea what's wrong with using every weapon in my arsenal during a negotiation."

She really has gotten brave. Most importantly, she was able to come up with ideas she was never able to before.

And one more thing struck me, even though Horikita didn't know about what happened between me and Ryuuen, she was finding out about it. Ryuuen had guessed that too. I didn't know how much she's found out, but I wouldn't be surprised if she'd heard about the incident involving Kei on the rooftop.

Horikita had told me that I didn't need to help out, I just needed to be here. She was keeping her promise even as she used me, so I had nothing to complain about.

"Our class is in a better position than yours, and yet we brought this proposal for a cooperative relationship to you. If that isn't enough for you to agree, then I'd rather we pretend this didn't happen at all."

Ryuuen absolutely couldn't team up with Sakayanagi, and even if he went to Ichinose, it was unclear just how many useful strategies that would unlock. If he made the wrong call here, even he couldn't avoid the effects it would have on them from now on.

And even if it wasn't likely, there still was the possibility that Horikita and Sakayanagi would form an alliance. If it would lead to Horikita's class taking first place and Sakayanagi's class taking second place, it wasn't an entirely bad idea. But if he allowed that to pass, it would become even more difficult to overtake Sakayanagi's class.

"Depending on how our discussions go, I think it'll be good to join hands with your class. So, let me know your answer. Do you accept or do you not?" Horikita asked.

She put her next question not to Katsuragi, but to the leader, Ryuuen.

A few seconds passed in silence, and then Ryuuen made his decision.

“Fine. We’ll take you up on that.”

He replied, but he didn’t stop there.

“But I will add one condition. Once we have a cooperative relationship, our relationship should be stronger and more equal. Between us, whichever classes in whatever order take first and second place, we’ll end up with a difference of 100 class points. Whoever takes first place will pay private points to make up for that gap until March 1st, the year we graduate. I’m adding that condition.”

Ryuuen was trying to do something similar to what he’d done in his contract with Katsuragi in the Uninhabited Island exam last year. One side gains a lot of class points, and compensates for that difference with private points. Ryuuen, too, must have recognized that he was at a disadvantage. He knew that, and yet he was trying to force a little extra in the deal for himself. However, Horikita had already predicted this.

“Sure, that condition itself is very fair. But I refuse. We’ll fight tooth and nail to see who gets first and who gets second. It’ll be the result of a fair fight, and that’s all.”

If they were on equal terms with or without that condition, there was no way she’d add it after having determined she was likely to win.

Ryuuen chuckled. “No free lunch here, huh. But, in that case, there’s little meat on the bone for us.”

“It’ll be difficult to get any concessions out of Horikita. But I think we’ll get a solid partnership out of this.”

Katsuragi took a softer tone with Ryuuen, who was still unwilling to officially accept the partnership.

“Not enough. If you want to ask me for help, you’ve gotta show more sincerity.”

“Sincerity? Don’t I get to ask the same of you? If the plan works out and we’re able to push Sakayanagi-san’s Class A to last place, that’s minus 150 points for them. There’s plenty for you to think about in this strategy of working together. But at the same time, we’re also taking a risk,” Horikita rebutted, continuing, “The forever lingering doubt—can we trust you, or can we not? If we focus on team competitions so we can team up, we will have to neglect the individual events.”

It’s easy to see Ryuuen betraying us by making his class hold back during the team competitions or just straight up not show up for the competitions they signed up for. On the day of the test, leaders like Horikita would also be bouncing around between their own competitions, so it would be doubtful if they’d be able to keep an eye on all the events. We can’t keep our phones on us, so she couldn’t even coordinate over a distance.

“You’re not trustworthy, but we have to trust you. The fact that we’re bearing that risk is the biggest compromise I can make in working with you. I am not going to yield even an inch more than that.”

Those words must’ve been a painful truth even for Ryuuen. Even if a great strategy was available to our class, it had to deal with the basic fact that we couldn’t trust Ryuuen. Horikita was going to accept that burden, so she was telling him to be quiet and cooperate.

“That’s fair. We had no faith in the way you do things. We have no choice but to agree.”

“I didn’t expect you to trust me in the first place.”

Ryuuen laughed nonchalantly, but the tension in his shoulders loosened. Perhaps Horikita had gotten through to him.

“Can you really trust me?”

“The enemy of my enemy is my friend. I’ll believe in that convenient saying our predecessors came up with,” Horikita replied.

If you form an alliance that you don’t trust, then it’ll be difficult for you to use your full strength. Depending on the situation, you may end up having to watch your back on top of fighting your enemy.

“I don’t accept everything you’re saying, but one thing’s for sure—it ain’t a good idea to let Sakayanagi’s class keep running on ahead.”

Katsuragi and Horikita agreed with Ryuuen’s response, so they nodded without hesitation.

Letting Class A win. That was the act that—no matter what—they could not allow any more.

“Even if you say that you’re gonna hold off a direct confrontation with her until the end of the school year, you can’t overturn the difference in class points with just that.”

We could take for granted that they wanted to get within range of her by that time.

“You’ve been listening in silence, but it’s about time you let us hear your opinion, Ayanokouji-kun.”

Horikita’s idea and its risks. Looking at it objectively, should we accept this strategy or reject it?

“Regarding the pros and cons, cooperation isn’t a bad idea. There may be some objections, but everyone understands that Sakayanagi is the target we need to take down. Yousuke and Kei will surely back you up here as well.”

Horikita once again became more confident in her proposal. However, Ryuuen put the brakes on the proceedings.

“You want to move onto the contract, but not yet.”

“Not yet? Are you saying that you want to drag out more concessions?”

“Let me confirm one last thing. Are you the one who came up with this proposal, Suzune? Or, was it Ayanokouji, the guy who’s calmly observing the situation? Which is it?”

He was carefully verifying who the person was who came up with the proposal to form a united front with Ryuuen’s class.

“Will you not go along with it if it’s not from Ayanokouji? You and Ayanokouji-kun seem to have a relationship that you can’t let others hear about, after all.” Horikita replied in a way that left a lot between the lines. “I can tell that the two of you have recognized each other as strong enemies —and the fact that I am out of place as well.”

“Did I say anything about that? I’m just telling you to answer who it is.”

Ryuuen was a bit irritated, scowling at Horikita as he told her to get on with it.

“It was me. This time I asked Ayanokouji-kun to only be present, and even he hadn’t heard anything until we talked about it here.”

If he knew I spearheaded the partnership, Ryuuen might refuse. Hearing Horikita answer honestly while fully prepared for that, Ryuuen laughed.

“I see. I’m glad I asked. If that’s the case, I’ll take you up on your proposal.”

With that as the only deciding factor, Ryuuen officially agreed to join hands.

“… Why?”

“Why, you ask? Well, dunno. Figure it out by yourself.” He avoided answering her. “It would be better for both of us to have a proper contract in place, just to be sure. No, for your own sake in particular.”

“Of course we will. I intend to have Chabashira-sensei and Sakagami-sensei get involved in this as well.”

A contract formed with the teachers involved. Naturally, there would be stipulations for breach of contract included in it. Even Ryuuen couldn’t do anything if he were bound by unbreakable rules.

“Well then, I’ll leave the paperwork up to you, Horikita. Is that fine?”

“Yes. Would you perhaps let me bounce ideas off you for a bit, Katsuragi-kun?”

Katsuragi shot a glance at Ryuuen for confirmation, and got a response indicating he could do as he liked.

Ryuuen’s class was hard to trust, so having Katsuragi was a big deal for them. On top of being a quick thinker and trustworthy, he could state his opinion without a shred of fear, even towards Ryuuen. Ryuuen’s eye for when to put Katsuragi on the field and the degree to which he entrusts things to Katsuragi are nothing short of impressive. Meaning, he was surely worth the incredible pile of money they used to win him over.

“Alright then. After we’ve officially settled the contract, let’s take on the Sports Festival.”

Thus, it was decided that Horikita’s class and Ryuuen’s class would take on the Sports Festival with a united front. We would prioritize our own class’s victory to the utmost, but at the same time aim to coordinate with them.

However, this wasn’t the ending, as Katsuragi changed the topic.

“It’s great that we’ve finished our discussion regarding working together, but there’s now something that we must think about. One can easily think that Sakayanagi and Ichinose will join hands, so what do you plan to do about that?”

Fighting our alliance with an alliance of their own. That kind of development could well occur.

“That ain’t a problem. Even if Sakayanagi and Ichinose worked together for this Sports Festival, we still have the advantage. On top of that, Sakayanagi will have to throw away even third place. Just as you had doubts about second place if we joined with Suzune, if they team up, then Ichinose will have the advantage. In Sakayanagi’s class, there’s 38 people after Totsuka’s expulsion and your transfer. Sakayanagi is definitely not going to participate, so that makes 37 people. Ichinose’s class is 40 people. The three-person difference is surprisingly *big*.”

The athletic abilities of their classes were about the same. Therefore, the three-person difference in numbers could determine the winner.

“However, it’s Sakayanagi we’re talking about. She will have established a strategy to make up for her lack of people.”

“Have you not seen the rules for this time around? If you don’t participate in the Sports Festival, you have to stand by in your dorm. As they can’t use their phones, Class A’s head won’t work at all.”

“Have *you* grasped the rules? Sure, Sakayanagi can’t move her body to its fullest. However, if she officially joins, gains her five points, then gains the five-point reward for participating, then she can obtain a total of 10 points. If she fulfills the minimum requirements, she can continue to sit from the outside and give out orders.”

“There ain’t no way that prideful Sakayanagi would show us a powerless, unsightly display.”

No matter what kind of competition it was, Sakayanagi wouldn’t be able to fulfill its requirements, and it was inevitable that Sakayanagi would stand out.

“Things won’t line up so conveniently. We are given the right to resign from a competition. If she participates and then forfeits, then she can avoid

embarrassing herself."

"Would it count as a compelling reason? If she participates knowing the condition of her body, then they'll want justification. After everyone finishes running in the 100-Meter Race, she has to run all the way till the end with her cane. You think she's gonna make a spectacle of herself like that?"

"Indeed, if things were normal, then she would pass on participating given her personality. However, if she knows that we've joined up, then Sakayanagi would consider the risks of losing. I'm saying it's wrong to assume that it's certain. I was just speaking thoughtlessly, but what do you see the percentage of her not participating being? Answer seriously."

"Maybe 90%."

"So from your unsubstantiated and carefree view it's 90%? If that's the case, then the actual value is even lower. I'd say 70-80% at best."

"Be happy with that number."

"I can't do that. If you want to talk certainty, then shoot for 95%."

Setting us aside, Ryuuen and Katsuragi started bickering between themselves.

"Bullshit. But, if we want to be more certain, there's a way. From now until the Sports Festival, we can thoroughly mock Sakayanagi. We'll say that if she participates, then we'll show up as a whole class during the competition and shame her. If we do that, then we'll reach the 95% you mentioned."

Ryuuen spoke of making her yield by threatening to trample on her dignity.

"From an ethical point of view, that's unacceptable."

"I agree. The school probably wouldn't watch quietly either."

Horikita and Katsuragi reject the idea though, saying that they wouldn't accept it.

"In the off chance Sakayanagi does show up, we'll crush her completely."

"It's not that simple, don't forget that we're sinking to the bottom class."

If Sakayanagi *did* function as a commander, then there was certainly no telling what hand she would throw at us. Whether or not she participated would play a big part in our victory or defeat in this Sports Festival. On the other hand, if we could be certain she wouldn't take part, then victory would be right before our eyes.

"Horikita. Are you factoring my contribution into our class's victory?" I interjected.

"For the most part, I'm not considering it. I'm leaving you, and only you, with a special status."

"That's good to hear. If whether or not Sakayanagi participates is threatening our cooperation, then I may be able to be of help."

"What do you mean?"

Katsuragi, who showed interest, stopped his conversation with Ryuuen and turned towards me.

"If you leave everything to me, I'll make sure Sakayanagi doesn't participate."

"… Eh?"

"*Oh?*"

Horikita looked shocked and Ryuuen was impressed. Katsuragi continued listening to me without saying anything.

“However, in exchange for making Sakayanagi not participate, I don’t want you to expect even a single point from me at the Sports Festival. That goes not just for Horikita, but you too, Ryuuen.”

“You haven’t been in my plans from the start. If you say you can hold back Sakayanagi, then that spares us some effort,” Ryuuen answered.

“I can’t even imagine what kind of plan you have, but if Horikita and Ryuuen believe in you, then I more or less don’t plan to say anything more than this on the matter. If Sakayanagi doesn’t participate, then pushing Class A to last place shouldn’t be that hard.”

“But can you really do it?”

“Yeah. There’s a high chance that she’ll sit out even if I don’t do anything, but you can leave it to me anyway. Also, I thought of this while listening to your conversation, but there aren’t many opportunities for the two of you to get together and cooperate like this, right? There’s a different matter I want to talk about, is that alright?”

In the midst of their discussion, I had thought of something a bit different from what the three of them had.

“What is it?”, Horikita asked.

As I began to verbalize my proposal, Horikita and Katsuragi crossed glances, and Ryuuen listened quietly.

The moment I finished my explanation, the ice cubes that had melted in Katsuragi’s glass clinked together.

“That’s an interesting idea, but…”

Not knowing whether or not he would accept it, Horikita looked at Ryuuen, bewildered.

“That certainly ain’t impossible going by the rules, but—”

“You’re not interested in any proposal that comes from me?”

Even though we were going to cooperate for the Sports Festival, if I was the one proposing it, then there was a chance he’d refuse. That was how he had been speaking, after all.

“Yeah, I’m not. Rejected.”

Ryuuen rejected it, but Katsuragi cut in.

“You can deal with your personal feelings later. But frankly, it’s not a bad proposal. We might need to discuss the details, and check the rules again but—no, it’s Ayanokouji we’re talking about. You’ve probably proposed this after confirming the rules properly.”

“There’s no problem as far as rules go. Instead of our class going alone, we could cooperate with the students in Ryuuen’s class to lead to a more powerful outcome. Isn’t that right?” I asked Horikita.

“Yes, that’s right. That would certainly…”

Horikita herself was well aware of the problems we were facing at the moment. If she could bring someone to fill in from elsewhere, then it’d be possible to alleviate her worries.

“Accept it, Ryuuen. We should be advancing our preparations right now for a direct confrontation with Sakayanagi.”

“You hear me, Ayanokouji? After I crush Sakayanagi, you’re next.”

“If you’re making your way up, then that’ll be inevitable.”

As if those words were enough to settle the matter, Ryuuen also accepted my proposal.

“Katsuragi, get things dealt with on your end.”

“I’ll do that.”

“Truly, a siege on Class A… huh.”

“However, before that, making Sakayanagi not participate in the Sports Festival is top priority. For both our cooperation at the Sports Festival and Ayanokouji’s proposal, if we don’t clear that first step, then the ball can’t get rolling.”

“I understand. As for that, leave it to me.”

I had a strategy to seal Sakayanagi that neither Ryuuen, Katsuragi, nor Horikita could execute.

1

Just before 7 PM, three second-year Class A students—Sakayanagi, Kamuro, and Hashimoto—gathered at the café in Keyaki Mall.

“I’m not even surprised when you summon me out of the blue anymore, it’s become so common. What is it today, Princess?”

“It is about what will happen at the upcoming Sports Festival. About what we must do.”

“Haven’t you already decided on a plan?”

“The situation changes from moment to moment. And today, there has been another new development,” stated Sakayanagi, “Ryuuen-kun and Horikita-san’s classes have made contact.”

Hashimoto’s eyes changed upon hearing that.

“Who approached whom? Was it from Ryuuen?”

“That is unclear. But either way, there is no doubt that the two have joined hands.”

“Hang on a sec. I find it hard to believe that it worked out that easily. It’s hard to imagine Horikita simply trusting Ryuuen. He’s not the kinda guy you can collude with!”

“They say *the enemy of my enemy is my friend*, right? We hold a firm lead over the rest. Even if they do not have a relationship of mutual trust, so long as they have the same objective in mind, they can work well together.”

Both could easily surmise how troublesome the two classes joining hands would be. Faced with the not very encouraging news, their expressions

stiffened.

“We’re going to be in trouble if this continues, right?” said Sakayanagi.

“Are you saying that by ourselves, we’ll lose?” asked Hashimoto.

“We will lose. If the other three classes were disorganized and fought each other, it would have still been possible for us to take any of the positions, but now we have an unexpected partnership to deal with.”

Sakayanagi clearly said, before looking at Hashimoto.

“I wouldn’t join hands with Ryuuen if it were me, though. You never know when he’ll catch you off guard and betray you.” said Kamuro.

“I’d rather he did betray them, in fact. Ryuuen-kun’s class takes first, and Horikita-san’s class comes second. I would welcome it if the results were that straightforward, but it will be somewhat troublesome if it is the other way around.”

Sakayanagi was more wary of Horikta’s class than Ryuuen’s. Hashimoto’s faint smile disappeared in response to that remark and that implication.

“There’s no doubt that they’re on a roll right now. I thought it would be impossible for any class other than Ryuuen’s to throw away a small fry and grab those 100 points. Has Horikita grown?… Or has Ayanokouji been making some moves in secret?”

Emphasizing Ayanokouji’s name, he turned towards Sakayanagi as if he was trying to check something. There was no way such an attempt to feel her out would work on Sakayanagi, so she continued indifferently.

“Your impression of him has been rising considerably of late. Did something happen?”

“…No, not especially. I do think he’s hiding abilities beyond what’s on his OAA, though. Well, it’s not like Ayanokouji’s the only student like that.”

The odds would be against him if they started trying to probe each other, so Hashimoto backed down immediately. He decided that it was not a good idea to provoke her carelessly and draw her attention.

“But what are you gonna do? You say we’ll lose without you, but you’ll be absent, won’t you? So you’re saying you’re gonna throw the competition?” asked Kamuro.

Hashimoto, who had been smiling, also seemed concerned about that, as his expression hardened once again. Just 150 points. Even if Class A sank to last place, it wouldn’t do a great deal of damage. However, after continually fighting hard to build their position until now, a defeat was not welcome.

“There is only one answer.” Sakayanagi smiled and continued. “I will also participate in the Sports Festival. Even if they really do join hands, they have calculated that with my nonparticipation and their cooperation, they can finally win. Let’s show them that that is an illusion.”

“For real? Will you be alright?”

“It’s good that you’re so willing, but—are you sure?”

Sakayangi declaring that she would participate shook them both.

“Is this about me being made into a spectacle? As for that, there are numerous ways to get around such a problem.”

“Well, considering it’s you, I’m sure you’ll do fine. If you say you’ll show, then that’s all we need.”

“However, this nevertheless does not improve our overall athletic ability. The most I can do is to pick up competitions that we might end up losing. In other words, it will be a tough battle to usurp first place *even if* I participate.”

“I think it’s enough if we just don’t come last,” said Hashimoto.

“It won’t be so difficult to crack the fragile relationship between Horikita-san and Ryuuen-kun. Let’s get in their way when they are desperately trying to cooperate on the day.”

Hashimoto and Kamuro put their trust in Sakayanagi, who exuded absolute self-confidence. She had continued to deliver top results on countless occasions so far.

“I guess I can feel relieved, huh. But you sure picked up that information quickly, Princess. It’s not like you went out and got it yourself when your legs are like that, right?”

She would often use Hashimoto and Kamuro for everyday information gathering. But since the two of them were only hearing this for the first time right now, Hashimoto asked curiously.

“I still have the responsibility of representing Class A after all. The number of first-years I am acquainted with has increased as well.”

Without getting flustered, Sakayanagi smiled softly, as if she enjoyed being in a pinch.

2

October had finally arrived, and the main event of the Sports Festival drew closer.

Kei and I had come to Keyaki Mall after school for a date.

The intense gazes of the 3rd year students were the same as ever. Despite getting caught in the crossfire, Kei gave off no impression of caring. Looks like she wasn't just paying lip service when she said she was used to it already.

It seemed like Kei had a few stores she wanted to visit today. For starters, we headed to the home electronics store.

"What do you intend to buy?"

"Eh? I don't really want anything though? Ah, well, it's not that I don't want anything, but we didn't come here for my sake today."

Not for her own sake, was her response. So it must be for someone else.

"Isn't it gonna be your birthday soon? I was thinking of surprising you, but then I thought getting you something you really want would be good."

Now that you mention it, my birthday is coming up.

"I was thinking we could walk around and find something you want."

"I see."

Of late, I do remember Kei repeatedly asking if there was anything I've been meaning to buy, but I'd often reply with whatever came to mind since

I had not been thinking too deeply about it. Because of that, it seems like Kei thought of finding a present I would want with me.

“You’ll have to spend private points, you know?”

It wasn’t like Kei had saved up a lot of money.

“I know what you mean, but I think it’s alright for your birthday. Just get what you like!”

She was bent on buying whatever I wanted, but that wouldn’t do.

I say that, but in this situation, I know that telling her I didn’t want anything would be the wrong answer. I could also tell that she wouldn’t be satisfied if I asked for something extremely cheap.

I’ll pick something that wouldn’t make Kei’s wallet suffer.

That’s the kind of response this scene called for.

“I know exactly what you’re thinking, you knooow?”

She stared at me with a relentless gaze and forcibly linked our arms.

“I’ll buy what, you, want! Got it?”

“… yes.”

At the very least, I should keep the burden on her low and not buy something that I don’t really need.

Just as we started walking with our arms linked, Kei snuggled her cheek on my arm.

“Ehehe. I’m so happy.”

She said as she hugged my arm harder.

“There’s nothing I’m hiding from you anymore. I’ve let you know anything and everything about me. I never thought that there would be someone more important to me than my mom and dad.”

Her face turned red and her eyes narrowed in true happiness.

“Kiyotaka, you hiding anything from me is a no-no too, you got that?”

“Uh huh.”

Hidden things. I wonder what she was referring to.

My family. The White Room. The things I’m trying to do at school.

My relationship with my friends or my romantic feelings.

If she was referring to any of them, then there was nothing there that I could say was not hidden. To put it in another way, I haven’t told Kei anything true about me at all.

“Ah-”

While we were walking around the store, talking about the products and dilly dallying, we ran into Satou, who had come to the store alone. When we bumped into each other, her eyes were glued onto our linked arms.

“Lo, Lovey dovey aren’t you. Sorry for bothering yooouuu.”

“Ah, wai- wait a minute!?”

Kei tried to stop her, but Satou had run off at full speed.

“…ah, damn…”

Kei facepalmed at her blunder.

“You’re still being considerate to Satou?”

“It’s not really that… but it really isn’t a nice feeling, you know…”

“If that’s the case, the next time we’re out we should refrain from linking arms.”

“Nope.”

Although she felt sorry for her friend, it seemed like she wouldn’t give that up.

“Ohh? Ayanokouji!”

While walking around the rice cooker and kettle corner, we ran into Ishizaki and Albert.

At that moment, I could feel Kei’s hold on my arm tighten slightly.

“On a date with Karuizawa? You guys are even linking arms… such normies…”

Ishizaki was looking at us with envy, but my attention was on Albert, who was standing next to him holding a large, branded pot. It was curious because the large pot didn’t seem so large in Albert’s large hands.

“Oh, this? The 20th of this month is Ryuuen-san’s birthday. We’re just picking something out for him.”

“Eh? The 20th… you guys have the same birthday?”

Kei was surprised and a little wary as she looked up at me.

“This is the first I’ve heard of it.”

“Who has the same birthday?”

Just as Ishizaki indirectly shifted his gaze to Karuizawa, Kei glared at him and took a small step back to hide.

“What’s wrong, I’m asking you to tell me――”

At that moment, Albert placed his hand lightly on Ishizaki’s shoulder. Finally, it seemed like Ishizaki figured out the reason Karuizawa was on her guard.

“… ah, that’s, right…”

I could hear him mutter, “Damn it.”

Even though it was on Ryuuen’s orders, Ishizaki had participated in calling Kei to the rooftop and bullying her. Naturally, Kei wouldn’t be comfortable around Ishizaki.

Annoyed at his own insensitivity, Ishizaki clicked his tongue and lightly hit his head with a clenched fist.

“I’m… sorry. I think I should have said it earlier… I, on the rooftop――”

“Don’t talk about that here.”

Ishizaki was about to apologize, but he still lacked the delicacy to do so appropriately. This was Keyaki Mall. At any time, it wouldn’t be strange to run into someone you knew. In this situation, Kei wouldn’t want him to broach the topic of the rooftop.

If we had just moved away from them this problem would be solved, but so long as our relationship continued, the number of times she would get mixed up with Ishizaki wouldn’t be small.

“Let’s go someplace else.”

Even inside the well-trafficked Keyaki mall, there were more than a few hidden corners.

Although Kei seemed dissatisfied, arms still linked she came along without a word.

Albert returned the product back to its shelf and came along with Ishizaki.

Precisely because they both felt sorry, they wanted to apologize.

By an emergency exit, we would be a good distance from the shops, and other students wouldn't show up or hear our voices.

Even if an acquaintance did show up, our location meant that if we stopped the conversation, there wouldn't be a problem.

"I'm very sorry! And for not apologizing for all this time!"

"… you don't have to. It would be troubling even if you did. In fact, it just makes me more irritated."

"Eh…?"

"You guys were beaten to a pulp by Kiyotaka, and since you lost you have no choice but to apologize."

"Well, that's… not…"

"If Kiyotaka didn't come to the rooftop… or if he lost to you guys, you wouldn't apologize like this. Am I wrong? You guys are just annoying me."

There was logic in Kei calling it weird and troubling.

Although there have been instances where I've interacted with Ishizaki and Albert since then, that's mostly because of what happened on the roof. The hypothetical Kei mentioned was not unreasonable.

"I know that there's nothing I can do if you blame me, but…"

"I'm not really blaming you. The strong being on top is natural. I hated being at the bottom too, so in order to be on top I took this high and mighty attitude. Isn't that right?"

Kei and Ishizaki had similar natures, but to different degrees. If you can't beat them, join them. That's the kind of sense of values they had.

"I get what you're trying to say. But – since we've also started to interact, there is something I do understand, if only a little: Ishizaki has definitely matured in a good way."

"What's this good way? It seems to me like he hasn't changed at all?"

"Well, at the end of the day it's just how I feel, but I think that if Ryuuen right now asked Ishizaki to do to someone else the same thing they did to you, Ishizaki would not simply obey."

"Really? I don't think he would go against Ryuuen, though."

That was probably right on the mark, as Ishizaki was at a loss for words.

Unable to say a thing, his frustration boiled over, so Ishizaki struck his own knees with his palms. Seeing Ishizaki like that, Kei sighed.

"That's enough. Right now, you are Kiyotaka's friend, right? I won't forgive you but I will stop blaming you."

"Is- is that alright?"

"I've already said it, haven't I? It's over, got it?

"Y, yes!"

Ishizaki raised his head in happiness.

"Umm… So about that. Earlier, whose birthday was it?

Ishizaki asked her again. Kei still didn't trust him fully yet, but she pointed her index finger at me.

"Eh? Really? Ayanokouji's birthday is also October 20th!?

Ishizaki was shocked beyond words.

“This is fate, isn’t it!?”

“What fate, there’s more than 400 people in this school, it’s not strange that there are some people with the same birthday.”

“But, isn’t it amazing that it’s Ayanokouji and Ryuuen?”

Ishizaki was overjoyed over a simple coincidence. As Kei said, it wasn’t strange, but for some reason even Albert looked a little happy.

“Can we return to the store now?”

“Ah! Right! Wait a sec!”

His voice was so loud that Kei, annoyed, plugged her fingers into her ears.

“I have a suggestion – if it’s okay with you, why don’t we celebrate both their birthdays together? Ryuuen-san’s and Ayanokouji’s double birthday party, won’t it be amazing?”

No, from the moment I heard that suggestion, I did not for a second think it would be amazing…

I tried to imagine it, but I couldn’t really picture it well.

“If he apologizes, I’m okay?”

“Eh?”

“I said if that guy, Ryuuen lowers his head then I accept.”

Her response was a pretense to refuse.

Ishisaki’s jaw dropped. Then he realized how difficult it would be, and his mouth changed to look like へ.

“Ryuuen won’t apologize to me, right?

“Eh? Well yeah, that’s definitely not happening……”

It might have been impossible for Ishizaki to even suggest it to Ryuuen. Ishizaki was stunned, but gathering his determination, he pursed his lips with great force.

“If both of you agree, then I will suggest it to him!”

“You probably shouldn’t?”

A beating was probably waiting for him if he did that. Ryuuen was a well known figure in our year, so that was the image that came to our minds.

“I’ll do something about it! If I can get the promise of an apology, it’ll be a birthday party!”

“Well… if you can really make it happen I’ll think about it…”

Ishizaki was overflowing with his passion and even this cheap promise wouldn’t bring down his mood.

Maybe I should also clearly reject this idea.

It’s true that Ishizaki has been able to express his intentions more strongly of late. Furthermore, judging from the fact that he didn’t expel anyone during the Unanimous Consent Special Test, it was also true that Ryuuen’s way of thought was beginning to change.

However, I shouldn’t read into it as proof of whether that was his instinct or his real intentions. Even if you want to change, humans don’t change that easily.

And Ryuuen wasn’t trying to change, he was trying to evolve.

Being a man who has only fought using evil, he has simply started to use good too. He was beginning to freely control what happened both above

and below the table.

If Ishizaki's read on him was wrong, then――

"I think you should probably stop."

Kei tried to stop him, but Ishizaki's resolve wouldn't be broken.

"If Ryuuen says he will apologize, it's fine right?"

"But ――"

"I understand! On top of that, let me apologize again. I'll get you something that I put even more effort into than I put into Ryuuen-san's present!"

Having lost to Ishizaki's energy, Kei hesitantly agreed, saying "Okay, I get it."

"Done! First, let's go look for Ryuuen-san's birthday present!"

Albert nodded, and he and Ishizaki went back towards the mega mart before us. They clearly understood that the two of us could not go with them.

"Why did you accept Ishizaki's idea? I thought you would shoot him down."

Accepting the honest apology was one thing, but she had never thought I'd choose to meet Ishizaki and the others on my birthday.

"I mean, for me, being together on your birthday, just the two of us would be great… but……"

"Are you betting on the chance that Ryuuen will apologize?"

"That's impossible. It's not that……"

Kei turned around and looked at Albert and Ishizaki as they were walking away from us. Ishizaki was happily talking to Albert.

“I could feel that Ishizaki-kun likes being your friend. Even Kiyotaka needs friends, you know.”

I quickly realized that she was referring to the fact that the Ayanokouji group was in pieces.

Kei realized I had guessed what she was thinking and turned away, her face bright red.

“Also? Ishizaki-kun did say he would once again apologize, and I just thought it wouldn’t be a bad thing to accept that.”

That side of her that wasn’t honest was somehow very Kei.

But, it was more likely that it wouldn’t come true. It was better to take Ishizaki’s proposal with a grain of salt.

Like this the days passed till the day of the Sports Festival.

3

After escaping from the electronics store just before, Satou stopped in front of the girls' restroom to catch her breath.

"Ughh, why did I run off!"

Her dear friend was going out with the guy she liked. There was nothing wrong with that. She knew that, but when she saw them arm in arm, an unspeakable urge had hit her. She didn't know what kind of attitude she'd end up taking if she'd stayed there any longer. That thought had made her run off so suddenly, but now she felt terribly guilty about it.

She sat down there, hugging her knees.

"I'll have to try not to panic next time…"

Since she was like this, there was no doubt that Kei-chan was also toning it down with Ayanokouji-kun in the classroom. Otherwise, she would have wanted to cling onto him, so, so much more. So she thought, and when she stood up a shadow fell on her.

"Excuse me for butting in, but are you Satou Maya-senpai?"

Faced with an unfamiliar student calling out to her, Satou was flustered.

"Yes, I am, but… Erm, who are you? You must be a first-year, right?"

"I don't think who I am matters very much right now. The thing is, there's an urgent message I have to pass onto you, Satou-senpai. Can you please spare me some of your time?"

"E-eh? What do you mean?"

She was confused by this unfamiliar junior who said they had something to tell her. The sight of Ayanokouji and Karuizawa clinging to each other wasn't fully out of the back of her mind yet, so she wasn't able to calm down.

"It has to do with Ayanokouji-senpai."

But when she heard those words, she stopped shaking.

"… Ayanokouji-kun?"

"Yes. With him, and his girlfriend, Karuizawa Kei-senpai."

When they named the two people who were taking up 99% of her brain's processing capacity, Satou subconsciously turned to look at them. As they slowly closed on her, she grew slightly nervous.

"Can you please come with me, so we can go somewhere else and discuss this comfortably, just the two of us?"

"That's…"

The first year student nimbly drew up to her, until they were so close their lips were almost at her ear.

"If Karuizawa-senpai were expelled─don't you think you'd have a chance, Satou-senpai?"

The closest friend she had right now, Karuizawa, and the person she liked, Ayanokouji. They spoke of changing the relationship between those two, and Satou's own position.



A range of emotions overflowed from her.

“Wh-what are you saying?”

“Whether you want to hear me out or not is up to you, Satou-senpai. However, if you choose not to, I’m sure you will come to regret it for the rest of your life. If you don’t want to be seen by others, I don’t mind meeting in my dorm room either.”

Seemingly satisfied after telling her their dorm room number, the first year student turned away from Satou and left.

Left alone, Satou remained confused, unable to process the situation. However, just one thing remained stuck in her memory.

“You’d have a chance.”

Those words, which implied she had a chance to date Ayanokouji. Her chest tightened, and simultaneously an emotion she didn’t want to know crawled out of her.

“I—”

4

While some of the problems were still unresolved, the class pressed forward in their careful preparations for the Sports Festival. There were students who were opposed to competing alongside Ryuuen, but once they got going and preparations were underway, there weren't any major arguments and the practice for the team events was also coming along well. Even those members of the class who had initially opposed it decided not to withhold their cooperation so that they could win and threw themselves into practice and training day and night.

And so finally came the day before the Sports Festival. Around 9:30 PM, I made a phone call to Horikita.

"Surprisingly late for you to call, isn't it? I was just about to go to bed."

Through the earpiece, I could hear a hair dryer running.

"I've got something important to say regarding the Sports Festival."

"You have something important to say? I better take this somewhat seriously, then." She said, and she must've quickly turned off the hair dryer because the earpiece went quiet. "Ah, before that, I had something I wanted to say. Sakayanagi-san is set on participating in the Sports Festival tomorrow, you know? Didn't you say you could stop her?"

"What I have to say has to do with that, too. I'm thinking of sitting out the Sports Festival tomorrow."

"…Sitting out? Wait just a moment, what do you mean?"

It was pretty clear that on the other side of the phone, she was thrown by my sudden announcement. Something clattered, and I could hear a small

cry.

“Are you alright?”

“Sorry, I just dropped the hair dryer…”

I could hear her put the phone down somewhere. I guess she was hastily trying to pick up the hair dryer.

“So, what do you mean by sitting out? You’re not unwell or anything, right?”

It wasn’t unreasonable for her to be confused, given that I sounded healthy.

“Ah, no, there’s no problems with my health. Rather, it’s like I feel better than I usually do.”

“Then why? If you sit it out, we’ll lose ten points, you know? Even though I wasn’t banking on the points you win in my calculations, losing those ten points will be painful.”

The class had just 38 people—fewer than the others—so I understood why she felt like complaining.

“I’m not going to say those ten points aren’t worth much. But this is my strategy, it’s essential.”

“… Your strategy?”

Of course, it didn’t have anything to do with things like my father’s agent coming and blending in with the guests.

I brought up something I’d kept quiet about thus far.

“It’s connected to the first step of my attack on Sakayanagi, which we cannot avoid if we want to push Class A to the last position.”

“Attack on Sakayanagi…?”

“I told you. That I have a way to keep Sakayanagi from participating in the Sports Festival.”

“But I don’t understand how you sitting it out has anything to do with attacking Sakayanagi…”

She went to ask me my reasoning, but she quickly stopped in her tracks.

“I see. I won’t be able to understand what you’re planning, not as I am right now. And I suppose you won’t change your mind about skipping the Sports Festival even if I try to persuade you otherwise?”

“Yeah. First thing tomorrow morning, I’ll tell the school that I’m sick.”

“If that’s the case, I guess I have no choice but to trust you at this point.”

She was exasperated, but she allowed it and gave her consent regardless.

“Just so you know, my personal goal was to take first place at least thrice, but because of this I will have to score more than ten points myself.”

“Thanks for your support.”

I cut the call and put my phone to charge. Even though she was just about to go to bed, I imagine Horikita would be unable to sleep for a while as she adjusts her calculations for the scores in her head. What I did was a bit rough on her, but she should treat it as a necessary expense.

Now, there’s one more person I need to call. After I tell them the necessary information, all the setup will be done.

Chapter 5

Introduction

It was morning. All the students were gathered at the grounds, and I was watching over them from the faculty area. Student Council President Nagumo was making the opening remarks from a podium which had been set up. Watching him were the guests who had been invited from outside. There weren't that many of them, just a few dozen. Despite that, it seemed like the students were restless in the presence of outsiders they weren't used to seeing. They were wired and eager to throw themselves at the field set for the Sports Festival.

We had been informed about the guests beforehand by the Student Council President, but—despite their numbers—we felt so much more pressure than we'd imagined. They were people from the political or other circles which had been involved in the foundation of this school. There weren't any politicians you'd recognize from having seen on the TV before, but they weren't too far from that status either. They were all dressed in suits and wore stiff expressions as they watched; it was almost like they were monitoring prisoners. And even with all of that, President Nagumo continued to speak boldly without quivering even a bit. He was fulfilling his role, in no way inferior to the splendid image my brother had shown to the students. After he concluded his remarks and the students gave him an ovation, the baton was passed to the teachers, who then reiterated the key points about the Sports Festival. And then we approached the time to start.

After this, students were free to do whatever they wanted. So long as they followed the rules, they could participate in a competition they had entered, or they could check out their opposition, decide that it wasn't a good deal

and withdraw from the event at the last-minute to participate in some other competition, provided they had two points. And we had to keep in mind that, as a rule, once a student had finished participating in all of their matches and had none other they were scheduled to participate in, they would have to go to a designated area and were assigned the duty to cheer for their class. If they were caught chatting or resting at some place they weren't supposed to be in, or playing hooky, they would not only lose their right to participate, but would also be stripped of their points.

Further, together with Ryuuen's class, which we had joined in a cooperative relationship, we made adjustments to avoid facing each other in individual events as far as possible, and structured teams for the team matches such that both classes selected students who could win with ease. We then split the number of students fifty-fifty, and ensured that both classes would get the same number of points regardless of whether they won or lost.

And then, no matter how capable a student was, we decided on an upper limit for the number of team competitions they participated in. This was a measure to ensure that the outstanding athletes such as Sudou-kun and Yamada Albert-kun weren't bound for a long period of time, and so we agreed that one person could help out in at most three team matches. In the contract, we restricted this agreement to events they signed up for before the day itself.

It would be ridiculous for them to fight and say "help out here" or "help out there" on the day of the Sports Festival itself. Also, we didn't enforce a hard and fast rule that they couldn't team up with students from Ichinose-san's class or Sakayanagi-san's class either. If they could make good use of it in a match, we were accepting of them teaming up on a case by case basis. I wasn't worried because I worked on this with Katsuragi-kun over and over again so that it wouldn't become an issue.

I didn't have much to worry about at the beginning of the competition as many would be participating in competitions they had signed up for in advance. I must not forget that I should debrief my classmates every hour,

and keep tabs on whether issues come up and make minor adjustments when required.

The first competition I was participating in was the 100 meter race. It started fifteen minutes after the festival opened, so I didn't need to hurry, but I wanted to get there early and check out the other particip─

"Come, Horikita! Fight me!!"

The person who ran up to me at full speed the moment after everyone had been dismissed to do whatever they wanted was Ibuki-san. She kept glaring at me even though she was panting.

"Are you stupid?"

"Huh?! What are you saying? You scared of losing to me? You are, aren't you?"

"Not at all." I rejected her instantly. "Which competition are you in right after this? Pace your breath before you answer."

"… Huh?! It's the 100 meter race, of course! I won't forget it, we decided this together."

"Yes, the 100 meter race. And we are registered for the very first race. That's what we decided. Therefore, you will have to run soon after this. And despite that, why are you sprinting around at full speed just before you have to participate? I shouldn't have to tell you that we've already decided that we'll be facing off, so what you should do is to go to the designated area and wait."

"Shit," she muttered, making it obvious that she only understood the situation she was in after I told her. "A-anyway, fight me!"

"Relax. You don't need to tell me, I will fight you."

Ibuki-san wasn't going to go down easy. Last year in the 100 meter race, I won only by a small margin.

If possible I'd have liked to avoid you as an opponent, but I had something to be very grateful to you for.

If Ibuki-san hadn't helped me, Kushida-san might not have started going to school yet. But that didn't mean I could give her the win. I'm sure you don't want that either, so I'll win fair and square. Ibuki-san, unhappy at the prospect of walking with me, made some distance and set off for the first event at the same time I did. A pleasant tension rose within me.

First up was a match with only second year girls. Sticking close to the conditions we had agreed on in advance, the only person who could be my rival would be Ibuki-san. But it would be foolish to think that that was good luck. If I was getting an easy fight, that meant some other person was going to face off against a tough enemy in some other fight.

1

The 100-meter race was held right after the opening ceremony; It was my first match against Ibuki-san. It resulted in a narrow victory for me. Strangely enough, I won with about the same small lead as I had last year. Ibuki-san kicked up the dirt in frustration after reaching the goal, giving the excuse that she'd dashed with all her strength before the match.

My next bout with her would be the long jump at the fourth event. The two events in between would be fought separately.

The second event was the obstacle course, in which I placed first. The third event was the tug-of-war team event, in which we placed third. The points I have gained up until now are: 5 points from the start, 10 points from getting two solo first-places, 3 points from getting third in the tug-of-war team event, and 3 points for participation – resulting in a total of 21 points. This could be called an excellent start.

Then, once 10 AM came around, my second bout with Ibuki-san, the long jump, was about to start.

I took the single jump that would decide that match, and for me, the event ended at that moment. I recorded a distance of 5 meters, 79 centimeters. Not bad. In a situation where failure was not acceptable, I might have recorded what was almost a new personal best.

Ibuki-san, who was three turns behind me, regulated her breathing as she stared at the results. There were three people left to jump. I had leapfrogged to the first place, so I was really close to scoring a lot from this event.

"Suzune! I found you!"

As I kept an eye on the next runner, I heard a voice calling out to me from behind. Looking back, I saw Sudou-kun rushing up to me with Onodera-san walking behind him. They're the pair I have great expectations of as high-scorers for this Sports Festival.

"From how you look, things must be going well."

"Since the start, Sudou-kun's had three straight victories, you know. What's more, he made it look easy. I should've expected that!!"

"Eh, I guess. But you know, Onodera's taken first place in both events she's fought. Yeah?"

"Well, in my case, I did get a bit lucky."

Onodera, unparalleled in swimming, had fully demonstrated her talent even on land.

"I didn't have the impression that you were that fast when we first entered school. When did you improve?"

I was curious, especially since I've been watching her all along in P.E. class.

"I don't really like running, and I'm not interested in stuff other than swimming, so maybe I was just not taking it seriously…"

"Ya said you definitely won't do long distance!"

"I get super tired; I can't run that much–there isn't a single good thing about it!"

It seems they have been practicing every day since deciding to team up. They're much more natural of a combo than I had imagined.

"Well, to be honest, you know, I wanted to fight against Kouenji if I could. That dude also got first in all three events he participated in, and seems like he'll continue that streak."

“That’s no good. Going against your classmates is not a good idea. You understand that, right?”

Both Sudou-kun and Kouenji-kun hold the potential to take first place. I understand their desire to race against each other, but they must prioritize the class right now.

“I-I get it. It’s just a joke.”

“It’s fine. I’ll keep an eye on him for that. Don’t worry.”

“I see. The more I can trust you with, Onodera-san, the less I’ll have to worry unnecessarily.”

“Y’all don’t believe in me one bit…”

He looked unsatisfied, but he averted his gaze when I looked him in the eyes… This must be proof that he was reflecting on what he had done in the past.

“After this, you guys are scheduled to participate in successive doubles’ events, aren’t you? Good luck.”

“You bet. We’re gonna keep this winning streak rolling.”

Promising words. But then, at that moment, the last runner went up to the starting line. I stopped our conversation for a moment and turned my gaze towards Ibuki-san.

“We can’t keep bothering her. Let’s go scout out the next event.”

“Yeah, let’s do that. See you later, Horikita-san.”

“Yeah.”

I gave them a sidelong glance and looked at Ibuki-san, who had begun her running start. I understand full well that Ibuki-san’s abilities are close to my own. In other words, It’s reasonable to think that she could surpass my

record. I'm wavering between wanting her to lose and wanting to have a good match against her at full strength.

She should have been under a lot of pressure, but her movements were sharp and refined. After she jumped and landed, she leaned forwards and fell. Though she had dirt on her face, she quickly turned towards the record keeper. 5 meters 81 centimeters. It was just 2 centimeters, but even so, mine being 2 centimeters short had settled my defeat.

"I did it!"

Ibuki-san struck a victory pose and made a big fuss like a child. She was one down and had no second chances, but she still made a splendid jump.

"Did you see? I won! You lose!!"

I can understand she felt so happy she wanted to bug me, but I must admit she was being a bit irritating.

"As I thought, you might've had the advantage because you don't have as much air resistance…"

If we assume that there was no difference in skill between Ibuki-san and me, then the gap between us could be explained by that…

"Huh? Air resistance?"

"It's nothing."

"Don't be a sore loser. Just honestly admit you lost!"

"Don't get carried away. This means I have one win, one loss. All this means is that we're back to being tied."

I tried warning her to keep her from flying off, but she kept her smirk throughout. I should feel bad for losing first place, but if she's so happy I guess it's alright…

“I won! I won! I won!”

… No, it isn’t.

If anything, it made my mental stress jump up. With this, I was at one win, one loss. I wanted to get to our third match as soon as possible. Still, after this, I was looking out for a few high-scoring team events, so my showdown with her would have to wait for the balance beam competition in the afternoon.

2

During the sports festival, there was an electronic scoreboard on the athletic field, so we could always keep an eye on how every class was doing. Ryuuen-kun's class started the competition at the top of our grade, but shortly after, our Class B took over first place and maintained that position. In second place was Class D, third place Class C, and fourth place Class A. It was the ideal ranking for us. Now, if only things would stay this way till the end.

I had some time left till my next competition, so I moved to the cheering seats to kill time.

"Good work out there, Horikita-senpai."

Yagami-kun, from Class 1-B, came over, calling out to me as he did.

"Your class seems to be doing well, too. You're a close second place."

"You too, senpai. Aren't you guys in first place? It's difficult to imagine this is the same class that started as Class D last year!"

"Was that a compliment? Or was some sarcasm thrown in there too?"

"Not at all! I genuinely respect you, although not as much as Student Council President Nagumo."

I followed his gaze to find Student Council President Nagumo running through the ribbon at a finish line.

"Some upperclassmen in the third year were talking about it just now. Apparently, this is his fifth consecutive win."

Girls cheered the Student Council President as the guests turned their attention to him. However, President Nagumo looked expressionless as he left the place. He brushed off the girls that called out to him, telling them he wanted to be alone as he distanced himself.

“He would usually at least pay lip service to them, but he doesn’t look the least bit happy,” I said.

“He is almost guaranteed to graduate in Class A, regardless of whether he wins or loses. So, maybe he can’t get fired up for this?”

Indeed. The Student Council President was in a rock-solid position, and so for him, the rankings of the sports festival would have no meaning. I guess the only reason he is aiming for first place is because he doesn’t want to hold back in front of the guests and the other students.

“I’ll go have a chat with the Student Council President,” I said.

“Is that so? Well, I have my next competition, so I’ll excuse myself.”

After a casual conversation with Yagami-kun, I approached the Student Council President. Alongside him was a third-year girl who was speaking to him. Kiryuuin-senpai, from Class 3-B. From time to time when I’d interact with third-year students, I’d hear a few things about her. I was also aware that she had excellent scores on the OAA.

I couldn’t interrupt them, so I simply bowed and waited.

“Congrats on the 5 wins in a row, Nagumo!”

“Why are you here?”

“You don’t have to be so cold-hearted, you know? I’m just concerned that you don’t look all that happy despite winning. Seems like there are more than one or two people cheering for you.”

“Don’t make me laugh. As if winning a competition of that level would mean anything to me.”

“Knowing you, you could’ve just gathered all the weaklings and have them compete against you for an easy first place. Though looking at the lineup for that race, it sure doesn’t look like you did that.” Kiryuuin-senpai pointed out the fact that he wasn’t trying to take the easy way. “Word around the block is that Ayanokouji is absent today. Is that why you look so upset?”

Ayanokouji. Once again, his name came up even in a place like this. President Nagumo didn’t turn to face Kiryuin-senpai even once. He sighed quietly.

“I thought at least he would finally quench my thirst, but it seems I had the wrong idea.”

“Poor little thing, how about I take you on?”

Her provocative taunt made President Nagumo glance at Kiryuin-senpai from the corner of his eye for the first time. However, after seeing her defiant smile, he turned away once again.

“What a pointless lie. Even if I wanted to, I can’t even imagine you seriously offering me a fight. Am I wrong?”

“Fufufu. You got me, huh?” Kiryuuin-senpai confessed, shrugging as she drew closer to President Nagumo’s side. “I’ll be done with my minimum requirements after the next event. I’m planning to relax and watch the matches after that.”

“Of course you are.”

“You should stop giving these underclassmen the time of day. You’ve already dominated our grade and are fixed at Class A. On top of that, you’ve achieved a lot as the student council president. That should be enough. I recommend you graduate quietly.”

Almost as if she was advising him on what to do, Kiryuin-senpai admonished him.

"*You're* giving me advice? What's this change of heart? I think we've spoken more times in the six months since you've gotten involved with Ayanokouji than we did in the two years prior."

"Maybe you're right."

"Don't worry, Kiryuuin. You don't need to tell me; I'm not going to play around with Ayanokouji anymore. He chose not to fight me, and there's no point in thinking about it too deeply."



“If he lost a direct confrontation against the Student Council President, he wouldn’t be able to move on as if nothing had happened. Try to understand why he ran away. He has such a cute side to him, doesn’t he?”

Fight against Student Council President Nagumo? Ayanokoji-kun was going to? Is that why I was asked to call him to the student council room—so President Nagumo could tell him that? It fits with the message he asked me to pass on, too.

Kiryuuin-senpai glanced at me, but she walked away without saying anything.

“I kept you waiting, Suzune. Did you need anything from me?”

“No, um, I was going to ask the same thing that Kiryuuin-senpai did. I watched you take first place, but you didn’t look happy about it at all, so. And, well… Ayanokouji-kun had promised to fight you at the sports festival, I see.”

“In the end, it didn’t happen. He is absent, and it ended with that.”

Ayanokoji-kun had said that he was not absent because of illness but rather as a strategy to keep Sakayanagi-san from participating. President Nagumo seemed unaware of that fact, and it was probably better not to reveal that carelessly.

“Come with me for a bit during lunch break. We’ll meet at—”

He invited me without any concern about whether I wanted to, so I had no choice but to accept.

Sometime later, when it was time for lunch, I found myself looking at the boxed lunches provided on the athletic field. One could take whatever they wanted from a diverse lineup, from light meals like sandwiches to stamina and power-boosting katsudon and other meals. I was impressed and astonished at how well prepared and thorough this school was.

Moreover, one could take as much as one wanted, with the only condition being that they had to finish all of it. Most students simply picked one lunch and left, but while I watched a few male students took several. Among them, there was one student with a particularly large figure happily holding three or four lunches to his chest. If I recall correctly, I think he was a first-year student… if he thought he could eat all that and still compete in the afternoon competitions, he was either underestimating this school or actually a really big shot.

“I kept you waiting.”

As I was reaching for one of the lighter meals, President Nagumo called out to me.

“What is it you wanted to talk about? I have a meeting soon, so I’d appreciate it if we keep it brief.”

“Yeah. I want to know about Ayanokoji. He seems unwell. Did he fall ill out of nowhere?”

He didn’t point it out earlier, but it seemed like President Nagumo still doubted him.

“Yes. This morning, he apologized and informed me he was sitting out. One student sitting out would mean losing ten points, but it’s not like I could force him if he’s sick.”

I was the only one who knew he was absent for a different reason. So, obviously, I answered the way I did.

“It’d be fine if he really was unwell.”

“What do you mean by that?”

I don’t think my attitude gave it away. Did the Student Council President have some reason to think otherwise?

“You heard my conversation with Kiryuuin, right? Maybe he didn’t want to embarrass himself, so he shut himself in.”

“That’s right. It would be difficult to be sure that that’s not the case.”

I gave out a safe answer to not provoke him.

“This might cause some trouble for your grade.”

“What does that mean?”

“I have no choice but to make someone else pay the price for him bailing out on me, isn’t that right?”

He didn’t answer my question and simply mumbled to himself instead. Then he raised his hand to indicate he was leaving and walked away without even picking up a lunch box.

“Price…? Cause trouble for my grade? What was that about…? Even so —”

Everyone, everywhere seemed to have a really high opinion of him. Once again, I was impressed by him at today’s sports festival. When he said he’d be absent, I was worried about how it would turn out. Still, when it actually came to pass Sakayanagi-san was also absent.

Without a doubt, Ayanokouji-kun had done something to hold Sakayanagi-san back. And the result was obvious when you looked at Class A’s current standings and scores. Because their commander suddenly couldn’t come, it was no surprise that they couldn’t coordinate so well. I felt a little bad for them, but this was a serious competition. Whenever there’s a chance to win, I’d like to take it.

3

After the midday break, it was time for the second half of the Sports Festival. More than half the students had already completed the minimum number of five competitions that they were required to participate in, and students who were confident in their athletic abilities were moving on to their sixth and seventh events. Up against Horikita and Ichinose, who were assessing the status and participants of competitions minute-by-minute, Class A's Matoba and Shimizu continued to struggle in the absence of their leader.

"There's doubles table tennis in the gym next. I just heard from Satonaka, and it doesn't look like there are any strong opponents. There are two spaces left, and there's a good chance we can make it in time."

"We've gotta build up wins and make sure we at least don't end up at the bottom of the standings."

Sakayanagi's absence had cast a dark shadow over Class 2-A, and many students were losing morale. However, no small number of them were motivated by it instead.

When they heard that the doubles table tennis—which would be closing entries in 10 minutes—wasn't well defended, they abandoned the penalty shootout that they had initially planned on taking part in and started for it in a hurry. Just at that moment, Ishizaki, walking in from the direction they were headed, had his head cast downwards slightly and wasn't looking ahead. Shimizu moved to his right to avoid Ishizaki as he approached, but Ishizaki also moved to his left at almost the same time.

Shimizu tried, but failed, to avoid running into him, and their shoulders bumped into each other. The impact of their collision was twice as strong as

expected, and could not have happened by accident. Judging that he had been forcibly hit on the shoulder, Shimizu tried to raise his voice, but—

“Fuck, that hurt…! Watch where you’re walking, asshole!”

Even before Shimizu could do anything, Ishizaki was shouting an accusation for all to hear.

“*You’re* the one who wasn’t watching where you were going, I could’ve gotten hurt!”

Class A’s Shimizu and Class D’s Ishizaki started glaring at each other.

“You’re the one who wasn’t facing forward!”

“Huh?! You playing victim or what? …You didn’t bump into me on purpose, *did you*?”

“No, what? No matter how you look at it, *you* deliberately bumped into *me*. Right?”

Looking for help, Shimizu asked for Matoba to cover for him.

“Yeah. You weren’t properly looking where you were going.”

“Yeah I was. The two of you are making shit up. Real dirty, aintcha.”

“What’s dirty? No matter how you look at it, you’re in the wrong.”

“Huuh?! *Me*?! You lot were lost in talking to each other and weren’t paying attention!”

The blame-game continued with Ishizaki not even ready to apologize, and time just kept flying by. Despite believing that they were in the right, Matoba urged Shimizu to calm down since they were in a hurry.

“Just leave it. Arguing with a guy like this…”

“I can’t accept this, though.”

“I get how you feel. I’m the same, but we’ve got more important things to do right now.”

“…That’s true.”

Although he empathized with Shimizu, he reminded him that they had a competition to win. Shimizu was reluctant, but nodded and glared at Ishizaki before walking away.

“Next time, be careful.”

“…Ouch.”

“Huh?”

Ishizaki muttered, suddenly holding his left shoulder as they tried to pass him.

“I was so worked up I didn’t even notice, but… I reckon I might’ve gotten hurt just now.”

For a moment, the two of them didn’t understand what he was saying, but then they soon caught on. It was a cheap trap set up by Ishizaki after all. They looked at each other and laughed through their noses. However, things took a sharp turn immediately after.

“It’s getting real lively over here. What’s going on, Ishizaki?”

“Ryuuen-san! Please listen to me! This lot is trying to mess with me!”

Ryuuen showed up to the place where they’d almost gotten to blows.

“Ryuuen…now this fucking pain in the ass has got involved… To think you’d use such an obvious tactic.”

“Oh? What are you talking about? I only came by ’cause I heard a disturbance, you know?”

“Stop with the jokes. You lot have already been caught doing the same shit before.”

“Same shit? Oh, *that*. Sure, we might’ve done something similar in the past.”

“So you already know.”

“But you know? Even if we’ve got a record, whether or not we’re doing anything now is completely unrelated. It’d be a big problem if my cute underling was done in and injured by some underhanded Class A schemes.”

“Cute underling, what? You’re behind this, aren’t you? Enough of this, I’m gonna call a teacher over…!”

“Kuku. You’re right, if there’s trouble, we’ll just have to rely on the teachers. That’d be just great! We’re the victims here. We’ll go through it thoroughly, so rest assured. Ain’t that right, Ishizaki?”

“Right! I’m the victim!”

“How are *you* the victim? You lot aren’t even taking this sports festival seriously… you’re really okay with us calling for a teacher?”

Matoba decided that it was unavoidable, whispered in Shimizu’s ear, and then Shimizu ran off to somewhere else. But soon after going to call a teacher over, he returned with a depressed expression.

“What’s up? Where’s the teacher?”

“Uh, that’s—”

Shimizu brought back not a teacher, but his classmate, Hashimoto Masayoshi.

“I saw Shimizu running angrily, so I asked him what was going on. If you carelessly call a teacher, you’ll only make this a bigger problem. If they have to decide who’s right and who’s wrong, you might not be able to participate in the competition.”

“But!”

“I know. But right now, Ryuuen is aiming to make a scene. Don’t play into his hands.”

Hashimoto put his hand on Shimizu’s shoulder and asked him to draw back.

“I’ll try talking to him for now.”

“… Alright. Please take care of this quickly.”

Matoba had no choice but to leave it to Hashimoto to settle the situation, and so he, too, watched from a short distance.

“Let’s keep it civil, Ryuuen.”

Hashimoto heard about what happened and calmly walked into the commotion.

“Huh? Your lot started it. They came looking for a fight, and I obliged. That’s all.”

“I get it. But if you don’t pull back, we’ll be in trouble too. Our big earners for this sports festival are here, so you’re holding back our main force. I feel bad for saying it, but Ishizaki’s scores are only so-so, right?”

It would be clear to any observer that Ryuuen’s side was picking a fight. Hashimoto tried to focus on that point to hold Ryuuen from pushing strongly.

“Don’t underestimate him so much. Ishizaki has been working hard constantly, pouring in his blood, sweat and tears for this day. All so that he could compete with those big earners you were talking about. Right?”

“Right!”

Hashimoto had seen Ishizaki playing around so many times in the days leading up to the sports festival that he couldn’t help but be stunned.

“Jeez. You’re really gonna take every chance you get, eh?” Hashimoto knew he couldn’t compete in an honest discussion, but he scratched his head, unable to let it go. “But now it’s clear. You seriously intend to crush us in this sports festival. You’re making the elites from the first year dog us so unpleasantly, right?”

He noticed early on that physically gifted first-year students were following the more capable students from Class 2-A and joining any competitions they were participating in. However, they couldn’t withdraw from the competition after they noticed, and so they had been underperforming so far.

“Since the princess is absent today, we’re getting pretty desperate to avoid last place. If we make an enemy of you too, we won’t have any chance of winning. Let’s not make a fuss and just call it a draw.”

“A draw?”

Ryuuen had been relatively amiable until that point, but then he suddenly changed completely and his smile vanished.

“I don’t give a shit about what’s going on in Class A. We’re Class D. I’m using everything I’ve got to crawl up from the bottom. If you think you can interfere with that and easily strike a deal, you’re dead wrong.”

Hashimoto had been wearing a thin smile, but he froze at the vigor with which Ryuuen had pounced.

“Then what do you want? Us to give you a unilateral apology?”

“So you know after all. It’s not like we’re trying to get you to pay up. We just want a heartfelt apology. Right, Ishizaki?”

“Mhm. The pain in my arm has gone away a bit, so that’s enough for me.”

What would hurt more than anything was for them to lose any more time. Upon confirming that they wouldn’t demand monetary compensation or the like, Hashimoto decided to accept the proposal.

“I’ll try and persuade them, so gimme a sec.”

“Be quick about it. We’ve got another competition coming up too.”

Over five minutes had already passed since the altercation began.

They might just about be able to make it in time if they apologized immediately and ran to the gymnasium—though it would go right down to the wire.

“You heard him. I know it’s hard to accept, but I think you should take it on the chin and apologize.”

“Are you kidding me? I kept quiet and listened ’cause you said you’d do something about it. And now you’re telling me to do whatever they want and unilaterally apologize? There’s no fucking way.”

“Then you’re fine with us not winning? If you stubbornly hold strong here, you might be able to protect your pride. But when we lose by 5 or 10 points, will you be alright with that?”

“Th-that’s…”

“What matters right now is that our class wins, right? It’s just that we happened to step in some dog shit and ended up feeling like crap.”

If they just gave a word of apology, they could head straight back to the competition, so he urged.

“Shit…! Why do I have to…?”

Shimizu made a grand display of his irritation, but he then calmed himself and—despite being reluctant—agreed to it. He stepped forward to apologize to Ishizaki.

“Hold on, Shimizu. Matoba over there is just as guilty. He said I wasn’t paying attention.”

“…Matoba.”

“Alright, I get it…”

Left with no other choice, the two of them stood side by side and bowed their heads to Ishizaki, albeit only slightly.

“Our bad… That’s enough, right?”

They quickly raised their lowered heads and tried to leave, but Ishizaki stopped them immediately.

“Ryuuen-san… it doesn’t make sense to me, what even was that?”

“Well, that’s obvious. They grudgingly bowed their heads a little bit, but inside, they’re swearing at you. There’s no way you’d consider that a genuine apology. It isn’t sincere enough.”

“Are you out of your mind, Ryuuen? I can’t hold them back any more than this.”

Hashimoto judged that this was the most he could hold Matoba and Shimizu back. He ran to get a teacher, realizing that there was no way other than for them to intervene. About a minute later, he returned with one.

“What on earth is going on?”

“The truth is—”

“I accept your apology.”

Ishizaki declared, just before Hashimoto was about to tell the teacher what had transpired.

“I’m sorry, Ryuuen-san. You gave me all sorts of advice, but maybe I wasn’t mature enough to just let it go when he gave me a little shoulder bump… so I think I’ll forgive them since the two of them apologized to me earlier. Is that okay?”

“Isn’t that nice? If you’re gonna accept it, then—since I’m an unrelated party—it’s not my place to butt in.”

After seeing Ryuuen try to end the discussion there, the teacher tried to figure out what the situation was. Hashimoto—who had brought the teacher with him because he thought it was a necessary sacrifice to get out of this situation—was also left bewildered, unable to follow what was going on.

The teacher reached a conclusion based only on what he had seen so far.

“So the two of you apologized to Ishizaki for bumping into him. And he accepted. Am I understanding this correctly?”

“That’s—!”

Shimizu tried to speak up when he saw the teacher consider the problem solved, but Hashimoto stopped him.

“That seems to be the case. It has been resolved.”

“That’s alright then. In any case, please try to avoid any scuffles during the sports festival, okay?”

Seeing the duo about to explode in anger, Hashimoto waved them away to get them to promptly leave the scene.

“Hurry up and get going while the teacher is watching. Yeah?”

The two of them turned around and glared at Ishizaki and Ryuuen a few times, but they were eventually lost among the crowd heading towards the

gymnasium. When Hashimoto was left alone, he let out a deep sigh.

“Doing this kinda thing when there’s people watching, jeez… he’s really not someone you want to make an enemy of.”

Hashimoto was chilled to the bone, but laughed happily to himself even as he said so.

4

3 PM. With under an hour left, it was finally the endgame of the Sports Festival.

We continued to defend our first place standing as we entered the final stage. The point difference between us and Class D, which was closing in on us at second place, was a mere 17 points. We should operate under the assumption that their unexpected tenacity was due to some strategy Ryuuen-kun was working behind the scenes. Nevertheless, there were no difficulties among us second-year students, and our alliance continued to perform well. But if we didn't continue to score in this hour, it was entirely possible that they could turn the tables on us…

I stood in a corner of the gymnasium, reading the schedule of the remaining events and their rules. Ibuki-san, not even trying to hide her irritation, came over and drew close to me.

"Fight me!"

"What an odd thing to say. I win, two matches to one. That was the result, wasn't it?"

"I didn't participate!"

"I don't care. You didn't come to the designated area in time, so you lost, you know?"

"Ugh…! I-I mixed up the timings.…"

Indeed. Our fated third match was a balance beam event, for which registration closed at 1:20 PM. Ibuki-san didn't make it in time to enter and

couldn’t participate in the competition. Of course, I didn’t mess up, and while I lost first place, I managed second and scored three points.

“Whether you’re satisfied or not, to the rest of the world, that’s called losing by default.”

“1 Win, 1 Loss! We haven’t settled this yet!”

She continued yelling close to my ear, and it seemed like she had no intention of giving up.

“I have already participated in nine matches total. I suppose I have one match left, but…”

“That, that! Tell me what you’re participating in!”

“If you want a rematch, you need to behave appropriately.”

“Grr…!”

“Do you want to fight? Or do you not?”

“P… Pl… e… as… e… fi… ght… me…!!”

She requested me, quivering with rage to the point where she was almost spitting flames out of her mouth.

“There, satisfied?!”

“I suppose. I feel a little better now.”

The situation was changing by the second, and participation slots in matches were filling up. Should I do what I’d planned at the outset, or should I aim for something higher scoring?

“Now, tell me what you’re participating in!”

“Can’t you keep quiet for a moment?”

“Not happening!”

She immediately retorted, holding her palm out flat before curling her fingers repeatedly in a provocative gesture. I didn’t want to go up against her, but ignoring her would only make her noisier.

“I’m considering participating in a Shuttle Run after this, as I’d planned before.”

“Shuttle Run? That thing where you continuously go back and forth until you drop?”

“Yes. You could call it a back-and-forth endurance race.”

“I think I remember doing this in middle school. Alright, let’s make it the deciding match!”

She nodded with satisfaction before preparing to run off and sign up.

“What are you doing?” She asked.

“If you want to participate, go ahead!”

“No, aren’t you participating too? What’s the point if we aren’t in the same group?”

“I’m only *considering* it. I haven’t decided on it yet.”

“Huh?”

“To be honest, right now I’m thinking of making Volleyball my final match.”

“Volleyball? Don’t you need six people to participate in that? You look like you’ve just decided to participate, but that won’t be possible if you’re starting right now.”

Among the events announced only today were men's and women's volleyball competitions across all school years. I'd decided that our class should let it go as requiring six good players would be the main challenge. Still, it looked like the other classes might have also had similar thoughts, as my impression was that the teams that had signed up so far were unexpectedly weak.

"With ten minutes left for signing up, there are three empty team spots. And from what I've seen, the participating teams aren't all that formidable. This competition would be worth giving up on the shuttle run if I could win. The result of a team competition for which teams are formed impromptu depends significantly on the skill of the best players. If I can find just one or two more people who are confident in their skills, I can see us winning."

"So what about the thing I just begged you for?"

"Unfortunately, I'm going to have to ask you to give up."

Ibuki-san was flabbergasted. I thought she'd get mad again, but she was dejected and gave up. Well, honestly speaking the root cause here was *her* getting the entry time mixed up.

"… Yeah, whatever. Then I guess this is the end of our fight…"

"You won't participate in the Volleyball competition?"

"I'd need five people to fight you. I couldn't even try to do that. Yeah, pass."

"Yeah, you have no friends."

"You're not so different either."

"At the very least, I think I have a few classmates who'll help me if I ask them to."

“How about that. I wanted to settle things, but I’ll put this on hold for another time.”

Technically speaking, I’ve won… but whatever.

“You won’t participate in the shuttle run?”

“The only thing I was interested in was settling my score with you. I have no interest in going out of my way to help Ryuuen.”

“That’s good for me. The points you won’t score help my class get so much closer to winning.”

I shouldn’t provoke her and let her leave while things remain as they are. Or so I thought, but for some reason, she wouldn’t leave.

“Is there anything else?”

“If you don’t get enough people to play volleyball, you’ll participate in the shuttle run, right?”

The deadline for the volleyball tournament was 2:20 PM. The deadline for the shuttle run was 2:25 PM. Ibuki-san had realized the one thing I deliberately didn’t mention.

“I see I’ve said too much. To think, even you have a brain that works.…”

“Shut up. So anyway, I’m going to stick around for a while longer.”

So now, if—in the worst case—I couldn’t get a team together for volleyball, I’d settle things with Ibuki in the shuttle run. Well, that wasn’t altogether a bad thing.

I scanned the girls from my class sitting in the seats reserved for cheering, searching for capable people. However, there was no way I’d find someone like that so conveniently and quickly, so the clock just kept on ticking. Before I knew it, Ibuki-san sat down where she was standing next to me,

yawning as she did. She looked back at me as if saying, “Just give up already. Let’s face off in the shuttle run.”

“Oh~? If it isn’t Horikita-senpai and Ibuki-senpai~! Good work~”

While waiting for people I could invite to the event, first-year student Amasawa Ichika called out to us. Immediately, Ibuki got up and glared at her.

“Oh, no~ You’re making such a scary face… is it perhaps that time of the month?”

Amasawa-san needled Ibuki-san, but half of what she said didn’t even get through to Ibuki-san.

“If you’ve got any slots left, how about I fight you?”

“Now that you mention it, we couldn’t do it today. *But* I guess we can’t help it, being in different years didn’t give us many chances to compete. Don’t you think it’s about time you dropped the fight? You’ll lose, you know?”

“Don’t underestimate me. Be grateful we didn’t face off today.”

“You’re always so spirited, aren’t you~ By the way, what are you two doing here? If you aren’t participating in a competition, you have to cheer, or it’ll be *bad*.”

“Participate in the shuttle run, Amasawa-san. We can fight there.”

“Oh, are my seniors due to compete in the shuttle run? As for me—”

“Finally, found you.”

A person showed up where we were talking—it was Kushida-san. I thought she needed something from me, but she was looking at Amasawa-san, not me.

“I was wondering who was following me, and so it’s you, Kushida-senpai. What is it? I can hear you out, if you’re okay with Horikita-senpai and Ibuki-senpai being here.”

“Horikita… san? … Oh, you’re here.”

She seemed to have been so focused on Amasawa-san that she hadn’t even realized we were here.

“Oh, sorry, Kushida-senpai! Looks like all of my teammates are ready, so I’ve got to go!”

As she spoke, she pointed at a spot where fellow first-year Nanase-san and four other girls I’d never seen before were present.

“I came to the gymnasium to participate in volleyball. This is my first time playing volleyball, you know~”

As it happened, it looked like Amasawa-san was also due to participate in volleyball. As expected, even the first-year students were spurred into action by the weak teams who were participating.

“See you then. Best of luck at the shuttle run~!”

She came as she pleased and spoke as she pleased before leaving to join up with her group.

“She’s, in volleyball, she says.”

Ibuki-san glared at her back as she said that.

“Looks like it.”

“Then I’ll participate too. At any rate, you won’t be able to get five players.”

“Eh?”

“I’m telling you, I’ll participate too. Teaming up with you sucks, but this is a chance to beat that piece of shit brat of a first year!”

If Ibuki-san wants to help me, I have nothing to complain about regarding her skills. But…

“You don’t get to decide that. I haven’t said anything yet about including you in my team.”

“Huh? But you haven’t even found one person for it?”

“In a team competition, the point reward is split equally. Instead of filling spots with students from other classes, isn’t it obvious that I should try to fill them with students from my class?”

After all that effort, even if I would make a few points, Ibuki-san’s class was in second place. Therefore, the gap in points between us wouldn’t widen even a bit.

“Don’t care. If I can see Amasawa eat shit, that’s enough for me.”

“At any rate, it depends on the other team members. At the very least, there must be a higher proportion of students from my class in the team.”

“Then why don’t you let me join as well?”

Kushida-san said. Just like Ibuki-san, her eyes were still fixed on Amasawa-san’s back.

“What do you want, Kushida-san? I can’t imagine you’ve turned a new leaf and want to help me out.”

I was candid with her about what I was thinking, and Kushida-san too did not bother denying it. However, I was curious about the fact that her eyes were aimed squarely at Amasawa-san and not me.

“That first year, Amasawa-san. I owe her a debt.”

“You owe Amasawa-san…?”

“You too?”

“I don’t want to explain my reasons, but to repay that debt, I’m fine with helping you.”

“If so, I’ll gladly welcome you. I have nothing to complain about; you’re from my class and capable.”

They do say that the enemy of my enemy is my friend. An unexpected turn of events led to an ally coming to my side.

“But, without a doubt, she will be a powerful opponent.”

“Of course.”

Ibuki-san was already starting her warm-ups, amping herself up for it. Amasawa-san watched her do so from afar and smiled oddly.

Both Ibuki-san and I had experienced first-hand how incredible Amasawa-san was. Still, I didn’t know anything about the other members of her team. I dug up my memory of their OAA scores. Judging just from that, Nanase-san’s physical ability score was relatively high, but the rest were unremarkable. I’m sure I remember the names of the students who had scores close to A, but even if I overestimate them, I’m sure they must be B and lower… But, the bigger problem was that we were still three teammates short. Analyzing our opponents before we’d met the requirements for participation was like counting your chickens before they hatch.

“Do you have any conditions for the remaining three? You want to avoid anybody from Ryuuen-kun’s class, is that all?”

Kushida-san asked me a question regarding my criteria for selection.

“Yes. Naturally, I feel like we should try to keep it to our classmates as much as possible. However, I prioritize the match itself, and talent.”

“Got it. Then, just wait for a bit.”

Kushida-san said, and she walked away from us.

“Got it? What does she mean to do? Nobody’s going to help out that easily.”

Ibuki-san was curious, so she followed Kushida with her eyes. Kushida-san was speaking to Rokkaku-san, a member of Sakayanagi-san’s class. After talking to her for a bit, she then did the same to Fukuyama-san, a member of the same class. Then she moved to the gymnasium, where the students who were cheering the other events were.

“That girl, I think she’s Himeno-san from Ichinose-san’s class, right?”

Kushida-san brought two girls from Class A and one from Class C, and they all discussed for about half a minute. Then, she brought those three girls to us.

“They say they’ll take part in volleyball. Himeno-san isn’t the best at it, but she agreed to do it if the five of us backed her up. You can leave the competition to us, so it’ll be alright.”

Kushida-san, in her antebellum mode, spoke to Himeno-san without turning to me even once. I couldn’t hide my amazement, in particular, at how she’d convinced the two girls from Class A to help us.

“We’re worried we’re going to lose, and in the worst case, even if we don’t win, we want to at least contribute to our class.”

Right? The two of them said as they nodded to each other. Especially because Class A was sinking to the button, they were desperate for any achievement. Kushida-san had understood that desire and could instantly discern the capable students from the rest. Even if she didn’t remember the exact specifics of their OAA scores, as their friend, she was deeply aware of the physical talent both Fukuyama-san and Rokkaku-san had.

“Now that’s a trick you’ll never be able to pull off, Ibuki-san.”

“Shut up. Not like you were able to find anybody.”

“There were some five, six more people I could call on in the gymnasium, but… This is probably the best lineup we can make right now, so I thought.”

At any rate, we found six people for the volleyball event that I was worried I wouldn’t be able to participate in. In terms of proportions in the team, the difference between my class and Ryuuen’s was only one in six. However, compared to facing off in the shuttle run as is and making a gap of just two or three points, the ten points we’d make from a victory in this tournament were far more rewarding. Another advantage for me was that the points gap between us wouldn’t shrink even if we lost.

Ibuki-san and I were the lead, and Kushida-san, Rokkaku-san, and Fukuyama-san were capable students. Himeno-san, whom we’d recruited just to fill a spot, was a bit of a drawback, but we had plenty of firepower.

5

We won our first match with ease and were watching Amasawa-san's team. Nanase-san was the one in control of the match. Whether in offense and defense, her plays were a cut above, overwhelming her own teammates as well as her opponents.

"That Nanase girl flew under the radar, but isn't *that one* not as big a deal as we thought?"

"Indeed, I don't get the feeling that she is as skilled as we were worried she would be. I thought she was joking when she said she had no experience in volleyball, but…"

It was possible that she was deliberately holding back, but from what I could see, that didn't seem to be the case. She was better than those who simply couldn't play either offense or defense, but it didn't look like she would pose a threat.

However, after the match passed the halfway point, the situation started to change, bit by bit. Even Ibuki-san—who seemed to have been somewhat disappointed—started watching seriously. After not even 10 minutes of play, Amasawa-san was visibly improving. She was beginning to show glimpses of unparalleled adaptability and instincts that couldn't be explained as merely a result of high physical ability. Just then, Nanase-san scored a spike, bringing the match to an end.

"We'll come up against them after our next match. She might be even better by then."

"Even if that's true, experience from just a few games won't be worth shit. We'll win."

Being overly optimistic was dangerous, but in fact, Nanase-san was carrying the team, and so they won with Amasawa-san barely touching the ball. Naturally, we also won our next match, and—at 3:40 PM—it was time for the final.

In the Sports Festival, many rules were different from usual competitions, and volleyball was no exception. There was no serve rotation, any player could serve, and whichever team reached 10 points first or won the most points within 10 minutes would win. If the score was tied after time ran out, the team that won the last point would have the right to serve, and the match would be extended until either team scored one more point.

“The time has come to see how you look after you lose.”

“Will you be satisfied with just the result of this volleyball match? Ibuki-*senpai*.”

“First, I’ll beat you at volleyball. And then I’ll beat you in a fight.”

“Ahahaha. I don’t mind that way of thinking.”

They refused to appreciate each other’s efforts. Instead, sparks flew between them while we waited for the signal to start the match. Amasawa-san was disconcerting, but the one we had to be most wary of was Nanase-san.

“Just like the last match, I’m playing an attacker. I’m gonna smash every ball into their court,” declared Ibuki-san, even more enthusiastic than before.

Although she had some difficulty controlling her spikes, their destructive power left nothing to criticize, and so I had no objections. When the final match began, Ibuki-san let her serve loose and took the first point. I hoped we would be able to ride on that momentum, but Nanase-san’s spike immediately brought them one point back.

I expected it to be a close battle, but we had a slim advantage, and by the end of the opening, we had extended our lead slightly to 4 points to 2. Just like we had surmised, Nanase-san was evenly matched with me and Ibuki-san, but other than that, we seemed to be in a marginally more favorable position.

That all changed midway through the match. There were less than five minutes remaining, and with a three step run up, Ibuki-san leapt and spiked the ball. Amasawa-san appeared from behind the net, and the blow that had scored so many points so far was blocked—no, it wasn't just saved. Using the momentum of the ball, she slammed it straight down into the ground and into our court. The first-year team was awarded one point.

"What a shame~ Ibuki-senpai. Nanase-chan, what was this play called again?"

"A stuff block, I think. I'm not too familiar with it myself, though."

"There you go! I've already seen through your attack patterns, senpai, so you won't get through any more!"

"Fuck! I'll definitely make the next one!"

"Calm down. She just stopped you once by chance."

"Shut it. Make sure you pass it to me next time too."

And then, with the score at 5 points to 3, it was our turn to serve. It would've been nice if we could end it with this…

We couldn't go for a reckless shot, as according to the rules, if the ball went out the opposing team would immediately earn a point. And of course, if we aimed for a safer spot, they would return it. However, I decided to hold firm and passed the ball to Ibuki-san.

"This time—you're going down!!"

She shook things up with a two step run up, soared high into the air, and delivered her best spike of the day. The two first-years who jumped for the block couldn't even touch it, and the ball was falling in a straight line towards the floor. The one who stopped it from touching the floor was Amasawa-san. As if she knew exactly where it would go, she killed the ball's momentum with a clean receive and it floated above their court. Her golden hair fluttering, Nanase-san leaped and unleashed a spike towards Himeno-san.

Himeno-san froze. Kushida-san forced her way in front of her to try and receive the ball, but she could not control its power.

The first-year team was catching up bit-by-bit, and in the final stages of the match, we were neck and neck. It was six points to six. With only about two minutes remaining, if the match continued at its current pace, it was quite possible that it would end by reaching the time-limit.

"I'm taking the next one as well!"

Ibuki-san had been denied twice by Amasawa-san, but she was fired up to score this time. I directed our teammates to pass her the ball, and the game continued. As we exchanged a rally, Amasawa-san readied herself to go for a spike for the first time today.

"You're the only one I won't let finish this!"

Ibuki-san jumped up to block. However, immediately after, she saw Nanase-san coming up from behind Amasawa-san.

"Too bad~"

Amasawa-san smiled. She was a decoy. Right from the start, Nanase-san was going to hit the spike. Caught off-guard, Ibuki-san stretched her hand out for the ball, but she couldn't reach it. The ball was aimed at a sharp angle and—-was saved just before it hit the floor by Kushida-san, who slid to receive it.

“Ibuki-san!”

Everyone turned to Ibuki-san, and the first-year students rushed into defensive positions. Amasawa-san lay in wait for Ibuki-san’s attack, a composed expression on her face.

“Don’t fuck with—-!?”

Even in this difficult situation, she was aiming to force the spike through, but she couldn’t find the right path. It would have been very characteristic of her to go for it anyway, but she gritted her teeth and switched to a toss. Out of consideration for Ibuki-san’s determination, I used up the rest of my physical strength that I had been conserving until now. My spike slipped through Amasawa-san’s block and flew straight at Nanase-san, who was waiting for it. Fatigue was setting in so she couldn’t bump the ball up well, and it went flying out of the court. If she had been in perfect condition, she might have got it up cleanly.

In any case, the score was now 7 points to 6. With time running out, we had gained a one point lead. Whether we liked it or not, with about a minute remaining, it was our turn to serve.

“Right then, I guess it’s about time I play for real~” said Amasawa-san, as if she hadn’t been serious until now.

Ibuki-san served, but Nanase-san deftly caught up with it and defended. The ball lost its momentum and soared high into the air, and we stared at it as it flew to one spot.

“I’ll aim for—!”

The unleashed volleyball roared through the air as it approached me at breakneck speed.

Despite being fully focused, I was slow to react. The moment I tried to reach out, the distance between me and the ball widened, and I couldn’t make it. The sound of the ball violently striking the floor echoed.

“Out!”

It was a blessing in disguise that I was too slow to react and couldn’t touch the ball. It landed half a ball’s width outside the white lines that marked the inside of the court.

“Ahh. Sorry, Nanase-chan, I missed~ It’s pretty hard to control it perfectly, huh?”

“We survived… But as expected, her potential is ridiculous…”

While I admired Amasawa-san’s unfathomable ability and instincts, we had just survived by the skin of our teeth. The one point gap had widened to two. They took one point back shortly after, but the whistle soon blew, and Nanase-san—who had just set a toss—looked surprised. Amasawa-san was about to slam the ball to our side, but she landed on the floor without swinging her hand.

“Oh, time’s up. It was just starting to get interesting!”

As if she had just been playing around, Amasawa-san didn’t show the slightest hint of frustration as she praised her teammates’ efforts. After a quick chat with Nanase-san, she left the court. Despite losing, they would also gain points for getting second place in the tournament. And we, of course, succeeded in acquiring the maximum number of points by taking first.

“I dunno, I can’t really accept this… like, it doesn’t feel like we won.”

“We were pushed pretty hard at the end. I shudder to think what would have happened if there wasn’t a time limit.”

As the winners, we *should* have felt relieved, but we were instead left unsatisfied and depressed. Nevertheless, this was a huge victory, and it was a suitably fierce battle to conclude the Sports Festival.

When I came to, I noticed that there were a considerable number of spectators in the gallery, and they applauded us, albeit sparsely.

6

Finally, the sports festival had reached its climax. The gymnasium was buzzing with a strange excitement as every team event was starting its final competition.

“Our match is starting soon, Sudo-kun. Are you ready?”

Sudou and Onodera, who had paired up to participate in many double’s competitions in this Sports festival, were proceeding to the finals of their tenth event, the mixed double’s tennis competition.

“…Yeah.”

Sudou’s response was a bit absent-minded, and so Onodera felt something was off, but she continued anyway,

“Anyway, don’t you think we make a great pairing? So far we’ve won all four pair competitions we’ve participated in. I’m sure everyone in our class will be surprised!”

In the two matches so far, they were against a second year team in one and against a third year team in the other. Sudou and Onodera effortlessly got through both, and now they were poised to win five team events in a row. Moreover, including his solo events, Sudou was currently at nine consecutive victories, going on ten. On the other hand, while Onodera had not won first place in all nine of her events, she had won something in all of them.

Sudou responded laconically to her, his eyes focused elsewhere.

“Are you worried about that first year guy? You’ve been watching him all along.”

“Eh?”

“Housen… I think? He’s so big it’s hard to imagine he’s a first year, and he has this incredible aura. But, I don’t know, it doesn’t seem like that’s why you’re watching him. Did something happen between you two?”

“Nothin’ much. Don’t worry about it.”

Housen’s pair crushed the match they were playing, and so their opponents for the finals were set. Sudou had been intently watching their match while he vacantly kept up the conversation with Onodera. Onodera stared at him as he watched. So far, Sudou had thought nothing as he went into his matches, but clearly something had shaken him.

Today wasn’t the first time they were together. They had been working together throughout almost all of the preparation period for the Sports Festival. From practice time to lunch break and even when they went to school in the morning, they kept meeting and practicing together. And that is why she was capable of understanding the change in Sudou’s expression.

While he was an outstanding athlete, Sudou still had his flaws. He had a rough personality, he got carried away easily, and he had a quick temper. When they were working together, that sometimes held them back.

“We will soon start the finals. Please get ready.”

One of the staff members called out to them where they sat.

“Alright, let’s clinch this quickly and raise the roof!”

He pretended to be calm, and Onodera, too, cleared her mind after he said that. Even if there was something between him and Housen, so long as he didn’t make it a problem it was fine.

“Okay!” Onodera said as she picked up the racket, both so Sudou and she herself could hear it.

Their classmates steadily showed up at the gymnasium and quickly started cheering for her and Sudou. Even the adults must have been very interested in the finals because many of them stopped to watch.

“Almost feels like a tournament, doesn’t it?”

“Yeah. The tension and energy feel great!”

The two of them had been to tournaments for their clubs and were fine being on the big stage, so there was no concern about them being afraid of the crowd.

However…

“Didn’t think the finals would be against’cha, Sudou-*paisen*.”

“Housen.”

Housen gripped the net and spoke to Sudou. The atmosphere changed.

“You better not think you can beat me just ‘cus it’s tennis. I’m gonna destroy you, so you better be ready for that.”

The doubles match started. There was a time limit to the match. Four points took a game, and the match was decided by the best of three games. As a special rule to keep the finals short, the serve did not rotate with each game, and was instead given to whoever lost the point. Also, teams didn’t need to rotate the serve between themselves, so they could pick one person and have them serve again and again.

The match kicked off with a savage attack from Housen. Sudou and Onodera were rocked by the powerful serves Housen’s gigantic frame shot out, and they let them easily hit the court. On the other hand, Sudou’s serves were lacking and lifeless, and so were quickly returned inside the court again and again. Within a minute, they were cornered, and the score stood at 3 (40) – 0 (love).

“No way… he’s so fast…! He must have played tennis before!”

It was reasonable for Onodera to panic, as Housen’s balls hit the court at terrifying speeds.

“What’s the matter, Sudou? That ain’t enough to keep up with me!”

“Fuck!”

He gripped the racket hard, and he was about to raise it up and smash it into the ground.

“Sudou-kun, stop!”

“…!”

“Every time you get mad like that, you’re making a mistake. You should know that!”

“B-But!”

Now that he couldn’t take his frustration out any more, Sudou was suddenly filled with stress. When he saw Sudou across the net behave like that, Housen snorted.

“I’m not returning his shots either, so I can’t pretend to be much better, but you’re clearly not playing as well as you did in past matches?”

She pointed out that he was preoccupied with Housen, and so his movements had become stiff and slow.

“I can’t let you serve if you’re like this, Sudou-kun.”

Onodera took the ball. She signaled to Sudou to defend, and then she served.

She shot a clean serve, so clean it was hard to believe it was by someone inexperienced in tennis, let alone a girl. However, Housen quickly caught

up to it, and his technique was so good the racket seemed like an extension of his arm.

Sudou reached out to defend but it took him everything he had to just hit it with the edge of his racket, and so the first year team took the first game without letting their opponents score a single point.

“You ain’t worth shit, Sudou. You’re a *loser*.”

While Housen was enjoying the match from the bottom of his heart, his partner, in comparison, could not hide her fear. Housen was single handedly carrying the match, so it was really a 2v1 fight.

The second match. This was a do or die moment for them, and while they expected Housen to continue his relentless onslaught an unexpected development occurred.

The ball Housen shot was not as forceful as before, and Onodera adjusted to it and returned it. Just as they thought Housen was starting to get tired, he raised his arm high.

The ball he smashed was as strong and fast as a cannonball. It flew towards Onodera, who was defending the front, almost as if he was aiming for her. It grazed past her cheek, and Onodera’s expression twisted in pain. She reflexively dropped her racket, both from pain and surprise.

“You did that on purpose, you bastard!”

“Huh? ‘Course you aim at your opponent’s body in tennis. Keep shooting away from them and they’ll catch up and return it. Ya don’t even know that? Kickin’ up a fuss after just one ball!”

“Shit!”

Housen boldly stood his ground that he was correct. Onodera hurried to pick her racket back up.

“Don’t worry. It just grazed me… but still, isn’t he right that tennis is about aiming close to your opponents?”

“Ask someone who actually plays tennis. This is the Sports Festival!”

Sudou complained irritably, saying that only someone who usually played tennis would know.

The serve came back to Sudou, and the first one went out. The second time he played it safe, and so Housen easily returned it.

He didn’t put all that much energy into it, and Onodera closed in on it before returning it cleanly. The rally continued for two, three more strikes before Onodera once again moved to the front and returned the ball.

Just then, Housen closed in on the ball and smashed it back at them.

“Kya-!?”

The fastball reminded Onodera of the one from before, and she froze in fear, unable to move her racket. The ball grazed past her side. Sudou stopped it and returned it to the other side, but throughout the volley Housen persistently aimed close to Onodera. It was almost like he was playing around in the match.

Finally, Sudou’s team was at 3 (40), while Housen’s was at 2 (30).

Onodera was desperately trying to do something, but once again the ball went past her face. She instinctively reacted, which ended up twisting her left leg, and so she collapsed.

“Onodera!”

Onodera didn’t get up, so Sudou covered by taking the ball and returning it to Housen. The ball just barely hit inside the court, and so Sudou’s team took the second game.

But Sudou wasn’t celebrating. He exploded with anger.

“Enough of this! Can you even play fair?”

“How many times do I need to tell you? That stupid woman of yours is just bad. Worthless!”

“Stop, Sudou-kun. You’re doing it again.”

Onodera wasn’t getting up. She calmed sudou down, still lying on her back.

“I know that already! Do you think we should just let this go?”

“You’re not wrong. Even the referee is getting suspicious. But, Sudou-kun, even your own behavior is getting in our way.”

It was abundantly clear that from the moment the tennis match had started, Housen had changed his aim from winning the match to tormenting Sudou. His aim was to instill fear into Onodera, and make her mess up once in a way that would injure her.

“Anyway, just calm down, Sudou-kun.”

She was hurting, and despite that she gently but strongly admonished him.

Sudou had gotten heated, and that wasn’t enough for him to control himself, so he kept glaring at Housen. However, after seeing Onodera scowling in pain, he remembered what he should be prioritizing.

Soon, Onodera was getting aid for the injury she had suffered in her ankle.

“Sucks, I fumbled the game. But you lot are gonna have to play one more. Ain’t that just hell for you?”

Housen yawned as he watched them both, and after that he went to speak to his partner.

“That bastard… he wants to mess around with us as much as he can, he lost on purpose…”

Sudou muttered as he looked at Onodera's left leg in concern.

"Will you be alright?"

"I think, somehow. But man, I'm so worthless. I was so scared of the ball and tried to dodge it, and I ended up falling over and spraining my leg."

She chucked derisively at herself, tapping the tape on her ankle.

"I don't blame you. He's annoying as all hell, but he's a top class athlete."

Even Sudou was afraid of the extremely powerful volleys Housen's excellent physique effortlessly pumped out. Anyone who was not an experienced tennis player or a member of the tennis club would not be able to shake that fear so quickly.

"I… Ever since I came to this school, I have had a good opinion of you, Sudou-kun."

"Huh? Where'd that come from? Just stay calm and let them treat you."

"No, it's fine! This wound paid off. It bought us just a little bit of time to calm down."

"You sure are keeping it cool… Anyway, you had a good opinion of me back *then*?"

"Yes. But you are also the person I least wanted to have anything to do with. You were so thorny!"

"Oof…"

"The people around you attacked you because you didn't study and your behavior was terrible, but I'll support anybody who puts effort into their club. Sudou-kun, you had the talent, and you also put in the work, didn't you?"

"How would you know!"

“I know. When I go home after practicing until late, I pass by the gymnasium. Every time I think nobody will be around any more, and every time I see you, Sudou-kun, still practicing alone after everyone’s left. You even clean up properly, you really take it seriously.”

“W-Wait, you were watching… that’s, embarrassing.”

“But—in the end, if you stay like this I can’t truly think highly of you, Sudou-kun.”

“… Huh?”

“You got mad for my sake. I don’t hate that, but you still have a short temper. If you stay like this, someday, you will cause a fight worse than you’ve ever before.”

“… That’s …”

“I think you should stop getting so mad!”

“I-I know…!”

“Even in sports, if you lose your cool, don’t you lose more often than not?”

“Hmm… you’re right. Even the accuracy of my shots drops…”

“Me too. When I lose my cool, I get desperate for time, but it only makes me get slower than usual. There’s very little good about it, right?”

“You too, huh?”

“One time, after I lost an important match, I was so frustrated, I was in the changing rooms and I even forgot to change and… in my rage, I hurt my hand. All it did was make it worse for me afterwards.”

She remembered her past, and feeling slightly ashamed, stuck out her tongue just a little.

“Ughh. So that’s when I learned. Getting mad is no good, and it’ll come back to bite me later.”

“How’d you manage to control it and not get angry?”

“About that. A senior taught me some magic.”

“M-Magic?”

“Yes. I’ll teach it to you, Sudou-kun. A spell that controls your anger.”

“W-What do I do?”

“The peak of your anger, you see, is actually surprisingly short, and doesn’t last more than a few seconds. So when you want to scream in anger, do that once inside your head, and then take ten deep breaths.”

“So you mean… when I get angry, I should take ten seconds, that’s it?”

“Yes. I’m sure that’ll be enough to make a difference, so try it out.”

“… I get it.”

He wasn’t fully convinced, but Sudou committed this conversation to his memory.

“I wanted to pair up with you because I had a good opinion of you, Sudou-kun. Please don’t betray my expectations.”

“Onodera…”

They were done treating her, so Onodera checked herself once and stood up again.

“I’m fine. Whether we like it or not, this one game will settle the match. If we fumble, we lose. But if we take it, we win.”

“—Yeah!”

The third game started. Housen doggedly aimed at Onodera, even though her movements had become slower due to the injury on her left leg. He overdid it, and so he ended up losing points, but he showed no signs of stopping.

Sudou's team led with 3 (40) to 1 (15).

Even though he would lose the match if he messed up, Housen once again shot a fast ball at Onodera. This time, she couldn't dodge it, and the ball hit her right arm. Onodera squatted in pain.

"This isn't even how you treat a match… you playing aro—!"

His blood was boiling, but he remembered the spell Onodera had taught him just some time ago. He glared at Housen, who was still being provocative, but inside his heart he screamed in anger.

Ten seconds of anger. He had to control it for just ten seconds.

1, 2, 3; he counted, breathing deeply to let his emotions go.

8… 9… 10… The angry insults he had in mind for Housen receded into his throat.

Of course, not all of his irritation had disappeared, but he succeeded in analyzing the situation calmly and objectively. The suspicious looks of the referees. Onodera looking at him. The match that they had to win. The amount of time they had left. If he let Housen needle them now, of course it would hold them back.

"Onodera, do you trust my strength?"

"… Of course. I'm playing with you because I trust you."

Sudou had controlled his breathing. He threw the ball in the air and served his best shot of the day. There were no second chances for Housen, so he received the ball and returned it. That led to a one-on-one rally between

Housen and Sudou. Neither of them yielded an inch as they returned powerful shots at each other. As they continued, Housen lost out to Sudou's persistence and returned with a weak shot. Sudou didn't let it go and smashed the ball into their opponents' court.

"YEAHHHHHHHHH!"

His racket still in his hand, Sudou roared so loudly it echoed across the gymnasium.

"We did it, we did it!"

Housen had an overwhelming advantage, but because he continued to underestimate his opponents until the end he ended up losing. Irritated by his loss, he threw the racket at the court so hard it broke into two.

"We won, Onodera! Thanks to you!"

Sudou was so excited he ran over to Onodera and hugged her deeply to share his excitement.

"W-W-W-W-Wh…!?"

For a moment, Onodera didn't understand what was happening, and she panicked.

"Wa- it hurts, it hurts, Sudou-kun!"

She cried in pain, his strong arms squeezing her. Sudou quickly regained his composure.

"S-Sorry, sorry!"

Apart from winning, Sudou had managed to control his anger, and that must have made him happy because he had a broad smile, the happiest of the day.

"Congratulations on winning every event, Sudou-kun."

“Yeah! Thanks Onodera, if you didn’t help I would definitely have lost this match.”

“That’s not true! If anything, I only dragged you down…”

“I’m not gonna say your injury paid off, but when you got hurt and I snapped, for a moment I felt like I’d lost. You snapped me out of it.”

“Really. Then, we were… good partners, right?”

“Yeah. It was super easy to work with you, and I could really depend on you. This is seriously amazing, Onodera! Ahh, if only Suzune could somehow see us do so well…”

There were more and more guests and students around, so he couldn’t quickly spot Horikita.

“Suzune… huh?”

“Ah? Where? Where is he!?”

“Uh, no~, I mean, sorry, I mistook someone for her.”

“Damn. I see, maybe she’s near the grounds…”



“Next time we’re going back from club, let’s go have dinner together.”

“Eh? Oh, sure, that’s cool. Anyway, help me find Suzune. Where are you, Suzune!?”

“Ahahaha. No. Absolutely not.”

“Oi, Sudou. Don’t let this win get to yer head, eh? If I was serious, you’d be toast. Ya know that, right?”

Even though the match was long done, Housen didn’t seem to be finished with it and drew close to them.

“Come with me, let’s play some more behind the gym.”

“Hold on, you—”

Onodera moved to intercept Housen as he tried to provoke Sudou, but Sudou quietly stopped her.

“This guy and I have some history. Well, I guess I have no choice but to face him.”

“B-But!”

Onodera was trying to protect him from getting into a fight again, but Sudou understood what she was thinking and smiled. Then he turned to face Housen.

“Sorry, but I’m not interested in taking you up on your challenge.”

“Huh? Ain’t about whether you’re interested or not. From now on, you’re my sandbag.”

“I said, not interested.”

Sudou refused to go along, so Housen squeezed his shoulders together and slammed a clench fist into his stomach. The powerful sucker punch brought Sudou to his knees.

“Sudou-kun!”

Sudou stopped Onodera with his hand and calmly got up. The teachers rushed to him, but Sudou told them nothing happened and got them to leave.

“Damn, that hurts. Ughh. I already know you’re good at fighting! That time was partly my bad, too, so I’m not gonna complain. But. Any more, and I’ll even ask the teachers to intervene.”

“Pathetic, aren’cha? You were better when you came swingin’, you know?”

“Maybe. Onodera, let’s go.”

“O-Ok.”

“Boring fool. Don’t mess with me again.”

Somehow, Sudou found those words comforting. If he wasn’t the one to get violent, the situation wouldn’t get worse.

He learned that if he didn’t let the anger consume him, the situation would drastically improve.

“I really gotta thank Housen. When I saw how he’s so bloodthirsty like that, I fully got just how lame I’ve been. Can’t really put it to words, but… when I tried that method you taught me, something just hit me. Why have I been so mad all along? Something like that. Maybe a ghost finally left me or something.”

Sudou was grateful for the ten victories he’d won, but he was just as grateful to the Sports Festival, and to Onodera.

Chapter 6

Introduction

It was around 11 AM. My window was closed, but I could faintly hear cheers from outside. Seems like the Sports Festival was getting pretty exciting.

Things hadn't been perfect, but despite that the class had been working hard to win. They will be able to do well when facing off against the other classes and other years. That's what I'd determined, and that is why I was able to sit this sports festival out without hesitation.

I've made all the arrangements I wanted to, so I'll be leaving the rest in Director Sakayanagi's hands. Him being the director didn't necessarily mean I could blindly trust him, but if he betrayed me, that would in effect mean there was no way for me to remain in this school. So it was an easy decision to make.

All that's left is how the sports festival would unfold for the second year students, and what would come out of it. One of the biggest factors for our victory would be Sakayanagi's participation or lack thereof. I wonder what happened with that.

I looked at the entrance once. I'd played a strategy to try and contain her… but if it worked, I should've seen the results by now. I was concerned about a few things, but just like the status of the sports festival, at this point I could only wait.

It's about time I get started on making lunch—. Just as I thought that, the doorbell rang.

Well then. Will this be a welcome guest or an unwelcome one? Until I've answered the door, I won't be able to know that.

"Hello, Ayanokouji-kun."

They called, while I was watching the front door, still keeping my distance. I guess they had anticipated my caution. I let my guard down slightly and put my hand on the doorknob. A few hypothetical scenarios ran through my mind, but if *they* got into this dormitory you could say I'd already lost.

On the other side of the door was nobody except Sakayanagi, dressed in her casual clothes. She smiled at me.

"If you don't mind, may I bother you for a moment? Even though the only thing I'm prohibited from doing is leaving the dorms, calling on a guy's room during the sports festival is a bit questionable."

"Coming inside my room would be even more questionable, I'd say."

Despite that, I didn't turn Sakayanagi away and welcomed her inside.

"My apologies for bothering you."

Due to her disability, Sakayanagi slowly took off her shoes and walked into the room.

"Come to think of it, this is the first time you've come to my room, Sakayanagi."

"I don't usually get a chance to visit. Have you had lunch yet?"

"I was just about to get started making it."

"Is that so? That's great. Here, I have a present for you."

She handed me a small plastic bag.

“I bought this at the convenience store early this morning. It seems to be a new product, so I thought we might as well try it together.”

I looked into the bag and saw two small mont blancs inside. Coffee would go well with the mont blancs, so I should brew some.

“Feel free to sit on the bed, it would be better than sitting on the floor.”

“Thank you for your consideration.”

After having her sit on the bed, I went to the kitchen and poured some water into a kettle from the faucet.

“I don’t suppose you came here on a whim.”

I said nonchalantly. Sakayanagi laughed, bemused by it.

“Normally, one never knows who is in the dorm. Being the leader of Class A, I couldn’t possibly just visit your room by myself, Ayanokouji-kun.”

Anyone would be surprised by that and get suspicious. That is why usually Sakayanagi would never do something like meeting me in the dorm. Until today, at this time.

“You really are a terrible person, Ayanokouji-kun. This was part of your strategy, wasn’t it?”

“Strategy? What do you mean?”

“Fufu, you don’t need to play dumb, Ayanokouji-kun. You were almost sure —no, let me correct myself. You *were* sure I’d come here today, weren’t you?”

Considering Sakayanagi, she didn’t need to think too hard to know that this was a trap.

“During this sports festival, our Class A is starting with a disadvantage because of our smaller numbers. And while we have promising students such as Kitou-kun and Hashimoto-kun, on average we aren’t as good as Horikita-san’s class. In that case, what we need to do in order to win is to determine who participates in what competition, and to adjust the schedule moment to moment while observing where our rivals are participating during the actual event.”

I switched on the kettle and the water inside quietly started to boil. Then I grabbed a jar of ground coffee from the cupboard, along with cups and a filter.

“You wouldn’t know how it would play out if I were to participate.”

“You have a very high opinion of yourself, as usual.”

“If the other classes want to ensure they win against Class A, making me not participate is the most important thing to do.”

The Sports Festival calls for people to work on a precise schedule. Sakayanagi would be able to mentally organize her people, appropriately distribute them across events and then direct them accordingly. Further, managing participation in competitions that involved students from other school years was almost her speciality.

“Last night, I heard from my father that he had requested you to take a leave, Ayanokouji-kun, so that he could arrange for security at the dormitory and prevent any contact with the people sent from the White Room.”

“It’s true that I’m sitting out the Sports Festival because Director Sakayanagi asked me to do so, but I never imagined he would tell his daughter about that.”

“How funny! Didn’t you ask him to tell me about this, Ayanokouji-kun?”

Oh, she’s seen through my move as if it was nothing.

Director Sakayanagi would never violate the separation of his professional and private matters, even when it came to his own daughter. Which is why I'd asked Director Sakayanagi to tell her what the state of affairs was without letting her know that I'd done so.

I told him that he should let her know in advance, since it was likely that she would skip the Sports Festival due to her health, and in the unlikely possibility that I had some trouble with the White Room, she shouldn't get caught up in it. Sakayanagi had been planning to participate as the leader of Class A, but I doubt the Director was aware of that. Even if he was, it would've been safer for him to tell her so if she had to take the day off on short notice, it would still be fine. Given she was his own daughter, he would've known it was likely she'd stick her nose into it.

But there is one thing that even Director Sakayanagi doesn't know, which is that it wasn't easy to suppress Sakayanagi's instincts and curiosity. And so, if I happened to stay home, it wouldn't be strange for her to think of it as an opportunity to have a nice, long chat with me without anybody interrupting.

Which turned out to be exactly what she thought, and she nonchalantly showed up at the most dangerous place there was, that is, my room.

"So you decided to come just before 12 only to make me worry?"

"I tried being a little mean. I wanted you to think that maybe I'd ignored your strategy and was participating in the Sports Festival."

"Oh, I see."

"By the way, except me and you, everyone is participating in the Sports Festival."

Someone from Sakayanagi's information network must have checked who was participating from all the classes and told her via phone before the Sports Festival started. In that way, too, she was not cutting any corners.

“I wanted to be mean, but to be honest, I also wanted to visit just a little sooner,” she said. Just then, the water in the kettle starter started to boil noisily. “Just now, I went down to the lobby and checked how things were outside.”

As I was being treated as if I’d taken a sick day, I was completely prohibited from leaving my room. On the other hand, while Sakaynagi was not allowed to leave the dorm, she hadn’t taken a sick day. Even if they warned her for walking around outside her room, the act itself wouldn’t go against the reason for her leave.

“So how were things on the first floor?”

“There were three people there, seemingly bodyguards. It wasn’t just at this dorm, and they were stationed across the whole school, so it didn’t appear unnatural.”

Even though they were protecting me, the security people were only there to protect the government officials.

“The most valuable player of this Sports Festival isn’t Horikita san, for her proposal to cooperate with Ryuuen-kun, nor is it Ryuuen for accepting it. It was you, for authoritatively saying that you could definitely keep me from participating. Congratulations, with just that one thing you sealed your victory.”

“But we don’t know what the results will be yet.”

“While a late surprise is certainly possible, it is highly unlikely. Right now, with Horikita’s class taking them head on, and Ryuuen’s class taking every measure possible, Class A must be at their mercy. Even if one has great arms or legs, without a head one won’t get anywhere. That is because I’ve built up the class that way.”

You could say the same about Ryuuen. The problem here is that the head of the class is too strong. When the leader resolves every issue, conversely it also means that without the leader, nothing is resolved.

“Well, that’s fine. This time, I paid 150 points to enjoy some time with Ayanokouji-kun.”

It’s almost like she wasn’t even bothered by the damage Class A would take.

“You sure have no objection to losing class points.”

“The systems of this school are, to me, just an extension of playtime. To some extent, so long as I keep our status at Class A, there’s no problem.”

At long last, I took the mont blancs out of the bag and plated them. I placed two cups next to them and poured hot water from the kettle into them through a filter with coffee powder on it.

“You seem used to this by now.”

“It’s not a big deal, something like this .”

“Is every step of preparing something like this fresh and fun for you, Ayanokouji-kun?”

Sakayanagi must have been aware that I had never done this kind of thing in the White Room.

“Everything in this school is like that. I just wanted to do normal things, that’s all.”

At any rate, what Sakayanagi had said earlier was still stuck in my mind.

“So you do have the desire to remain as Class A. Is it just your pride?”

I asked her as I put some milk and packets of sugar at the table.

“Initially, I was not obsessed about Class A or anything like that. But after finding out that you were in this school, it became my goal. Because maybe, after you lead your class to Class B, you’d seriously fight me.”

To put it simply, she was waiting for me at the top.

“In the first term of the first year, Class D had lost all their points. However, after a point, they started to gain points, and finally they have risen to Class B. Of course, the reason for that must be that you were acting behind the scenes, Ayanokouji-kun.”

She said happily and freely, almost as if she was bragging about herself.

She picked up a plate with a mont blanc from the table and put it on her lap.

“Let’s eat it together, Ayanokouji-kun.”

She prompted me to sit down next to her, and with no reason to refuse I sat down on the bed. I don’t know what she was thinking, because then she scooped up some of the mont blanc with a fork and held it out at me.

“Here.”

“… What do you mean, ‘here’?”

“Isn’t it obvious? Eat it!”

“No, I get it, but…”

“There’s nothing to worry about. It’s just you and me here, Ayanokouji-kun, and nobody will get in our way.”

I thought she had some ulterior motives, but that doesn’t seem to be the case.

I took the fork in my mouth and a sweet aroma filled it. Surprisingly, this might’ve been my first time having a mont blanc.

“Is it good?”

To be entirely honest, I didn’t like the taste all that much. Personally, a simple shortcake would taste better. That’s what I thought. But I’m not

going to criticize a present.」

“Yeah.”

I simply said it was good. Sakayanagi smiled a bit.

“Then I’ll have some too.”

Unfazed by using the same fork she’d fed me with, she scooped a portion for herself and tried it.

“It doesn’t stand a chance against the sweets at the café, but for a sweet from a convenience store it makes the grade.”

Satisfied, she nodded and then held the fork out to me again.

Since both of us were eating the same one, we quickly finished the first mont blanc.

“Next time, I’ll bring a different cake.”

“Eh?”

“Your response suggested you didn’t like it very much, Ayanokouji-kun.”

“… Hm, but I just normally said it was good.”

“I’m very proud of how perceptive I am, especially when it comes to you, Ayanokouji-kun.”

I never thought she could figure out I didn’t like it very much.

“In a real battle of wits, you’d never show such a weakness, but when it comes to an everyday thing like this you’re surprisingly open, aren’t you?”

“Maybe it’s because I’m not used to it, after all.”

“Fufu. That sort of thing has its own appeal, you know?”

I couldn’t tell whether her response was serious or a joke, but she continued anyway.

“Please let me try again sometime. If I see a delicious cake, I’ll bring it with me.”

“It’d be nice if a situation like this, where we’re certain nobody can see us, comes by again.”

Whether it was a weekend or not, so long as there were people out and about in the dorm, it was close to impossible. There was the option of meeting late at night or early in the morning, but as one would expect, that had problems of its own.

“But what I find mysterious is your change of heart, Ayanokouji-kun. You’re not helping out from time to time while you stand on the sidelines as you were supposed to. Now you have started to seriously aim for Class A. Why?”

“Oh, so there’s things even you don’t know.”

“I’m not a god. Moreover, I know your background, Ayanokouji-kun, and consequently there are things I don’t understand or can’t think of. Can you tell me, please?”

As a genius driven by her curiosity for the unknown, she wanted to know the reason.

Sakayanagi is not interested in ranking as Class A or D because she knows that she won’t be taking the benefits of it after graduating. As the daughter of the director of this institute, and as someone with abundant talent in academics, most things were well within her grasp. She has no need to use the special privilege of Class A to accomplish something, and so she does not particularly care about it.

You could say the same about me, as it is certain that I will be returning to the White Room after graduating. Our trajectories may be different, but we

know well that the special privilege of Class A will be in vain for us.

“It might seem like a mystery to you, yes.”

“I don’t suppose you are trying to amass a fortune in private points and make merry, like Kouenji-kun?”

“He definitely is in a similar position as the two of us.”

He was the kind of person who could get anything he wanted with his parents’ influence and his own talents. Despite that, the reason he sometimes contributed to the class on a whim is for the private points.

“I think you at least have the right to hear why I decided to contribute to my class, Sakayanagi. After all, you walked into an obvious trap and almost threw away a chance at winning the Sports Festival.”

If she got nothing out of this despite taking the risk of losing 150 class points, that would be the end of this. However, if I gave her something worth her while, it left it possible that she’d fall for the same strategy again.

“If you answer my question, then I’ll come here if this happens again.”

“Don’t say the very thing I’m thinking at the moment!”

“Fufufu.”

“Fundamentally, I am trying to do the same thing you are, Sakayanagi. By defeating me, you want to answer the question of what it means to be a genius. I am, in my own way, thinking of proving that the white room is by no means perfect.”

Sakayanagi was… not surprised. This was proof that she had predicted this, even if she wasn’t sure of it.

“So that means that you are trying to build up the strongest class with your own hands, Ayanokouji-kun?”

When I nodded in assent, Sakayanagi put her index finger on her lip.

“It’s not that I haven’t considered that before but… I have a few doubts.”

“Of course.”

“Like this Sports Festival. Despite the circumstances, you should have been able to participate anyway. Your odds of winning would have been much higher if you were on the ground giving orders, and wouldn’t that have made your position more solid? It’s not like you were worried about whether or not I would participate, after all.”

“There is a theme to how I have spent this Sports Festival.”

“How interesting! What was this theme?”

“Observation.’ I decided that it was a good opportunity for me to determine how well the other students would be able to fight when I don’t directly participate in the Sports Festival. Getting you to sit it out was just a side effect, I’d say.”

“The fact that I came to meet you because you were observing from the sidelines doesn’t mean you directly affected the Sports Festival itself, right. … Oh, I see.”

While she was speaking, Sakayanagi arrived at a conclusion that was one step ahead.

“That mean—”

Just as she tried to put her conclusion to words, I faced her and lightly knocked her back. No, saying I knocked her back was overstating it. I lightly held her shoulders and pushed her back, and due to Sakayanagi’s lack of strength, that was enough for her to be unable to resist falling back.

Pomf. The sound from the mattress mixed with the creaking of the metal frame.

She bragged about being a genius, but I'm sure Sakayanagi had never even considered this. Before she could understand what was happening, I was hanging over her, looking down at her.

"U-Um?"

Sakayanagi was usually so calm and collected, but she hadn't caught up to this situation yet.

"My plan is the basis for how I'm living my school life. Including that you would visit me today, that you would be interested in my plan, and that you would have the possibility of and the path to figuring it out."

As she must never have had a man hang over her like this before, Sakayanagi was anxious and nervous, so she made a noise with her throat.

"If you told others about what we talked about today, it would get in the way of my plan."

"You think I would… leak it?"

"At this point, it is not entirely out of the question. If you threatened me, saying I would have to face off against you if I didn't want it revealed, I would have no choice but to accept."



“I see, yes… that’s right. However, if I ever wanted to coerce you into a showdown… couldn’t I just use the existence of the White Room instead?”

“No, that wouldn’t be effective. Even if you made the existence of that institute widely known, other people wouldn’t be able to comprehend it. And it wouldn’t be any risk to me personally.”

‘Ayanokouji was raised in an educational institution known as the White Room.’ Most people would just be puzzled if they heard something like that. They couldn’t even find anything if they looked it up on the internet. There would definitely be some confusion because Sakayanagi would swear by it, but I would naturally just do nothing.

“But the plan I’m trying to pull off is not at a stage where I can let it be widely known. It is entirely possible that you use it as material for blackmail.”

I closed in on Sakayanagi a bit, putting myself in the way of the light and thereby creating a dark shadow on her.

“And I just happened to come to know about it. … So what are you going to do?”

“A secret for a secret, and a threat for a threat. Right now, you and I are the only ones left in this dorm. So no matter what happens, nobody will come to help you. Even if you scream at the top of your voice, at best it’ll be barely audible at the end of the hallway.”

“Are you seriously going to commit a crime to protect that plan?”

“Crime? You and I are going to agree to share a secret.”

I took my phone out and launched the camera.

“If you want to refuse, your only choice is to use your own strength to run away.”

For Sakayanagi, the disability in her legs would… No, even if both her legs were fine, she had no way out. How would she respond to this hopeless situation?

“—You think you’ll win?”

“Win?”

“Even if things go as you plan right now, will it actually put you at an advantage? … That’s what I mean.”

“I’m sorry, but you have no chance of winning.”

“The small difference in our level of experience, I will use one way of learning to catch up and then leave you behind. In fact, you might even find out that your way of learning has been wrong all along?”

Even when she was driven into a corner, Sakayanagi continued thinking rationally as much as possible. She must have been frightened, but I’m impressed that she was able to control it so much.

I threw my phone away to the end of the bed and slowly moved that hand towards Sakayanagi. I held her shoulders and then drew it towards the nape of her neck. Even after that, she only looked away.

“Let’s begin a special lesson, shall we?”

Sakayanagi smiled boldly and quietly closed her eyes, showing no signs of resistance.

1

“You really are a terrible person.”

“Perhaps.”

It had been about an hour since Sakayanagi came to my room.

“With this, we now share a secret we can’t tell anyone else about.”

“If you put it that way, you’ll invite misunderstandings.”

“*You’re* the one who invited a misunderstanding in the first place, Ayanokouji-kun. Am I wrong?”

“No, you’re right.”

“Setting that aside, this was my first time on a boy’s bed.”

“You left in ten seconds, so I think it shouldn’t count.”

“You’re not taking a girl’s memories seriously.”

I showed my phone to Sakayanagi, selecting what was necessary and deleting the rest. While I was doing that, I must’ve swiped too far back because a photo of me with Kei came up. It was a photo of us we’d taken at Keyaki mall.

“It looks like your relationship with Karuizawa-san is going well.”

“I suppose.”

Kei was smiling cheerfully in the photo. Sakayanagi looked at it as she continued,

“At some point, Ayanokouji-kun was attracted by her appearance, voice, or personality… Ordinarily, that’s what I would’ve thought, but there are a few things that I don’t understand.”

Then, she looked up at me, her eyes sharp, her expression just as when she was facing off against me.

“I looked into her, as much as I could. From what she does after school to what she does on her weekends. The way things are right now, it is easy to put a tail on you, Ayanokouji-kun.”

Because the entirety of the third year is observing me, I’m not on guard for each and every one of them. It was difficult to pick out Sakayanagi’s agent once they had mixed in with the rest. It could’ve been Hashimoto, who I had noticed following me earlier, or it could’ve been someone else I couldn’t identify.

“I could not fully ascertain why you chose to date her, Ayanokouji-kun, but there is something I could figure out. The strong trust and love she shows for you—I could go so far as to call it blind faith. Perhaps you are planning to use her for some experiment down the line, or you are trying to save her. I deduced that it must be something of that nature.”

I don’t remember ever telling her anything more than I needed to. I would think she does not know as much about Kei as even Ryuuen does. Despite that, she did well in getting so close to the truth with her conjecture.

“The special lesson you had for me, it is also related, isn’t it?”

“I’m getting somewhat tired of saying this now, but well done. You’re right.”

For different things than with Kei, Sakayanagi and I could understand each other without even speaking.

Ding dong.

The doorbell suddenly rang, its slow and relaxed sound spreading through the room. It was around 12:30, about time for the students to finish their lunch. I got a visitor all of a sudden, even though nobody should have been in the dorm at this time.

Sakayanagi and I looked at each other before turning to the doorway at the same time. There should have been three bodyguards in the lobby. Did this person break through them with force? No, assuming they could use overwhelming force to suppress the bodyguards, they wouldn't stop there. They would enter my room as they pleased, without bothering to do something like calmly ringing a doorbell.

The bell rang once again. It was known that I was resting in my room, so ignoring this any further would be cause for suspicion. While unlikely, it was possible that it was someone from the school.

"Who is it?"

I called out to the visitor, staying on my bed.

"Remain as you are and listen to me."

A boy responded. He must have figured out from my voice that I was sitting at some distance from the door. A young voice. Not of an adult, but of someone of roughly my age.

"I remember your voice."

But I couldn't attach a face to it. The voice should be of a student's, and while I couldn't remember the person, I clearly remembered the voice. Of course, I had also overheard many random voices while living in the school. However, this person's voice quickly clicked with me.

"You've called me once before."

I responded. The person on the other side of the door was quiet for a moment.

“Incredible. You remember my voice after hearing it just once.”

It was after my father had come to visit this school, I remembered clearly.

“Back then, I think you had something to say, but you didn’t.”

“I was happy to get in touch with you, but immediately after that something put me in a bad spot. I couldn’t contact you again… I’m sure you’re interested in it, but who I am is irrelevant right now. That is because to you, I am neither an enemy nor an ally.”

“Then why did you come here?”

“After eliminating Tsukishiro, peace will return if you eliminate the White Room student. I was concerned that you might be laboring under that misapprehension, so I have come to give you advice.”

“Fufu. What an interesting conversation! Do you mind if I join in?”

“Oh, Sakayanagi Arisu.”

Sakayanagi’s response was unexpected, but the boy on the other side of the door didn’t seem surprised. If anything, he immediately figured out who it was from just the voice. He might have looked into who was absent from the Sports Festival, or he could have met her before and remembered her voice.

“Anyway, stay on your guard if you want to enjoy your school life until graduation.”

“You claim to be neutral, but you’ve come to support me.”

“Your existence is a bad influence. I want to prevent anything more from happening, that’s it.”

He answered, his voice growing fainter as he walked away. It didn’t seem like he ever intended to stay for long, and we could assume he had left.

“That voice… I remember it from somewhere…”

“You have some idea of who it could be?”

“Just like yourself, Ayanokouji-kun, I can’t say for sure. But I get the feeling that somewhere, I have heard that voice from behind a door once.”

In short, it was something different from my own memory of his voice.

“It wasn’t recent. Five, maybe ten years ago… At any rate, it was an old memory.”

“If that’s true, then it is close to impossible that he is a white room student.”

“Indeed. If I had met him as a child, then that would be the case.”

That matches with his reaction when he found out Sakayanagi was here. He was not surprised, and further, his reaction conveyed that he was familiar with her.

However, whether it came from Amasawa or this guy, *that* was just the thing I didn’t care about at all. At this point, I had not been harmed at all, so I had no desire to do anything about it.

2

Despite my absence, the Sports Festival ended almost ideally for us. The class was also fired up by the result, the likes of which we could not even have imagined in the year and half until now. The gap between us and Class A had shrunk, and Horikita's class had amassed no small amount of class points via the Uninhabited Island Test, the Unanimous Consent Test and now the Sports Festival.

A few days after that. We had passed the 15th of October.

The rankings in the sports festival were: Horikita's class in first place, Ryuuen's class in second place, Ichinose's class in third place and Sakayanagi's class in fourth place. It goes without saying that this was not due to just one person, but a result of the whole class's will and strength. Further, the Sudou-Onodera pair took first place in each individual ranking.

Kouenji also took first place in ten events, but because they were all individual events he finished second. He seemed satisfied with that and didn't stir up any trouble. And while Sudou and Onodera won the right to change classes, both of them picked private points without hesitation. We had shown some instability, but we were certainly rising up towards Class A.

Kei seemed to have plans with her friends, so I was going to head back from Keyaki mall. As I was about to head back home by myself, Horikita called out to me.

"There's something I wanted to talk to you about. Is that alright?"

"It would be better if we could do it on the way back."

"That's good enough for me."

She had deliberately called out to me just when I was about to head back, so I presume she didn't want others overhearing what we would talk about.

"I have learned a very important lesson from the Unanimous Consent test."

"Let's hear it."

The Sports Festival had ended, but not all of our problems had been resolved yet, and while we were still unstable the class had started to move forward. But Horikita was still agonizing over it, and it seems like she had learned something from it.

"I did not make a mistake. I was able to recognize once again that I chose to keep Kushida-san, and that that choice was correct."

In this situation where we needed results, Kushida had contributed even in the Sports Festival by increasing our points. She had returned to being a model student in her daily school life, and while her Social Contribution score in the OAA had gone down in the beginning of October, it would probably only be a matter of time before she brings it back up. If I had to be merciless in comparing them, she was contributing to the class as a member far more than Airi would. Of course, it wasn't all roses and sunshine.

"I know. There are still reasons for us to be worried. Especially when it comes to Hasebe-san; honestly, I still don't know what I should do about her. But, if we face a similar test once again, I think I will be able to handle it much better next time."

"And why do you think so?"

"During that test, I made a poorly thought out promise so we could achieve unanimity. I said that we would expel the traitor, and I had to go back on my word. It was a good shortcut to achieving unanimity, but I didn't understand how risky it was. Deep down, I knew that Kushida-san was the traitor. And I made that decision before I was even clear on whether I wanted to expel her. That was a mistake."

“If it was possible to keep her, then it is true that making an unnecessary promise was equivalent to tying your own noose.”

It would have been a desperate measure to avoid time running out, but if at that stage she could achieve unanimity while leaving it possible to cut off Airi or someone else who was about as weak as her, then it wouldn’t have caused as many complications as we had now. It’s all about tradeoffs, I suppose.

“We got class points. However, we had to pay dearly for it. That special test has taught me a lot. It showed me both victory and defeat.”

“It’s not certain that you *haven’t* failed, however.”

Horikita had closed her eyes. She exhaled slowly before opening them again.

“I’m just a second year high school student. I’m a child. Isn’t it okay for me to mess up?”

“You’re fighting back now, huh.”

“It’s not like me to waver about it forever. I am—I’m going to keep being as I am. Maybe I’m not as good as the other leaders. But we have Hirata-kun, Karuizawa-san, Sudou-san, Onodera-san, Kushida-san and Kouenji-san. I will move forward with their support. Class A waits for us. That is what I now believe.”

“Oh.”

“Of course, you are one of those people, too. I never know what you’re thinking, and you can be uncooperative, but… you are, both to the class and to me, absolutely essential.”

I am something like the training wheels on a bicycle. Even if they are absolutely essential when starting out, you mess up, you fall over, you waver again and again, and eventually you become able to ride with ease.

It’s not just one person supporting you as you set off on your bicycle. Your classmates truly will support you.

After I’ve seen you grow a bit more——

I will leave your class.

I won’t tell her now, but someday, Horikita, too, will know why.

And then——

She will definitely understand why.

Once you have a class that you trust will always win, you will have to face the reality that you cannot win.

I will teach you that.

Not for anyone else, but for my own sake.

I—If I keep winning, that’s all that matters.

If I decide to face Horikita and defeat her, it will be as good as certain.

But– I wish to be defeated, and that is exactly why I am going to leave.

There is a future where I wish and hope that it will not be certain.

I know the answer, but paradoxically, I hope I am wrong.

Epilogue

“Sorry, I kept you waiting.”

Hasebe called out to Miyake, who was waiting at the entrance, before lightly punching his shoulder.

“No, I wasn’t waiting all that long. I was bored anyway.”

Hasebe had been absent from school for a week, but after that she was coming to school every day.

“Was it alright for you to quit the Archery club?”

“I was only continuing out of inertia, anyway.”

“But you quit because of me, right?”

“No, that’s not true. I quit because I wanted to. But more importantly, I’m happy you’ve started coming to school.”

She only participated in the minimum required five events in the Sports Festival. She didn’t get any results, but at the very least she contributed to the class.

However, she was more or less not speaking to anybody except Miyake, and she was slightly estranged even from Yukimura, since he had agreed to expelling Sakura. Miyake treated it as if it was something he couldn’t do anything about, and continued standing by her without saying anything about it.

“At first, I thought, ‘let’s destroy everything’. Not just Kiyopon, I thought it would be good to take revenge on all our classmates who threw away Airi.

I'm such a terrible person, aren't I?"

"No… I understand what you're feeling."

"At that point, we *had* to expel someone. But that should have been Kushida-san. That was what was promised first, and that would've been correct. Isn't that right?"

"… Yes."

"I won't forgive Kiyopon. I won't forgive our classmates. But, to keep holding them back, to keep tormenting them forever, I thought that was wrong."

She confessed all of her thoughts, and the silent answer that had come through to her, to Miyake.

"Say, Miyacchi. Will you—help me take revenge, just once?"

Her eyes weren't smiling, and Miyaki didn't have the courage to ask her if she was serious.

"Haruka…"

"As if! It's just a joke, it's just a joke!"

She laughed to cover it, and stepped forward.

"I'll take my revenge by myself, after all."

"I—"



Hasebe had reached out, then withdrew her hand. Then she turned around and walked away. Even though he was hesitant, Miyake silently followed her.

AFTERWORD

Maybe it's been a while, or maybe this is our first time meeting. Kinugasa Shougo here.

This time, I have a serious afterword.

All of you have found out by now, haven't you?

After five years, a sequel to the Classroom of the Elite TV Anime will be produced and aired.

When I put it into words, it seems short and trivial, but it really took a lot of work and pain for us to get to this announcement.

I'd almost stopped writing, and not just once or twice.

'Maybe there won't be an anime again.' There were times when that worry took hold of me.

However, the reason I was able to keep writing with more or less no change in my pace of publication was that even after the end of the 2017 anime, many of my readers kept supporting me.

If I hadn't kept up this great track record for so long, I don't believe the anime adaptation could ever have been made again.

As an author, there is nothing that makes me more happy and grateful than the greenlight for the sequel.

I am truly, truly, truly thankful.

And let me make one thing very clear.

More than anyone else, I have always eagerly waited for a Classroom of the Elite Anime Adaptation.

There could be an anime, maybe we can make it? These discussions started to come up roughly two years ago.

Yes! Just as I was getting excited with anticipation, the effects of a worldwide viral pandemic led to a delay.

Anyway, I'm happy that we were able to get the announcement now.

But I will continue to work hard without letting up even for a moment and continue the story of the source material of Classroom of the Elite.

There are so many stories to tell, but that is it for this afterword.

A long time has passed, but if you've wanted to see Ayanokouji and the rest grow, then I hope you are looking forward to it. Can't they just animate everything until the end? Can't they?! Can't they?!!

Anyway, setting that aside… YESSSS!! WE DID IIIIIIIIIIIIIIT!!

And to all of you, thank you very much for your continued support!!!!

Sakayanagi Arisu SS: Complicated Feelings

I was having a good time chatting with Ayanokouji-kun who excused himself from joining the sport festival and was absent.

I always had to be careful about what others until now, and today was the only chance I had where nobody could interfere.

“You were just observing, but even made me come here and visit you. You are not planning on doing anything during the festival either, right? … I see.”

I pieced together all the scattered hints he had been giving me during our conversation.

“In other words—Eh”

Suddenly, he gently grabbed my shoulders and pushed me back.

Usually, this amount of strength was nothing to most people, but since my body was rather weak and I hadn’t expected it, I fell backwards in a daze.

It didn’t hurt of course. I just fell back from where I sat on the bed.

I should have been seeing his face right now, but my eyes were spinning while looking at the ceiling.

Before I managed to sort out the situation, Ayanokouji-kun began mounting me.

He had his hands on both sides of my head leaving me without any way to escape.

“E-excuse me?”

I didn’t look like he had succumbed to his primal desires.

It should have been impossible, but somehow the possibility was within my calculations.

My thoughts were all scrambled and that hindered me from coming to an answer.

“My school life is founded on this plan I have. The fact you would come here today, would show interest in and eventually reach the answer as within possibility.”

As if he were making fun of me, he reached his conclusion against this situation.

“You will be hindrance if you told anyone else about this.”

“You think I… would leak this?”

I wasn’t so naïve that I didn’t understand how much of a bother that could be to him.

I thought we both understood that…

“The chances aren’t zero. You may try to blackmail me by saying you’d expose it unless I agreed to have a match with you. I’d have no other options in that case.”

“I see, that’s certainly true… But, couldn’t I just reveal the truth about the White Room instead?”

His true goal was hidden.

That was definitely true, but I still haven't managed to calm myself enough right now to think about it.

While my mind was working, trying to calm down my thoughts, I continued to talk to him.

"Shall we start the special lesson?"

I saw his eyes as he muttered this and finally understood his goal.

I couldn't help but laugh, close my eyes and wait for the lesson.

If this was his goal, I won't mind.

With these complicated feelings, I acknowledged that I would be used by him.

But, do remember this, Ayanokouji-kun.

If you are going to use me—I'm going to use you until the very end.

Chabashira Sae SS: Something That Can't be Forgiven

It was after homeroom had ended and my conversation with Horikita was soon about to end.

"We're soon out of time. Just let me tell you one last thing, although it may look like I'm meddling too much. The most important thing is what you, Horikita, wants to do with Kushida. Think carefully about this."

The focus was to make Kushida return to class, but this wasn't as important now.

I'm not sure how useful my advice would be to her, but at least I hope it may have cleared her thoughts a bit.

"Thank you, teacher. I've decided what to do now."

"Don't mind it. As your teacher, this is nothing— it's surely something to be expected after all."

After sending her off, I walked back to the staff room.

After going down the steps and into the hallway where the staff room was, I heard someone running from behind.

"Don't run in the hallway…"

"Sa~~~~e-chan. Yah-ho!"

I planned on warning the student, but I knew it was a teacher by instinct.

“Is that you, Chie? How are you going to set an example if even you are running full ahead?”

“Bu~ut, I saw you right ahead!”

“Stop with that Bu~ut! Just call for me like normal.”

There was no need to run up to me this way,

“By the way, you were taking quite a long time talking with Horikita-san.”

“… so you even heard that?”

When in the world did she start?

There was a huge risk of this leaking If Chie heard about Kushida.”

“From when I heard her say thanks to you.”

When it was almost over, in other words.

I can’t exclude the fact it may have been a lie, but it was true I didn’t notice her before either.

“Looks like even the model student Horikita has lots of worries.”

“She’s just a child, right? But that’s not what I wanted to say.”

She smiled as she walked right beside me. Her eyes weren’t laughing.

“Why have you gotten closer to your students now?”

“There’s nothing weird for a homeroom teacher, is it?”

“It is. You are not that kind of a teacher. You have never been until now, have you?”

“That may be true.”

“I won’t acknowledge it. There is no way Sae-chan would ever act like a teacher.”

“… I know.”

I replied, but my reply never reached her.

Amasawa Ichika SS: The Truth is, I've Always

As I entered Senpai's room, I began searching with conviction.

But as expected of him. He had cleaned it all in that short amount of time.

But I that wasn't my true goal. My true goal was to check if this room was being wiretapped or not. It did look too clean for it to not be wiretapped. Had he already made a move, I thought but…

"They should just ignore me and enjoy their school life. I highly recommend it."

To him who was fully enjoying his freedom, I, who was White Room student was just a nuisance.

I know that.

"Yes, I agree as well. I think I should do that too but…"

That's why I want do expose Takuya and let them fight it out ASAP.

If he could observe Ayanokouji-senpai from at close, touch him, feel him, he would understand.

But Senpai wouldn't bite. No emotions at all as he was just waiting for me to leave.

I wanted to upset him so I face my butt in his direction.

From this angle, that and that could be seen and I wondered if that would work.

“Drawn in by my underwear? How pervy.”

I am the one showing him so what the heck am I saying, right?

“Sorry, I’m more worried about what else you may be doing if I take my eyes off you.”

Clever, but uninteresting.

Our conversation would naturally return to just discussing daily topics, so I moved the topic back.

I turned around and got closer to him, but he didn’t even raise an eyebrow.

“I think they may have gone on a rampage by now? I feel like they have gotten their methods and goals all wrong. Instead of returning to the White Room, they are more focused on expelling you.”

“What a bothersome topic.”

It didn’t show on his face, but it was probably true that he thought it was a nuisance.

“That may be true for you, yeah. I have been thinking this for a while, but how about I just reveal them to you and just let you do your thing?”

But didn’t even bother getting to know. His premise was that I was untrustworthy and he didn’t want to listen to unnecessary information from me.

He didn’t answer my proposal as he read his opponents one, two steps ahead.

The truth is, I want to be by his side.

Even if I’m a nuisance, just being close to the person you look up to. But…

There is no guarantee that my school life could go on forever.

Onodera Kayano SS: That's What I Believe In

A hit with unbelievable power brushed against Housen-kun's racket.

His rage was being transformed and brought into the game itself, my ideal form of sportsmanship.

The scattering sweat sparkled like gemstones.

"HELL YEEEAAAAAAAAAAHH!!"

Seeing Sudou yelling from his very core, I couldn't help but frolicking in this victory.

"We did it! We did it!"

Housen-kun, who we had been playing with, looked frustrated and smashed his racket to the ground.

"We won Onodera! All thanks to you!"

Sudou ran towards me, and I raised my hand for a high-five but was met with air instead.

I was embraced with both of his hands around me in a hug.

"W-w-wha,, wha-wha!?"

A happiness followed by a surge of panic.

But I was the only one flustered as Sudou just looked all happy and excited.

He was starting to squeeze harder, so I tried to pull out.

“Wai-, ouch, it hurts Sudou-kun!”

He finally noticed my distress and now he was the only flustered.

“M-my bad!”

We were trailing due to my injury, but turned that into victory, never giving up until the very end.

Our beliefs and tenacity beat Housen-kun’s by a mile.

“Congratulations! You won all your events, Sudou-kun.”

“Yeah, thanks a lot Onodera. If not for you, we’d have lost this match for sure.”

“That’s not true. I was probably a hindrance…”

“Could have been a fluke, but when you got hurt and I just snapped, I thought we’d lose this. But you were the one to call me back.”

His eyes looking straight at me felt like they were sucking my in.

“I see, then we… are a pretty good combo, right?”

“Of course! Easy to work with and rely on. Yeah, you are the best Onodera. Ah, maybe Suzune was watching me from somewhere too?”

His eyes that I felt I could watch for eternity withdrew from me and scanned the area around the gymnasium.

“Suzune…right?”

I muttered. He reacted like a dog at that name and suddenly looked questionably at me.

“Eh? Where? Where is she!?”

“Ah, eh well, sorry, looks like it was another person.”

“Shit. I see, maybe she’s on the field then…”

I hate losing and that lit the fighting spirit within me ablaze.

Yes, I have to admit it.

I’m, interested in Sudou-kun.

I can catch up and show some results, no matter how far ahead he is.

That’s the sportsmanship that I believe in.

“Let’s eat on our way next time after clubs, okay?”

“Eh? Ah, sure I guess. More importantly, help me look for Suzune. Where are you, Suzune.”

“Hahaha, absolutely not.”

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Translator's Notes

Chapter One

1. I'm sure many of you looked at this paragraph and thought something was off. Well, I know it doesn't make sense, but that's what it said in the source. These sentences are very confusing, as the sentence in the middle doesn't fit what comes before or after it. Here's the original of the sentence:

   逆に、診断書さえあれば大きな問題にならない。

   I'm not sure whether this is just me not being able to understand what's being said or a mistake in the source. If I had to guess, I'd say this is supposed to be something like *On the other hand, getting a doctor's note itself wasn't a big deal.* That would fit with the rest of the paragraph fairly well. [↑]